



PERFORMANCE WORK STATEMENT (PWS) DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS

Office of Supply Chain

Inventory Management Modernization

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1.0 BACKGROUND

The Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) is a large and complex civilian agency that provides care and services to Veterans and their families across three lines of business. VHA delivers direct health care through the nation's largest integrated health system, including clinical services, pharmacy operations, prosthetics, and facility logistics. VBA administers federally authorized benefits and services such as disability compensation, pension and fiduciary programs, education benefits, insurance, home loan guaranty, and Veteran Readiness and Employment, each relying on timely purchasing and inventory support for nationwide operations. NCA manages the national cemetery system, providing burial services and memorialization, and sustaining cemetery infrastructure and equipment with reliable supply and asset management. To meet mission needs across these lines of business, VA requires an integrated, modernized inventory and purchasing capability that delivers real-time visibility, standardized controls, and coordinated supply readiness across all organizations and facilities.

These illustrative metrics describe VA's operational scale:

1. 7.5 million unique patients were treated by the VA as of September 30, 2025.
2. 148 million outpatient visits, an increase of 7.98% above 2022 current estimate.
3. 155 million outpatient prescriptions dispensed by VA PBM to an estimated 5.5 million unique Veterans.
4. 160 million mail-order prescriptions dispensed via CMOP, accounting for roughly 80% of all VA outpatient prescriptions, consistent with historical volume trends across seven automated fulfillment centers.
5. 24 million outpatient prescriptions dispensed at VA medical facility pharmacies.
6. 24.5 million prosthetic devices, items, and services delivered by PSAS.
7. Enterprise footprint of >1,300 health care facilities, including 172 VA medical centers and >1,100 outpatient clinics, serving >9.1 million enrolled Veterans.
8. 6.6 million contract actions totaling \$38.3 billion in FY 2025.
9. 6.3 million micro-purchase transactions totaling \$4.0 billion via the Government Purchase Card in FY 2025.

To support this scale today, VA primarily relies on legacy business capabilities provided through IFCAP and the IFCAP GIP sub-package:

1. IFCAP provides enterprise governance for budget alignment, fund control, and purchasing. It delivers budget-aware request and approval control, vendor stewardship and eligibility screening, execution of purchases under policy through purchase orders and purchase cards, use of delivery orders against existing contracts, and receiving and acceptance documentation that ties to financial obligation and payment. IFCAP roles and workflows establish accountability from request initiation through approval and receipt, with audit trails and standardized artifacts such as the electronic 2237 request. These capabilities underpin compliance with mandatory sources, contract terms, and fiscal reporting across facilities.

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2. IFCAP GIP manages expendable inventory across VA facilities. It enforces par-level management and reorder points within a Primary and Secondary inventory structure, supports barcode-driven counts and perpetual transaction history, automates replenishment through repetitive item lists and due-in/due-out tracking, and exposes enterprise reports for stock status, emergency levels, and packaging or source discrepancies. GIP also supports point-of-use cabinet integration and operating room case carts and instrument kits, aligning inventory availability with clinical procedures and patient care.

Although foundational, the current IFCAP/GIP capabilities operate within station-centric, roll-and-scroll VistA environments that constrain enterprise performance. The decentralized systems hinder master data management, enterprise visibility, and process standardization, while tight interdependencies on IFCAP complicate system replacement. Technical sprawl, including ad hoc dashboards, warehouse utilities, and standalone graphical interfaces deployed to supplement legacy systems increase inventory management cost and inconsistency. The architecture lacks uniform, real-time interoperability, is not cloud-native, and does not enforce enterprise master data standards, producing fragmented practices and uneven analytics across facilities. These constraints translate into inconsistent business processes and recurring issues identified by GAO and OIG, including inaccurate inventory records, expired items, and weak facility-level oversight, reinforcing the need for stronger controls and governance. Accordingly, the FY 2026 to 2030 Supply Chain Transformation Plan calls for system modernization, process standardization, improved data stewardship, and secure integration with EHRM and FMBT/iFAMS, which together form the enterprise drivers for modernization.

Inventory Management Modernization (IMM) will replace VA's legacy systems and consolidate disparate functions into a centralized, web-based, cloud-ready enterprise capability for purchasing and inventory management. IMM will unify master data governance, purchasing, receiving, stocking, distribution, and point-of-use support so every facility and program operates from the same authoritative data, the same standardized workflows, and the same real-time picture of supply readiness across VHA, VBA, and NCA.

2.0 APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

In the performance of the tasks associated with this Performance Work Statement, the Contractor shall comply with the following:

1. "Federal Information Security Modernization Act of 2014"
2. Federal Information Processing Standards (FIPS) Publication 140-3, "Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules", March 22, 2019
3. FIPS Pub 199. "Standards for Security Categorization of Federal Information and Information Systems," February 2004
4. FIPS Pub 200, "Minimum Security Requirements for Federal Information and Information Systems," March 2006
5. FIPS Pub 201-3, "Personal Identity Verification of Federal Employees and Contractors," January 2022
6. 10 U.S.C. § 2224, "Defense Information Assurance Program", as amended

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7. 5 U.S.C. § 552a, as amended, “The Privacy Act of 1974”
8. Public Law 109-461 (P.L. 109-461), Veterans Benefits, Health Care, and Information Technology Act of 2006, as amended, Title IX, Information Security Matters
9. 42 U.S.C. § 2000d “Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964”, as amended
10. VA Directive 0710, “Personnel Vetting Program,” September 8, 2025, <https://www.va.gov/vapubs/index.cfm>
11. VA Handbook 0710, “Personnel Vetting Program,” September 8, 2025, <https://www.va.gov/vapubs/index.cfm>
12. VA Directive 6102, “Internet/Intranet Services,” August 5, 2019
13. 36 C.F.R. Part 1194 “Information and Communication Technology Standards and Guidelines,” as amended
14. Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Circular A-130, “Managing Federal Information as a Strategic Resource,” July 28, 2016
15. 32 C.F.R. Part 199, “Civilian Health and Medical Program of the Uniformed Services (CHAMPUS)”, as amended
16. NIST SP 800-66 Rev. 2, “Implementing the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) Security Rule: A Cybersecurity Resource Guide,” February 2024
17. 45 C.F.R Parts 160 and 164, Subparts A and E, the Standards for Privacy of Individually Identifiable Health Information (“Privacy Rule”); and 45 C.F.R. Parts 160 and 164, Subparts A and C, the Security Standard (“Security Rule”); as amended
18. Sections 504 and 508 of the Rehabilitation Act (29 U.S.C. § 794d), as amended
19. Homeland Security Presidential Directive (12) (HSPD-12), August 27, 2004
20. VA Directive 6500, “VA Cybersecurity Program,” February 24, 2021 (see VA NOTICE 24-18, dated September 27, 2024, “Update to VA Directive 6500 Cybersecurity Program”, and VA Notice 25-07, dated 3/18/25, “Amending VA Directive 6500 to incorporate M-24-15”)
21. VA Handbook 6500, “Risk Management Framework for VA Information Systems VA Information Security Program,” February 24, 2021 (see VA Notice 25-01, dated October 15, 2024, “Update to VA Handbook 6500 Risk Management Framework for VA Information Systems VA Information Security Program”, and VA Notice 25-06, dated 3/18/25, “Amending VA Directive 6500 to incorporate M-24-15”, VA Notice 25-16, dated September 15, 2025, “Amending VA Handbook 6500 to Replace Enterprise Mission Assurance Support Services Tool With Office of Information Technology Governance Risk Compliance Tool, and VA Notice 25-17, dated September 22, 2025, “Rescission Of Office Of Information Security (OIS) Deputy Assistant Secretary (DAS) Memorandum – Requirements of Proper Plan of Action and Milestones (POA&M) Completion)
22. VA Handbook 6500.2, “Management of Breaches Involving Sensitive Personal Information (SPI),” June 30, 2023
23. VA Handbook 6500.6, “Contract Security,” March 12, 2010 (see VA Notice 24-12, dated April 22, 2024, “Update to VA Handbook 6500.6, Contract

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- Security, Appendix C VA Information and Information System Security/Privacy Language for Inclusion into Contracts, As Appropriate")
24. VA Handbook 6500.8, "Information System Contingency Planning," March 25, 2025
 25. VA Handbook 6500.10, "Mobile Device Security Policy," February 15, 2018 (see VA NOTICE 25-10, dated June 9, 2025, "Use of Personally Owned Mobile Devices Policy Amendment of Department of Veterans Affairs Handbook 6500.10", and VA Notice 25-15, dated August 22, 2025, "Update to VA Handbook 6500.10 Mobile Device Security Policy")
 26. VA Handbook 6500.11, "VA Firewall Configuration," August 22, 2017
 27. OIT Process Asset Library (PAL), [OIT Process Asset Library](#).
 28. One-VA Technical Reference Model (TRM) (reference at <https://www.va.gov/trm/TRMHomePage.aspx>)
 29. VA Directive 6508, "Implementation of Privacy Threshold Analysis and Privacy Impact Assessment," October 15, 2014
 30. VA Directive 6510, "VA Identity, Credential and Access Management," September 3, 2024
 31. VA Handbook 6510, "VA Identity, Credential and Access Management," September 27, 2024
 32. VA Directive and Handbook 6513, "Secure External Connections," October 12, 2017
 33. VA Directive 6300, "Records and Information Management," September 21, 2018
 34. VA Handbook, 6300.1, "Records Management Procedures," March 24, 2010
 35. NIST SP 800-37 Rev 2, "Risk Management Framework for Information Systems and Organizations: A System Life Cycle Approach for Security and Privacy," December 2018
 36. NIST SP 800-53 Rev. 5, "Security and Privacy Controls for Federal Information Systems and Organizations," September 23, 2020 (includes updates as of 12/10/2020)
 37. VA Directive 0735, "Homeland Security Presidential Directive 12 (HSPD-12) Program," October 26, 2015
 38. VA Handbook 0735, "Homeland Security Presidential Directive 12 (HSPD-12) Program," March 24, 2014
 39. OMB Memorandum 05-24, "Implementation of Homeland Security Presidential Directive (HSPD) 12 – Policy for a Common Identification Standard for Federal Employees and Contractors," August 5, 2005
 40. OMB Memorandum M-19-17, "Enabling Mission Delivery Through Improved Identity, Credential, and Access Management," May 21, 2019
 41. OMB Memorandum, "Guidance for Homeland Security Presidential Directive (HSPD) 12 Implementation," May 23, 2008
 42. Federal Identity, Credential, and Access Management (FICAM) Architecture, June 30, 2023 ([FICAM Architecture \(idmanagement.gov\)](#))
 43. NIST SP 800-116 Rev 1, "Guidelines for the Use of Personal Identity Verification (PIV) Credentials in Facility Access," June 2018

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44. NIST SP 800-63 Rev 4, 800-63A-4, 800-63B-4, 800-63C-4, "Digital Identity Guidelines," August 1, 2025
45. NIST SP 800-157, "Guidelines for Derived PIV Credentials," December 2014
46. VA Memorandum, VAIQ #7100147, "Continued Implementation of Homeland Security Presidential Directive 12 (HSPD-12)," April 29, 2011 (reference <https://www.voa.va.gov/documentlistpublic.aspx?NodeID=514>)
47. IAM Identity Management Business Requirements Guidance document, May 2013, (reference Enterprise Architecture Section, PIV/IAM (reference <https://www.voa.va.gov/documentlistpublic.aspx?NodeID=514>)
48. VA Memorandum "Personal Identity Verification (PIV) Logical Access Policy Clarification," July 17, 2019, <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=4896>
49. Trusted Internet Connections (TIC) 3.0 Core Guidance Documents, <https://www.cisa.gov/publication/tic-30-core-guidance-documents>
50. OMB Memorandum M-19-26, "Update to the Trusted Internet Connections (TIC) Initiative," September 12, 2019
51. OMB Memorandum M-08-23, "Securing the Federal Government's Domain Name System Infrastructure," August 22, 2008
52. Sections 524 and 525 of the Energy Independence and Security Act of 2007, (P.L. 110–140), December 19, 2007
53. Section 104 of the Energy Policy Act of 2005, (P.L. 109–58), August 8, 2005
54. Executive Order 13221, "Energy-Efficient Standby Power Devices," August 2, 2001
55. Executive Order 14148, "Initial Rescissions of Harmful Executive Orders and Actions," dated January 20, 2025
56. VA Directive 0057, "VA Environmental Management Program," October 25, 2022
57. OIS VAIQ #7424808 Memorandum, "Remote Access," January 15, 2014, <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentListPublic.aspx?NodeID=28>
58. Clinger-Cohen Act of 1996, 40 U.S.C. §11101 and §11103
59. "Veteran Focused Integration Process (VIP) Guide 4.0," March 2021, <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=4371>
60. VA Memorandum "Proper Use of Email and Other Messaging Services," January 2, 2018, <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentListPublic.aspx?NodeID=28>
61. "Product Line Management Transformation Playbook" version 3.1, August 2023, <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=4946>
62. NIST SP 500-267B Revision 1, "USGv6 Profile," November 2020
63. OMB Memorandum M-21-07, "Completing the Transition to Internet Protocol Version 6 (IPv6)," November 19, 2020
64. Social Security Number (SSN) Fraud Prevention Act of 2017
65. Section 240 of the Consolidated Appropriations Act (CAA) 2018, March 23, 2018
66. C.F.R Title 15 Part 7, "Securing the Information and Communications Technology and Services (ICTS) Supply Chain", as amended

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67. Executive Order 14028, "Executive Order on Improving the Nation's Cybersecurity," May 12, 2021, <https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefing-room/presidential-actions/2025/01/16/executive-order-on-strengthening-and-promoting-innovation-in-the-nations-cybersecurity/>
68. OMB Memorandum M-22-09, "Moving the U.S. Government Toward Zero Trust Cybersecurity Principles", January 26, 2022, <https://www.whitehouse.gov/wp-content/uploads/2022/01/M-22-09.pdf>.
69. NIST SP 800-52 Revision 2, "Guidelines for the Selection, Configuration, and Use of Transport Layer Security (TLS) Implementations"
70. OMB M-26-05, "Adopting a Risk-based Approach to Software and Hardware Security," January 23, 2026
71. OMB M-21-31, "Improving the Federal Government's Investigative and Remediation Capabilities Related to Cybersecurity Incidents," August 27, 2021
72. NIST SP 800-88 Revision 1 "Guidelines for Media Sanitization," December 2014
73. CISA Binding Operational Directive (BOD) 19-02: "Vulnerability Remediation Requirements of Internet-Accessible Systems," April 29, 2019, [BOD 19-02: Vulnerability Remediation Requirements for Internet-Accessible Systems | CISA](#)
74. CISA BOD 22-01: "Reducing the Significant Risk of Known Exploited Vulnerabilities," November 3, 2021, [BOD 22-01: Reducing the Significant Risk of Known Exploited Vulnerabilities | CISA](#)
75. CISA BOD 23-01: Improving Asset Visibility and Vulnerability Detection on Federal Networks." Cybersecurity & Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA), [BOD 23-01: Improving Asset Visibility and Vulnerability Detection on Federal Networks | CISA](#)
76. VA Directive 6550, Pre-Procurement Assessment and Implementation of Medical Devices/Systems, June 03, 2019
77. VA Memorandum, "VA Security Controls," January 17, 2025, <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=5010>
78. E.O. 13960, "Promoting the Use of Trustworthy Artificial Intelligence in the Federal Government," December 3, 2020
79. E.O. 14319, "Preventing Woke AI in the Federal Government," July 23, 2025
80. OMB Memorandum [M-25-21](#), "Accelerating Federal Use of AI through Innovation, Governance, and Public Trust," April 3, 2025
81. OMB Memorandum [M-25-22](#), "Driving Efficient Acquisition of Artificial Intelligence in Government," April 3, 2025
82. OMB Memorandum M-26-04, "Increasing Public Trust in Artificial Intelligence (AI) Through Unbiased AI Principles," December 11, 2025
83. VA Enterprise Cloud Technical Reference Guide, Version 2.0, November 10, 2022

Additionally, the Government notes that familiarity with the following documents will be essential to the Contractor's success. These documents can be found by utilizing the links for each report:

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- Government Accountability Office (GAO) Reports
 - GAO-18-34 – “Veterans Affairs Contracting – Improvements in Buying Medical and Surgical Supplies Could Yield Cost Savings and Efficiency”, Report to Chairman, Committee on Veterans’ Affairs, US House of Representatives, dated November 2017.
(<https://www.gao.gov/assets/gao-18-34.pdf>)
 - GAO-18-658 – “Pharmacy Inventory Management Could Benefit from System-Wide Oversight”, Report to the Subcommittee on Oversight and Investigations, Committee on Veteran’s Affairs, US House of Representatives, dated September 2018.
(<https://www.gao.gov/assets/d18658.pdf>)
 - GAO-20-487 – “VA Acquisition Management – Actions Needed to Improve Management of Medical-Surgical Prime Vendor Program and Information Future Decisions”, Report to Congressional Requestors, dated September 2020. (<https://www.gao.gov/assets/gao-20-487.pdf>)
 - GAO-21-105304 – “Veterans Affairs – Systems Modernization, Cybersecurity, and IT Management Issues Need to Be Addressed,” Testimony Before the Subcommittee on Technology Modernization, Committee on Veterans’ Affairs, US House of Representatives, Statement of Carol C. Harris, Director, Information Technology and Cybersecurity, dated July 1, 2021. (<https://www.gao.gov/assets/gao-21-105304.pdf>)
 - GAO-22-105483 – “VA Acquisition Management – Fundamental Challenges Could Hinder Supply Chain Modernization Efforts If Not Addressed”, Testimony Before the Subcommittee on Oversight and Investigations and Subcommittee on Technology Modernization, Committee on Veterans’ Affairs, US House of Representatives, Statement of Shelby S. Oakley, Director, Contracting and National Security Acquisitions, dated November 18, 2021. (<https://www.gao.gov/assets/gao-22-105483.pdf>)
- VA Office of Inspector General (OIG) Reports
 - VAOIG-17-03718-240 – “Inadequate Oversight of the Medical/Surgical Prime Vendor Program’s Order Fulfillment and Performance Reporting for Eastern Area Medical Centers”, VA OIG Office of Audits and Evaluations, dated December 17, 2019. (<https://www.vaoig.gov/sites/default/files/reports/2019-12/VAOIG-17-03718-240.pdf>)
 - VAOIG-19-06147-50 – “Inadequate Oversight of the Medical/Surgical Prime Vendor Program’s Distribution Fee Invoicing”, VA OIG Office of Audits and Evaluations, dated March 4, 2021
(<https://www.vaoig.gov/sites/default/files/reports/2021-03/VAOIG-19-06147-50.pdf>)
- Assessment J (Supplies), prepared by McKinsey and Company, Inc., dated September 1, 2015. Assessment J report was conducted based on the Veterans Choice Act (Title II, Section 201) requires an independent review of how VA and VHA acquire and manage pharmaceuticals, medical and surgical supplies, and

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medical devices, including related distribution and inventory services. Medical equipment is excluded.

<https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=4970>

- Commission on Care, Final Report, dated June 30, 2016. The Commission on Care The Commission on Care, created under Section 202 of the Veterans Access, Choice, and Accountability Act of 2014, was tasked with examining veterans' access to VA health care and evaluating how the Veterans Health Administration should be organized, resourced, and positioned to deliver care effectively over the next 20 years. (<https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=4971>)

3.0 SCOPE OF WORK

This PWS defines the overarching requirements for the IMM solution. The Contractor shall provide a comprehensive, end-to-end solution that includes, but is not limited to, system integration, business process re-engineering, organizational change management, and training necessary to successfully deploy, integrate, adopt, and sustain the solution. The Contractor shall deliver a total Inventory Management modernization and transformation capability that encompasses all identified functional areas and the full spectrum of Inventory Management solution requirements. Task orders issued under this contract may include the acquisition of software and IT products when such products are necessary to fulfill the required solution. These services and related IT products may span the entire system life cycle, from initial development through long-term sustainment. Services and deliverables provided under this contract shall be global in scope. The Contractor shall be prepared to deliver support and required products worldwide.

This PWS establishes general requirements, specific technical, functional, and performance requirements will be detailed within individual task orders. Functional area requirements are described in Section 5.0 and are not mutually exclusive. While some task order requirements may fall within a single functional area, many will span multiple areas to support the delivery of a full life cycle Inventory Management solution.

The VA requires a comprehensive modernization and transformation program that is supported by a Contractor serving as a transformation partner. The Contractor shall provide services that enable the VA to achieve the program's objectives through an integrated approach, rather than solely delivering or deploying technology products. The modernization and transformation effort consists of three primary components, as outlined below:

(1) People:

The enterprise IMM effort will establish centralized accountability, training, and talent management, which when coupled with centralized systems and processes, is expected to have a positive compounding effect that improves operational efficiency and effectiveness. This involves implementing a robust Supply Chain management and training capability that utilizes a comprehensive organizational and individual change management process

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with supporting training enablers to ensure that end users are fully capable of executing their functions.

(2) Process:

The enterprise IMM initiative will standardize business processes and transactions to promote operational efficiency and scalability, improving process maturity, management, and governance while minimizing or eliminating the use of non-standard or manual processes. This includes strengthening compliance by enhancing VA's ability to meet federal regulations, improving automated controls, and mitigating long-standing audit deficiencies while avoiding any stop-gap compliance measures which do not address longer-term strategy, process compatibility, and benchmarking. A key aspect of process improvement will also involve addressing any organizational or structural deficiencies which bring undue challenges related to oversight, collaboration, efficiency, accountability, and program management.

(3) Technology:

The solution will incorporate the following principles and/or capabilities:

- a) The Contractor shall rapidly deliver an easy-to-use, integrated, and intelligent enterprise Inventory Management and Order Management solution that enables swift user adoption across all VA environments. The Contractor shall develop and provide a deployment roadmap for Government approval that addresses all aspects of implementation—including people, process, and technology—and supports effective customer adoption and timely rollout of the proposed solution.
- b) The Contractor shall optimize current and future inventory management capabilities to ensure rapid deployment of the proposed solution without disruption to ongoing operations. The Contractor shall integrate existing systems that are not slated for replacement and support the phased retirement of legacy systems in a manner that enables rapid, orderly, and non-disruptive modernization. The Contractor shall lead the user community through all required transition activities to maintain a fully functional operational environment. In addition, the Contractor shall provide VA with a comprehensive modernization, integration, migration, and system-replacement plan for Government review and approval.
- c) The Contractor shall adhere to all applicable VA policies, including Scaled Agile Framework (SAFe) best practices and all Office of Information and Technology (OIT) security policies, to ensure compliant, secure, and standardized delivery of the solution.
- d) VA requires delivery of an enterprise supply chain solution using Scaled Agile and High-Reliability Organization tenets utilizing an incremental plan that provides capabilities enterprise wide while avoiding “big bang” system implementation. The Contractor shall develop a deployment roadmap (part of the overall roadmap), for government approval, capturing the details of

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the capability deployments, to include explaining how sites with previously deployed capabilities will be updated to reflect new capabilities added in following waves. The Government envisions an initial task order to develop a more detailed plan, followed by another task order to create a pilot. After the completion of each task order, the Government reserves the right not to issue further task orders.

4.0 PERFORMANCE DETAILS

The Contractor shall provide and/or acquire the services, hardware, and software required by individual task orders pursuant to the general requirements specified below.

4.1 CONTRACT/ORDER TYPE

This is an Indefinite Delivery Indefinite Quantity (IDIQ) type contract. Orders may be issued on a Firm Fixed Price, Time and Material and/or Labor-Hour basis. In accordance with Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) Part 12.207(d) task orders may use award fee and performance or delivery incentives when the award fee or incentive is based solely on factors other than cost.

4.2 ORDERING PERIOD

The total ordering period is not to exceed 10 years and consists of a 5-year base period and a 5-year option period.

4.3 HOURS OF WORK

Hours of work shall be in accordance with individual task order requirements.

There are 11 Federal holidays set by law (USC Title 5 Section 6103) that VA follows:

Under current definitions, five are set by date:

New Year's Day	January 1
Juneteenth	June 19
Independence Day	July 4
Veterans Day	November 11
Christmas Day	December 25

If any of the above falls on a Saturday, then Friday shall be observed as a holiday. Similarly, if one falls on a Sunday, then Monday shall be observed as a holiday.

The other six are set by a day of the week and month:

Martin Luther King's Birthday	Third Monday in January
Washington's Birthday	Third Monday in February
Memorial Day	Last Monday in May
Labor Day	First Monday in September
Columbus Day	Second Monday in October

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Thanksgiving

Fourth Thursday in November

4.4 PLACE OF PERFORMANCE

The place of performance shall be identified in individual task orders. Locations in the Enterprise will be Government or non-Government sites within the continental United States (CONUS) and/or outside the continental United States (OCONUS). Locations may include but are not limited to Federal, State, or VA, data centers, facilities, regional offices, benefits delivery centers, medical treatment facilities, health clinics and community care facilities as defined in individual task orders.

4.5 TRAVEL

Travel shall be in accordance with individual task order requirements. All travel shall be in accordance with the Federal Travel Regulations.

5.0 INVENTORY MANAGEMENT MODERNIZATION FUNCTIONAL AREAS

VA recognizes that the needs of its various supply chain user communities share more commonalities than differences. Therefore, the Contractor shall provide a unified “single pane of glass” view of supply chain system capabilities, offering a common entry point and presentation layer for all VA users. User access shall be role-based and configurable to tailor system options, menus, reports, and approval authorities for specific user groups or individuals. The Contractor’s solution and engagement approach shall prioritize consistent and standardized process flows across all VA purchasing and inventory management functions. Core activities—such as ordering, receiving, managing, tracking, and delivering expendable and some non-expendable material—shall follow uniform workflows to ensure efficient and seamless integration with VA’s Financial Management System to improve operating budget management. VA’s desired end state is a modernized, Department-wide inventory management and ordering environment.

Individual task orders may encompass more than one task area listed below. Further task details are described to provide greater insight into the complexity and uniqueness of some potential task order requirements covered by this PWS. Task area requirements are not mutually exclusive and may apply across multiple functional areas and multiple task orders. Efforts to be performed by the Contractor under this contract are of such a nature that they may create a potential organizational conflict of interest as contemplated by Subpart 9.5 of the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR). Contractor personnel may be required to sign a non-disclosure agreement

5.1 PROJECT MANAGEMENT

5.1.1 CONTRACTOR PROJECT MANAGEMENT PLAN

The Contractor shall deliver a Contractor Project Management Plan (CPMP) to include a Communication Plan, Training Plan, and Change Management Plan that is congruent with existing IMM documentation (where applicable and specified in a Task Order) for each awarded Task Order that defines the Contractor’s approach, timeline and tools to be used in execution of the Task Order. The CPMP should take the form of both a

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narrative and graphic format that displays the schedule, milestones, risks and resource support. The CPMP shall also include how the Contractor shall coordinate and execute planned, routine, and ad hoc data collection reporting requests as identified within the SOO. The initial baseline CPMP shall be accepted by the Government and the Contractor shall update and maintain the approved CPMP throughout the Task Order period of performance.

5.1.2 SCHEDULE MANAGEMENT

The Contractor shall create, maintain, analyze, and report schedules in a manner that is fully consistent with Scaled Agile Framework (SAFe) delivery while also meeting programmatic requirements for an Integrated Master Schedule (IMS). The Contractor shall produce an IMS for the IMM program that provides enterprise level visibility into major milestones, Program Increment (PI) boundaries, deployment waves, product roadmaps, dependencies, risks, and other elements necessary for Government oversight. The IMS shall be updated regularly and shall reflect the best available information at the time of update.

The Contractor shall ensure that the IMS is structured to align with Agile planning practices. The IMS is not required to provide fixed dates for Agile backlog items or user stories and shall not conflict with the iterative nature of SAFe delivery. Instead, the IMS shall capture time-phased activities at the feature, epic, capability, release, PI, or deployment level, along with all external dependencies, critical path items, integration points, and Government-directed milestones. The IMS shall serve as a coordination and transparency tool rather than a prescriptive task-level.

For each Task Order, the Contractor shall develop and maintain a Task Order schedule consistent with this approach. The Contractor shall also develop and maintain a Task Order oriented Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) that supports traceability of work to outcomes. The WBS shall be linked to the IMS and shall be organized to reflect value delivery, decomposition of epics and capabilities, and integration points with other VA systems and program teams.

5.1.3 RISK MANAGEMENT

The Contractor shall conduct risk management for each task order awarded. The Contractor shall provide input to the product Risk Management registry within the VA approved toolset maintained by VA and report risk tracked by task order in the Monthly Progress Report.

The Contractor shall:

1. Comply with and/or establish the Risk Management Plan (RMP) where one is not already established by VA. If already established, the contractor shall conduct a gap analysis and provide recommended updates to the RMP.
2. Use the VA-provided approved tool to create/update and actively manage a project and security risk register (also referred to as risk log) that identifies knowable circumstances that may have a negative impact on project success and describes the potential impacts and asserts measures to either

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reduce/eliminate their impact. Critical risks determined by the VA PM shall also be documented in the VA PARS Dashboard and/or other OIT-approved tools. Risk items shall also include security risk data from security scans and outstanding plan of action and milestones (POA&M).

3. Use the VA-approved boards and tools to facilitate risk meetings and reviews.
4. Collaborate with project team(s) to actively manage, size (level of effort), develop approved mitigations and plans of action and milestones and assess/re-assess probability and severity of project risks and issues throughout the project lifecycle.
5. Continuously update risk for all task order activities in the VA approved toolset (currently Jira and eMASS) and risk register and link risk to their appropriate activities.
6. Participate in monthly cloud security continuous monitoring meetings for cloud applications that fall within your suite of capabilities.

5.1.4 DOCUMENT MANAGEMENT

The Contractor shall:

1. Use a VA-approved tool and repository for all documents and electronic artifacts and apply version control to each deliverable. If assigned tools are deprecated, the Contractor shall assist the VA Tools Team in migrating documents and electronic artifacts to the new tool.
2. Ensure that all artifacts are versioned correctly according to VA standards and follow a versioning approach which identifies all major, minor, and update changes to the components.
3. Based on VA requirements, and the unique needs or nature of each TO, the Contractor shall determine the components within each product that must be under configuration control. The Contractor shall deliver a List of Configuration Items for each TO, including but not limited to configuration identification, configuration control, and configuration audit.
4. Ensure that all Document update cycles are captured in the IMS and are reviewed within their appropriate timelines and updated, if necessary, with proper version control with the review noted in the Revision History of the document.

5.1.5 SOLUTION MANAGEMENT SUPPORT

The Contractor shall comply with the VA DevSecOps process and supporting SAFe practices. To complete this task, the Contractor shall follow SAFe Ceremonies to ensure alignment and collaboration with relevant stakeholders and partners. Additionally, the Contractor shall organize, in coordination with the government, Program Increment (PI) Planning across interdependent legacy systems, as required, to mitigate technical risk and improve rapid delivery of business value. As part of each TO, the Contractor shall provide expertise to help manage the following processes:

1. Consolidate requirements or sequencing to generate efficiencies.

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2. Assist in defining process, governance, and solution implementation requirements, to include the generation of Epics, Features and User Stories while mitigating dependencies.
3. Collaborate with other Program Offices to gain an understanding of how future state requirements for a successful implementation of changes to the VA supply chain impacts legacy process or dependent systems.
4. Provide guidance/recommendations on handling dependencies between supply chain implementation requirements to reduce risk as new process, governance, or capabilities are delivered and legacy systems are retired.
5. The Contractor shall create operational and development Value Stream documentation for the Supply Chain Solution. The Operational and Development Value Streams will be used to ensure proper team structure and prioritization of capabilities using Weighted Shortest Job First (WSJF).
6. The Contractor shall organize and conduct meetings to produce products to support the Solution, Program Increment, and Team level. Epic, feature, and story backlogs shall be maintained, and relevant planning meetings executed. The Government will set priority and approve the backlogs.

5.1.6 ONBOARDING/INPROCESSING

The Contractor shall manage the onboarding of its staff to VA. Onboarding includes steps to obtain a VA PIV card, network and email account, complete training, initiate background investigations, and gain physical and logical access to VA. In addition, the Contractor shall identify individuals who may require elevated privileges to the necessary development and test environments for the various systems to be enhanced. After review between the Contractor and VA COR, a decision will be made as to the necessity of obtaining GFE for the onboarding staff. If approved, the Contractor shall follow the appropriate steps to obtain the equipment.

A single Contractor Onboarding point of contact (POC) for each task order shall be designated by the Contractor that tracks the onboarding status of all Contractor personnel. The Contractor Onboarding POC shall be responsible to submit all required onboarding paperwork, required TMS certificates 48 hours from start date provided to the VA COR and identified Government representative. The Contractor shall be responsible for tracking the status of all its staff's onboarding activities to include the names of all personnel engaged on the task, their initial training date for VA Privacy and Information Security training, and their next required training date. The Contractor Onboarding POC and the Contractor task order PM shall communicate any issues with in-processing/onboarding of an incoming contractor and shall follow-up with the identified Government representative as required. The Contractor Onboarding POC shall also report the status of the staff level during onboarding status meetings. The Contractor shall provide an Onboarding Status Report weekly for any staff with outstanding onboarding requests for review by the identified Government representative.

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5.1.7 VA MANDATORY TRAINING

The Contractor and identified Government representative shall determine which team members require access to the VA network and VA approved toolset. All Contractors that require access shall complete all the required VA Talent Management System (TMS) training courses within 14 days of the identification of the access need. The Contractor shall work with its respective point of contact, to obtain access to TMS to complete the mandatory training courses.

As an action under the Continuous Readiness in Information Security Program (CRISP), VA's Assistant Secretary for Information and Technology issued a memorandum requiring all VA government and contract staff to complete information security awareness and applicable role-based training. The Contractor shall submit TMS Training Certificates of completion for VA Privacy and Information Security Awareness, Rules of Behavior, Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act, and Role-Based trainings. The Contractor shall provide signed copies of the Contractor Rules of Behavior IAW Section 9, Training, from Appendix C of the VA Handbook 6500.6, "Contract Security".

The Contractor shall complete the appropriate VA TMS role-based training courses for all contractors with required access to Elevated Privileges:

- TMS ID 3197: Information Security Role-Based Training for IT Specialist (WBT)
- TMS ID 3867205: Training for Elevated Privileges for System Access (WBT)
- TMS ID 3867207: Information Security Role-Based Training for System Owners (WBT)
- TMS ID 1016925: Information Security Role-Based Training for Software Developers (WBT)
- TMS ID 1357076: Information_Security_Role-Based_Training_for_System_Administrators (WBT)
- TMS ID 1357084: Information Security Role-Based Training for Data Managers (WBT)
- TMS ID 1357083: Information Security Role-Based Training for Network Administrators (WBT)
- TMS ID 64899: Information Security Role-Based Training for IT Project Managers (WBT)

The Contractor shall complete the following Agile training courses, and other emerging Product Line Management and SAFe courses as required by the identified Government representative:

- TMS ID 4533235: Product and Product Line Management: Creating and Managing the Product Back Log
- TMS ID 4533231: Product and Product Line Management: Overview of Product Line Management
- TMS ID 4551891: Introduction to Agile
- TMS ID 4551982: Product Owner

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The Contractor shall complete emerging training requirements for GitHub, Jira, or other VA approved tools as appropriate or required. Contractors who have completed these VA training courses within the past 12 or 24 months, depending on the training requirements, and have furnished training certificates to VA, will not be required to re-take the training courses.

5.1.8 TRANSITION SUPPORT

The Contractor shall recognize that the services under this contract are vital to the Government and must be continued without interruption, and that upon contract expiration a successor, either the Government or another contractor may continue them. The Contractor shall provide phase in training and exercise its best efforts and cooperation to affect an orderly and efficient transition to a successor.

The Contractor shall develop a Transition Plan supporting outgoing transition support. Upon VA PM's approval of the Transition Plan, the Contractor shall commence transition out activities working with the incoming Contractor or Government entity. Additionally, the Contractor shall provide formal coordination with Government staff and successor staff and management. The Transition Plan shall specify a training program and a date for transferring responsibilities for each division of work described in the plan. The Contractor shall provide sufficient experienced personnel during the phase-in, phase-out period to ensure that the services called for by this contract are maintained at the required level of proficiency. The Transition Plan shall include, but is not limited to:

- a. Coordination with Government representatives
- b. Review, evaluation and transition of current support services
- c. Transition of historic data and IMM data in a structured format conforming to current storage and access technologies to VA or to a new Contractor system
- d. Transition of all accounts
- e. Disposition of Contractor purchased Government owned assets,
- f. Transfer of Government Furnished Equipment (GFE) and Government Furnished Information, and GFE inventory management assistance
- g. Turn-in of all Government keys, ID/access cards, and security codes

5.2 DATA MANAGEMENT

Current efforts in Data Management include standardizing and normalizing inventory and supply chain data using Data Governance tools, and support of Data Stewardship program. Initial efforts are positive with inclusion of several sites and Veterans Integrated Services Network (VISN) leadership. Additionally, inclusion of technical and relational definitions of supply chain attributes are included in the VA Enterprise Data Catalog.

VA envisions a future supply chain solution which supports and enables data discovery and evaluation of data quality. This includes a supply chain solution that supports a comprehensive, coherent, and complete inventory of every source data set that is used by the supply chain, and, importantly, from a governance perspective, the registration of that data in a VA Enterprise Data Catalog. Not to be confused with supply catalogs, the

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VA Enterprise Data Catalog shall register metadata sources and metadata standards, as well as the lineage and provenance of data elements and attributes. In this manner, supply chain data shall be nested in VA's data ecosystem. The supply chain data will be trusted and confidently leveraged to support VA operations, decisions, and capacity and capability planning and analysis. Moreover, the supply chain solution will support VA leaders and employees at all levels in making appropriate data-driven policies and decisions to improve VA's services and improve their value to all Veterans.

Consistent with the principle of "curate once, reuse many times," the inventory management system shall minimize data duplication and maximize data reuse, using standardized data structures compliant with Federal and VA requirements and industry identifiers such as GTIN, GLN, NDC, and UPC. Where standards do not exist, the Contractor shall propose new ones aligned with the Federal Integrated Business Framework (FIBF). The system shall provide automated, auditable end-to-end data traceability and support a fully linked, transportable supply chain through VA enterprise item identifiers. It shall also incorporate modern capabilities including full GS1/EPCIS compliance, real-time data lineage, AI-enabled data quality management, API-based interoperability with VA systems, scalable cloud architecture, tamper-evident logging for high-risk items, emergency readiness and stockpile visibility, support for automated identification technologies (RFID, BLE, barcoding), and integrated quality and recall management.

The scale and complexity of VA's supply chain require adoption of modern data management and analytics capabilities, including emerging technologies such as graph modeling, to support cost analysis, source selection, and item-level procurement decisions that improve efficiency and Veteran outcomes. The system shall include an advanced supply chain data management capability able to identify endogenous dependencies (e.g., increased clinical activity driving higher glove usage) and exogenous interdependencies (e.g., pandemics or disasters increasing demand for beds, masks, and critical supplies). The solution must automatically model and surface internal and external connections, including upstream and downstream dependencies, across the Veterans Health Information Systems and Technology Architecture (VistA) and all other VA supply chain systems. It shall also enable real-time visualization of these relationships to support operational planning, risk mitigation, and proactive decision-making.

The solution shall provide integrated, enterprise-wide data visibility and access, enabling real-time transactional information to be consumed across all organizational levels and supporting strategic goals through accurate, actionable analytics. The system must support patient-level serial number tracking for full traceability and clinical accountability. Upon request, the Contractor shall repatriate any required data to VA-designated repositories.

The Contractor shall develop a comprehensive Data Governance Plan. The plan shall include proposed data architecture, metadata, taxonomies, ontologies, data catalogs, business glossaries, data dictionaries,

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VA data must be normalized across sites, and VA retains perpetual data governance and ownership of all VA data standardized by the contractor.

The Contractor shall provide a VA Data Repatriation Plan to support migration of data, data standardization business logic rules and supporting code to VA designated repositories or systems at any point during period of performance. The plan shall include long-term storage, archiving, and purging capabilities and standards aligned to all Federal and VA policy.

The system must support an abstraction layer enabling controlled access to PII/PHI where functionally required.

5.3 STANDARDIZED BUSINESS PROCESSES AND ENTERPRISE INTEGRATION

The Contractor shall define and implement standardized business processes in conjunction with deployment of the Inventory Management solution. The solution shall support VA's enterprise supply chain expendable inventory management functions and be measured by operational Key Performance Parameters (see Mission Needs Statement in the Readers Room). The solution shall integrate acquisition and financial data in support of Electronic Health Record Modernization (EHRM) and Financial Management Business Transformation (FMBT), with the end-state of improving visibility and accountability across the VA enterprise.

5.4 TECHNOLOGY MODERNIZATION, INTEROPERABILITY, AND HOSTING

The Contractor shall provide an Inventory Management solution that is interoperable, compatible, and capable of integration with current and potential future products. The Contractor shall provide and coordinate delivery of required hardware, software, and ancillary equipment (e.g., end-user tools and interfaces) and coordinate with OIT to host on the VA Enterprise Cloud (VAEC) or VA IT infrastructure where Software as a Service (SaaS) is proposed. Upgrades deemed necessary by the COR shall be implemented to ensure consistent use and appropriate monitoring across the enterprise.

5.5 INTEGRATED PLANNING AND PROGRAM MANAGEMENT

The Contractor shall provide deployment plans, product roadmaps (including sunset strategies), concepts of operations (CONOPS), and an integrated master schedule (IMS) to fully implement objectives and recommended Service Level performance standards. Product roadmaps shall be incorporated into the overarching program roadmap. The Contractor shall plan and collaborate seamlessly with multiple contracted teams, including OIT's integration team, to ensure cohesive delivery for the Government customer.

5.6 DEMAND PLANNING ALIGNMENT

The Contractor shall share standardized, well-developed demand data with internal partners (VBA, NCA, VHA, VACO, and OIT) and external suppliers to ensure capacity aligns with demand. Sample performance metrics include Forecast Accuracy, Forecast

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Bias, Mean Absolute Percent Error (MAPE), Weighted Absolute Percent Error, Mean Percent Error, Root Mean Squared Error (RMSE), and rolling out-of-sample errors.

5.7 CUSTOMER-CENTRIC SUPPLY CHAIN OPTIMIZATION

The Contractor shall optimize integrated supply chain inventory management based on the service needs of each customer area. Performance considerations include product and volume complexity, pricing, product life cycle, quality expectations, innovative product adoption, and cycle counts and shrinkage in Perpetual Inventory Management environments. All stakeholders shall have access to an intuitive, intelligent, and integrated expendable inventory management solution that supports individual user needs and enables VA to fulfill its mission of caring for Veterans. Sample performance metrics include Perfect Order Index, supply chain cycle time, fill rate, obsolete inventory, inventory turnover, product complexity (number of variants), and volume complexity (high-volume/low-mix or low-volume/high-mix).

5.8 PRODUCT STANDARDIZATION AND DIFFERENTIATION

The Contractor shall balance product standardization (to minimize unnecessary variance) with customer-driven differentiation within established VA standards. Sample performance metrics include unplanned delays/downtime, stock-outs of mission-critical items, freight costs, and stakeholder dissatisfaction.

5.9 CATEGORY MANAGEMENT

The Contractor shall leverage category management capabilities and streamline acquisition procedures to support aggressive modernization objectives, strengthen supply chain resilience, and promote a robust vendor base, including small businesses. The Contractor shall identify how processes and technologies will help VA meet Category Management goals outlined in OMB M-19-13 and OMB M-22-03, including enhanced acquisition data analysis and sharing, improved demand management, and effective vendor management. Sample performance metrics include Purchase Order Cycle Time, number of electronically processed POs, average cost to process a PO, Total Cost of Ownership, cost avoidance, approved supplier locations, and lifecycle transparency.

5.10 REAL-TIME PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND INDUSTRY-ALIGNED METRICS

Metrics shall be aligned with industry standards. The Contractor shall provide timely and predictive data enabling supply chain participants to proactively meet customer needs, manage risk, and comply with public policy. The Contractor shall deliver an enterprise real-time performance management capability that defines, monitors, and reports metrics across the enterprise and within each functional area to support proactive decision-making. Sample metrics include Inventory Turnover, Inventory Accuracy, Order Fill Rate, Perfect Order Rate, On-Time Shipping, Back Orders, Order Cycle Time, Inventory Days on Hand, Rate of Return, and Order Picking Accuracy.

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5.11 ANALYTICS AND MULTI-LEVEL DECISION SUPPORT

The Contractor shall leverage business intelligence and predictive analytics to support processes, policies, and strategies across the VA enterprise. Sample metrics include Demand Prediction, "Production" Scheduling, Predictive Maintenance, Inventory Optimization, Predictive Fleet Routing, Cost Optimization, and risk management metrics.

5.12 CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

The Contractor shall operate a continuous improvement program at the enterprise level and within each defined Core Functional Area (see Section 5.11), using data-driven methods to optimize performance over time.

5.13 ORGANIZATIONAL CHANGE MANAGEMENT (OCM) AND TRAINING

The Contractor shall deliver an organizational change management program that supports enterprise-wide modernization and user adoption from initial implementation through the full lifecycle of the contract. The Contractor shall follow the Prosci® ADKAR methodology. The Contractor shall provide comprehensive training, an operational readiness checklist, and an executive dashboard to verify site readiness for physical transition to the new IT solution and to confirm that the inventory management system is fully prepared to execute all required functions. The checklist shall confirm system functionality, role-based user readiness, data migration validation, system interoperability, cybersecurity compliance, performance against defined acceptance criteria, and continuity of operations; and verify successful completion of end-to-end testing, user training, help desk preparedness, activation of monitoring and sustainment processes, and legacy system user account deprovisioning post-deployment. The checklist shall confirm system functionality, role-based user readiness, data migration validation, system interoperability, cybersecurity compliance, performance against defined acceptance criteria, and continuity of operations. It shall also verify successful completion of end-to-end testing, user training, help desk preparedness, and activation of monitoring and sustainment processes.

5.14 INVENTORY MANAGEMENT

The modern real-time inventory management solution shall ensure that the right items are available at the right place and time across all VA supply chain Core Functional Areas, supported by integrated business processes and enabling technologies. The system shall create, edit, cancel, display, adjust, and receipt delivery orders; automate budget, billing, payment and reconciliation activities with VA's IFAMS Finance Management System; and support full end-to-end ordering and receipt workflows. It shall enable item research and procurement through Blanket Purchase Agreements (BPA), consignments, and local or national contracts, comparing options based on user-defined criteria such as price and delivery. The solution shall store product locations to include tracking at arrival to the facility warehouse through inventory points, to the point of consumable use, and to the patient where applicable (such as prosthetic items and services, and implants). The system shall allow for re-issue from warehouse to warehouse (one facility to another) and allow for multiple warehouse locations for a given facility. It must be able to track and re-sell items from national warehouses to

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facility warehouses receiving supplies. It must track demand, forecast material requirements, monitor on hand balances, generate material release orders, determine reorder points, and supply analytics and reporting to optimize inventory practices.

The system shall be fully interoperable with VA's electronic health record (currently VistA and Oracle Health), financial and accounting systems (currently FMS and iFAMS), and other supply chain platforms to ensure consistency in funding and cost data. It shall also provide real-time, enterprise-wide inventory visibility, advanced automation, and integration across all relevant operational environments.

The solution shall be capable of:

1. Providing real time automated dashboards with actionable insights, including enterprise-wide visibility into inventory, orders, assets, and supply chain expendable inventory management risks to support rapid operational decisions.
2. Providing and coordinating delivery of required hardware, IT infrastructure, and ancillary equipment (such as handheld devices and barcode printers) needed to ensure consistent use of the supply chain solution across the enterprise. To the maximum extent possible, the solution provider shall leverage existing end-user hardware laptops and mobile devices when it meets current VA standards. The solution software shall be fully interoperable with existing Point of Use Systems (PAR Excellence weight-based system and TrackCore at a minimum, as well as Integrated Financial and Acquisition Management System (iFAMS) and Oracle Health EHR.
3. Providing automatic updates from multiple sources of industry recall information. The system shall monitor all items VA purchases or purchased and assess recalls against that set of data. Recall information that matches VA past or present inventory shall trigger alerts and prescribed action to process and handle the recall. The system shall alert and initiate tasking for users to remove stock in distributed areas and automatically sequester material on hand preventing further distribution. Lastly, the solution shall be interoperable with VA systems such as TrackCore, Wavemark, and Oracle Health to initiate recalls of implantable medical devices.
 - Capturing location, quantity, cost, shelf-life data, demand/consumption, status (on-order, in-transit, receipt/inspect/sort/storage), and disposal.
 - Providing canned and ad hoc reports that can be pulled within the solution to determine if inventory practices are optimal and to provide information to make inventory decisions.
 - Tracking quality control data on like items located in several locations to support contingency operations.
 - Allowing access to inventory, by central office, to pull reports on contingency material to support all hazard events and to enable the cross leveling of material.
 - Allowing the inclusion of peripherals to support more effective and efficient receiving, accountability and distribution of material to support clinical operations.

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- Allowing visibility of material, in the secondary inventory points, through real time interaction with point of use systems, providing material availability at contracted sources of supply. Allowing catalog ingestion into the solution to ensure the correct source of supply is being procured from to ensure procurement guidance is being adhered to. The solution shall be flexible and efficient to ensure the capability to rapidly support contingency operations (e.g. pandemics and/or disasters, etc.).

Including specific inventory management and logistics operations subcategories such as:

- Medical Devices (MD)/Medical Device Systems (MDS) and supplies, including:
 - MD/MDS and clinical systems
 - Medical/Surgical equipment and supplies serial numbers
 - Prosthetics and Implants
 - Pharmaceuticals
- Mail Room
- Patient Safety Recalls (Quality Assurance (QA)/Quality Control (QC))
- Procurement, storage, distribution, and disposal of:
 - Hazardous Material (to include ammunition)
 - Medical Gasses (including oxygen)
 - Medical materials
 - Biohazardous material waste
 - Contingency material
 - Non-medical/non-IT
 - Regulated medical waste
 - NCA materials and supplies
 - VBA materials and supplies
- Emergency Management
 - Patient Safety Recalls (Quality Assurance (QA)/Quality Control (QC))

5.14.1 MEDICAL SURGICAL SUPPLIES

Any solution would provide the capability to manage Medical Surgical consumables, material by sets, items in multiple locations, quality control data (Lot Number and expiration dates).

The solution shall:

1. Improve supply chain performance and patient safety across all VA Medical Centers through reliable, accurate, and timely product availability.
2. Provide a single, standardized enterprise supply chain management approach that minimizes variation and supports consistent operations across all VA facilities.
3. Enhance demand forecasting using Artificial Intelligence/Machine Learning (AI/ML) driven predictive analytics and integrate strategic sourcing capabilities to optimize purchasing and reduce waste.

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4. Strengthen materiel catalog management by unifying item data, enforcing common standards, and improving data quality and consistency across the enterprise.
5. Establish standardized replenishment processes that support higher-frequency, lower-batch restocking cycles without increasing material handling costs.
6. Create a unified, standardized enterprise database for inventory (e.g., inpatient disposable goods managed by Logistics, outpatient by Pharmacy), with the ability to cross-reference items, support substitution, and allow Logistics to supply non-durable and IV products when required.
7. Implement a standardized supply formulary to reduce product variation and streamline product identification across the enterprise.
8. Enable potential reductions in on-hand inventory through improved supply chain visibility, forward-deployed inventory management, and automated replenishment within clinical areas.
9. Standardize and extend recall tracking and remediation beyond warehouse areas by establishing full visibility into supplies located in clinics, EDs, wards, ORs, and other point-of-care locations.
10. Shift oversight of supply chain management from clinical personnel to trained logisticians, freeing clinical staff to focus on patient care.
11. Leverage modern digital and adaptive technologies that integrate seamlessly with VA systems (e.g., POU, VistA Prosthetics, IBM Maximo, ROES, AEMS/MERS, iFAMS, EHR systems) and incorporate Veteran data when needed to support reverse logistics, returns, and end-to-end disposition management.
12. Capture and manage quality control data to support recall closure, product audits, and end-to-end traceability.

5.14.2 TRACKING SYSTEMS, SCANNERS, AND PERIPHERALS

The solution shall:

1. Support real-time inventory tracking through RFID, Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE), barcoding, Ultra-Wideband (UWB), NFC, passive/active RFID hybrids, computer-vision tracking systems, IoT-enabled smart shelves and cabinets, automated dispensing point of use cabinets, and edge-device telemetry for item-level location, condition monitoring, and chain-of-custody verification.
2. Integrate modern technologies such as handheld scanners (1D/2D barcode, RFID-enabled), smart carts, mobile workstations (WOW), industrial tablets, wearable scanners (ring scanners, wrist-mounted devices), optical character recognition (OCR) devices, and future integration with technology such as AR-enabled smart-glasses for hands-free picking and tracking.
3. Support integration with robotics and automation systems such as autonomous mobile robots (AMR), automated guided vehicles (AGV), robotic picking systems, automated storage and retrieval systems (AS/RS), and vertical lift modules (VLM).

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4. Enable plug-and-play compatibility with smart refrigerators, temperature-monitoring sensors, cold-chain IoT devices, environmental monitors, and digital lockboxes for controlled substances.
5. Provide support for predictive maintenance sensors on equipment and vehicles used in logistics operations.

5.14.3 Advanced management and analytics features

The solution shall:

1. Enable mobile, hands-free, and point-of-care supply documentation via handhelds, tablets, voice-enabled systems, or wearable devices.
2. Provide end-to-end supply chain transparency using a modern “Control Tower” approach with predictive analytics for disruptions, shortages, and expirations.
3. Enable automated workflow routing, exception management, and alerting for supply shortages, expirations, recalls, temperature excursions, and order variances.
4. Support GS1 standards (GTIN, GLN, UDI) for full traceability of medical devices and supplies.
5. Include robust cybersecurity, zero-trust architecture compatibility, and compliance with VA, federal, and healthcare security requirements.
6. Deliver a cloud-native or hybrid-cloud architecture enabling scalability, rapid updates, and high availability.
7. Provide full audit trails, versioning, and compliance logs for regulatory requirements and quality management processes.
8. Support role-based access, personalization, and task-oriented user interfaces to improve efficiency across Logistics, Pharmacy/ Pharmacy Biopreparedness, Prosthetics, Nursing, and other stakeholders.
9. Offer AI-enabled decision support that recommends substitutions, predicts demand shifts, optimizes supply distribution, and monitors real-time risk factors.
10. Provide configurable analytics dashboards to support real-time monitoring, performance management, and continuous improvement.

5.14.4 PHARMACEUTICAL/BIOREADINESS

The system shall provide a comprehensive, enterprise-level pharmacy inventory and procurement solution that integrates all existing VA pharmaceutical logistics capabilities while closing current gaps, including the absence of perpetual inventory management and enterprise-wide visibility across all pharmacy locations. It shall maintain an accurate perpetual inventory across all sub-locations, including inpatient, outpatient, ward stock, narcotic vaults, research areas, and emergency cache environments, while supporting mobile counting, cycle counts, annual inventories, par-level recommendations, and real-time reconciliation. The system shall operate independently of the EHR while integrating seamlessly with Consolidated Mail Outpatient Pharmacy (CMOP), Purchase Price Variance (PPV), Enterprise Payment System (EPS), Bar Code Medication Administration (BCMA), Electronic Product Code Information Services (EPCIS)

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providers, IFAMS, automated dispensing technologies, and other VA pharmacy applications. It shall support Drug Supply Chain Security Act (DSCSA) compliance by scanning and validating EPCIS data, storing required trace data for at least six years, retrieving DSCSA information within 24 hours, and normalizing data using Global Trade Item Number (GTIN), National Drug Code (NDC), and Universal Product Code (UPC) identifiers. It shall adjudicate recalls, isolate suspect products, document regulatory actions, and automatically receive safety alerts for pharmaceuticals and biologics. The system shall extract and report key clinical and supply chain metrics, auto-update drug databases, incorporate community pharmacy fulfillment data, provide enterprise reporting, and deliver analytics for utilization, shrinkage, and stock optimization.

The system shall enable a full suite of procurement and financial management capabilities, including automated PPV ordering based on prior-day utilization, dynamic demand signaling, early shortage detection, PPV fill-rate monitoring, and PPV sales reporting to PBM. It shall support EDI and manual purchasing, NAC and BPA contracts, open-market and specialty orders, direct-to-patient shipments, Fast Pay reconciliation, invoice matching, ATP vendor verification, and retention of procurement and financial data for required regulatory periods. The system shall ensure complete governance of controlled substances through CSOS/DEA-222 support, vault and biennial inventories, chain-of-custody documentation, destruction workflows, research accountability, witness verification, and tracking of prescription pads and destruction logs. It shall also maintain bio readiness by supporting All-Hazard Emergency Cache management, including activation workflows, FDA-based expiration updates, annual emergency-readiness inventories, and tracking of controlled-substance tote seal tags and inspection updates. Across all functions, the system shall guarantee compliance, auditability, temperature-tracking where required, continuity of care, and the ability to produce all documentation needed for VA oversight bodies and external regulators such as DEA, FDA, Joint Commission, GAO, and OIG.

5.14.5 PROSTHETICS AND DURABLE MEDICAL EQUIPMENT (DME)

The system shall support modern, industry-standard inventory management tailored to VHA Prosthetics and Sensory Aid Service (PSAS), ensuring full transparency from procurement through issuance and enabling automated tracking, point-of-care scanning, recall management, and patient-safety actions. It shall operate as an enterprise-wide, highly automated supply chain platform with a centrally governed, clinically validated catalog and seamless integration with the EHR, PSAS Formulary, and other VA systems. Ordering Providers shall be able to view, select, customize, and order PSAS items within their normal workflow, including items outside the catalog when clinically justified. The system shall ensure orders are complete and actionable, provide clinical decision support, consolidate communication, display real-time order status, and support uploads of required documentation. It shall maintain accurate inventory by posting and decrementing stock in real time, enabling point-of-care scanning, notifying when patient-specific items arrive, allowing migration of unused items, tracking pack quantities, and granting limited vendor access for local inventory management. The system shall also manage the Automotive Adaptive Equipment (AAE) benefit nationally to prevent duplicate issuance.

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The system shall provide robust operational, financial, and program-management functionality for PSAS, including enterprise-wide transaction history (2319), rentable-item tracking, repair vs. replace analysis, preventive maintenance, centralized correspondence, consult routing, address verification, and comprehensive work queues for RFQs, POs, and follow-ups. It shall support shipping/tracking uploads, patient-expiration alerts, vendor contract alignment, appeals processing, installation and delivery status visibility, service-dog and HISA eligibility workflows, HISA benefit calculations, and a longitudinal PSAS record. The system shall offer full reporting and analytics capabilities, including cost tracking, productivity metrics, recall research, program evaluation, fabrication cost analysis, and appeals compliance. It shall automate purchase-request generation, bundled purchasing, home oxygen workflows, purchase-card reconciliation, vendor-invoice processing, workload capture, 3rd-party billing, and integrated implant procurement and tracking. Patient-facing functions shall include portal visibility, decision-letter access, and self-service supply reordering, while staff-facing functions shall support prior-order review, provider notifications, beneficiary travel coordination, and complete order tracking across the PSAS lifecycle.

5.14.6 BENEFITS SUPPLIES

VBA requires a modern, data-driven inventory management solution that provides full lifecycle management for durable goods, including tracking delivery, warranty, maintenance history, and service-life milestones. The system shall use end-of-life analytics to forecast future needs proactively and optimize replacement planning. It must integrate seamlessly across VA's enterprise systems while operating independently when needed, support scalable automation, and interoperate with modern supply chain platforms. The solution shall embed continuous process-improvement capabilities, including automated monitoring, workflow optimization, and integrated risk-management tools that assess vulnerabilities, track mitigation activities, and adapt to emerging operational requirements.

5.14.7 BURIAL SUPPLIES

NCA envisions a solution for an easy to use, automated, and intelligent system which links ordering with VA inventory management and financial systems to capture supplier risk which not only anticipates supplier issues but begins the process of recommending replacement suppliers or new solutions based on AI.

5.14.8 SUPPLY CHAIN INVENTORY RISK MANAGEMENT

The Contractor shall provide a solution that integrates with existing VA risk management platforms to share real-time information on supply chain disruptions, product shortages, and other risk indicators, supporting proactive mitigation and continuity of supply chain operations. The Contractor shall implement a comprehensive supply chain expendable inventory management risk management program that evaluates and mitigates risk across all Core Functional Areas (see section 5.11). The program shall incorporate modern control tower concepts for end-to-end situational awareness and predictive risk alerts. The Contractor shall deliver a Supply Chain Control Tower to account for demand planning and supply chain risk assessment.

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5.15 INVENTORY ORDER MANAGEMENT

The real-time e-commerce order management solution leveraging VA contracts, other Federal organizations, and commercial partners, as well as associated supporting business processes and technologies shall ensure the right goods and services are delivered to the right place at the right time across all supply chain Core Functional Areas. This provides a front-end user experience consistent with, and integrated, with the VA Financial Management Business Transformation (FMBT) iFAMS. This includes a continuous procurement optimization strategy that incorporates category management and strategic sourcing initiatives throughout the life of the contract. The solution must enable VA users to carry out small business program requirements, including market research to consider set asides where mandated by VA's Veterans First Contracting Program law, contracting fast pay agreements, and resulting small business performance requirements. Optimally, users will be able to comply with these requirements internally, with limited need to resort to external systems for supplemental guidance or functionality. Additionally, the solution shall provide the ability to track freight audit and payment services. The system shall have the ability to track receipt and process payment for medication shipped directly to the Veteran through a specialty pharmacy or a direct to patient shipment program.

The Contractor shall deliver an AI/ML-enabled procurement management capability that analyzes buying patterns and recommends cost savings opportunities, sourcing strategies, and performance improvements across enterprise, regional, and local levels.

5.16 WAREHOUSE MANAGEMENT SYSTEM (WMS)

The solution shall include a WMS which includes, but is not limited to:

1. A means to support warehouse organization(s) with input to improve inventory storage and make best use of available warehouse space and reduce waste.
2. Optimized warehouse processes and daily scheduling of current inventory and staff available to support all warehouse operations to include scheduling, shipping and receiving times and location.
3. Managing and tracking inventory, to include within the facility, by obtaining movement information from all devices and warehouse equipment including when items are received, stored, picked, packed, and shipped while adjusting levels of inventory in real-time.
4. Addressing order fulfillment to include shipping needed inventory to VA facilities.
5. Monitoring and reporting on warehouse operations to ensure proper procedures are followed and identify problems with warehouse performance to help support process improvement and track progress.
6. The ability to bidirectionally interoperate with 3PL (third party logistics) software applications used by VA transportation vendors to track delivery from point of origin to its destination to include Veteran's private residence/domiciles (e.g. home address, caretaker's residence, nursing home).
7. The ability to interoperate with software applications utilized by outside distributors/service providers/installers of various goods/services across VA (e.g.

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beds, IT provisioning), to include vendor managed inventory. This shall include the tracking of inventory throughout its lifecycle of use by VA and/or a Veteran.

5.17 SUPPLY CHAIN FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT

The system must provide supply chain staff with an integrated, end-to-end capability to manage all financial, procurement, vendor, purchasing, receiving, reconciliation, and purchase-card activities efficiently and accurately. It shall allow staff to create, edit, approve, track, amend, cancel, and archive purchase requests; manage due-ins; view real-time inventory; resolve PR/PO/invoice/receipt discrepancies; and maintain complete documentation throughout the procurement lifecycle. The solution must support the VA accounting structure and process interoperability with other VA finance systems. Supply chain users must be able to view unobligated balances, align appropriations and LOAs, adjust BOCs, process fund transfers, obligate funds according to authority, and monitor updated financial balances as transactions occur. The system shall support full order lifecycle management—including status checks, amendments, full/partial/overage receipt processing, reversals, vendor returns, dispute resolution, and accurate 3-Way Match—while also enabling vendor validation via SAM/CCRC, enrichment of vendor profiles, Prime Vendor procurement, financial reporting, and direct access to financial data. It must fully support purchase-card operations such as order creation, editing, approval, reconciliation, dispute notation, receipt matching, card registration/status updates, multi-LOA payments, and automated LOA decrementing, along with processing matched and unmatched invoices, IPAC transactions, and invoice posting to ensure complete and accurate reconciliation for all supply chain activities.

5.18 TECHNOLOGY & ARCHITECTURE (PLATFORM/CLOUD/INTEGRATION)

If the contractor recommends a SaaS offering, it shall already have, or shall achieve, FedRAMP Authorization at a level (Low, Moderate, High) commensurate to the security and privacy level of information processed, stored, and exchanged, by the proposed segment of the solution. While VA prefers a solution composed of applications where FedRAMP Authorization already exists, the contractor will be responsible to ensure all artifacts are submitted for necessary approvals should they be necessary.

The Contractor shall:

1. Evaluate and propose optimization of technologies and business processes required to achieve performance standards, emphasizing configuration over custom development to ensure sustainability and modernization alignment.
2. Provide a continuous, modular approach to system enhancement that ensures the solution remains evergreen throughout the life of the program. The system shall support ongoing upgrades, integration of emerging capabilities, and seamless updates without disrupting operations, enabling it to evolve as technology and mission needs change. Provide a solution that is cloud based in accordance with the definition above.
3. Ensure the proposed solution(s) is/are accessible via VA provided desktop, laptop and, mobile technologies.

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4. Provide a sustainment function for all supply chain systems delivered under this contract, including integrated product support aligned with the VA help desk, to ensure ongoing maintenance, security, and operational performance throughout the period of performance.

5.19 USER RESEARCH

As part of user research, the Contractor shall:

1. Facilitate discovery activities, to include generative research with users and business stakeholders, an assessment of current related features, a content review, an information architecture review, an accessibility review, a business process review; and collection of any available data and analytics and provide in a User Research Checklist. The following Checklist provides additional details on these requirements: (<https://department-of-veterans-affairs.github.io/va-digital-service-handbook/delivery/research-and-discovery/checklist>)
2. Partner with other VA Product Teams to ensure that the process governance or new product fits into the existing structure.
3. Conduct formative and contextual user research studies to understand users' goals, needs, journeys, and pain points with respect to process and product development. Apply insights from user research studies to define minimum viable product functionality, including epics and user stories, as well as operational, business, functional, technical, data, and integration requirements.
4. As part of the overall product test strategy, conduct routine, iterative usability testing to continually improve the user experience and to inform content, information architecture, design, functionality, and accessibility. Iteratively apply insights gathered to inform design and development.
5. Before releasing to production, conduct user acceptance testing on new features, content reviews of existing content, Information Architecture reviews for global navigation and design reviews of existing patterns and User Interface elements to identify and make modifications while maintaining a positive user experience.

5.20 PRODUCT LIFECYCLE ACTIVITIES

The Contractor shall support Human Centered Design (HCD) activities for IMM throughout its lifecycle by engaging in the following activities:

1. Conduct technical discovery activities on existing supply chain products as well as internal and external business process flows and functions. Work closely with VA customers to understand their needs and how those needs map to VA capabilities. Collect available data, user feedback, and VA stakeholder feedback and capture in a Product Discovery Report. This shall include an analysis of how proposed solutions or changes will affect the existing functionality and operation of existing VA systems/applications.
2. Maintaining a Product Plan/Roadmap that includes comprehensive list of supply chain product functionality that needs to be built or updated and prioritization of these based on discovery that has happened, as well as product Key Performance Indicators (KPI). These product's KPIs shall be established in

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concert with the identified Government representative and key stakeholders. All KPIs shall be designed to allow the team to effectively and objectively evaluate the product against user needs throughout the life of the product.

3. Provide Subject Matter Experts (SME) to participate in and/or facilitate VA stakeholder meetings, some of which may be in-person at VA facilities, to plan building and integrating the services and change management activities. This support will include managing agendas, taking meeting minutes, tracking and following up on action items, and use of collaboration tools during these meetings.
4. Demonstrate proposed supply chain product to receive feedback from potential consumers and iterate on designs quickly prior to beginning software development/application integration.

5.21 SOLUTION ARCHITECTURE PLANNING

The Contractor shall use VA enterprise architecture (EA) and enterprise security architecture (ESA) reference models and architectures where feasible to create a Solution Architecture Package that includes the initial business, systems, application, and data architectures for the new features and capabilities using an architecture framework, approved by the PM/COR. These documents shall be updated for each TO utilizing VA approved templates and GitHub Enterprise or other VA approved tool when appropriate and shall include a Changes Page which specifies the updates made to the document for review and approval by all active TO identified Government representative. The Contractor shall also outline any initial gaps, questions or challenges that may hinder progress in future TOs.

5.22 MONITORING REQUIREMENTS FOR VA SYSTEMS

The purpose of monitoring is to collect and analyze data from the applications in the VA IT infrastructure and to leverage that data to improve business results and drive value creation for customers. VA implements specialized software tools that aggregate data by monitoring VA applications to achieve this purpose. All new applications (COTS or developed) are required to ensure sufficient telemetry within their system to allow data collection at the business logic, application, and environment layers. A full Authority to Operate (ATO) will not be granted by VA with insufficient monitoring.

5.23 APPLICATION PERFORMANCE MONITORING AND ALERTING

As part of hosting IMM systems, the Contractor shall utilize Application Performance Monitoring (APM) strategies for application health and performance. System monitoring shall cover all aspects of system availability and interfaces so that system administrators are alerted and take preventive action prior to any service interruption. The Contractor shall provide an Application Monitoring Plan that defines how the system shall be monitored throughout the performance of the requirements, including the automated testing tools and automated Service Level Agreement (SLA) testing scripts that shall be used. The Contractor shall provide the Application Monitoring Plan to the VA Task Manager for review and approval. Upon approval, the Contractor shall implement application monitoring in accordance with the approved plan and establish

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an Application Dashboard that provides real time performance metrics to all program stakeholders.

The Contractor APM processes shall:

1. Inform the enterprise of the performance of the application in accordance with customer expectations.
2. Ensure that software components are instrumented to support a VA approved performance monitoring standard (e.g., Splunk)
3. Produce and maintain documentation describing data flow through the application, focusing on how and when the application passes/accepts data to/from other systems or end users.
4. Ensure that all workflows and actions identified during the human centered design process are distinctly mapped/measured in the monitoring environment.
5. Monitor system, network, application, database logs, and performance metrics via VA approved VAEC/Cloud Service Provider (CSP) monitoring tools and ensure that code and logic changes are accurately reflected in the monitoring tools.
6. Work with the VA to instrument all significant data paths; or instrument all significant data paths themselves using VA approved monitoring tools.
7. Utilize monitoring plugins and agents to monitor numerical metrics provided by external services, servers, or equipment to collect more in-depth metrics.
8. Proactively monitor application performance and availability metrics, services for errors, faults, anomalies, slowdowns, and other disruptive conditions over time and be able to conduct predictive analysis and be capable of determining baselines based on self-learning application communication intelligence and machine learning to understand what "normal" behavior means for each system.
9. Monitor any application language, report, and log all application performance metrics, availability metrics, and communication trends, be capable of accessing product diagnostic (i.e., agent logs) log files without accessing physical host, provide log file aggregation, log file analytics capabilities, and store log files associated with monitored processes.
10. Monitor End-to-End application flows that indicate issues within the environment, including where they originated from and leading indicators (a situation is occurring that if it remains unaddressed will lead to a full or partial outage)
11. Document and report number of system calls, Average Response Time, and number of errors (plus error types).
12. Use analytics to provide further intelligence into how the entire process is impacted.
13. Identify potential errors at the code level for integration into a continuous improvement/continuous development reporting approach.
14. Integrate with web automation and testing tools to allow synthetic testing of real user experiences while providing metrics for monitoring and reporting.
15. Monitor mobile applications based in a mobile environment, support "webhook" capabilities built into the management console, monitor web-based and non-web-based applications for an entire round-trip including browser rendering (all browsers active within VA), must support application programming interface (API)

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integration between products to extract data from and/or publish data using an API.

16. Support integration with web automation and testing tools to allow synthetic testing of real user experiences while providing metrics for monitoring and reporting.
17. Monitor and show CPU host and process usage as well as memory host and process level usage.
18. Track and report on the quality of the end user experience within the application.
19. Work with the VA to establish performance thresholds for the application and integrate those into the monitoring tools.
20. Establish robust and reliable alerting and escalation paths for performance violations (e.g., automated email, text, calls); to notify parties directly responsible for the application as well as the VA monitoring tools immediately.
21. Write and monitor synthetic monitoring scripts for VA infrastructure and applications.
22. Perform postmortems of any outages occurred, including root cause analysis and steps to prevent future outages and provide Postmortem Reports accordingly.

5.24 NETWORK AND OPERATING SYSTEM PERFORMANCE MONITORING

As part of hosting IMM systems, the Contractor shall utilize Network and Operating System Performance Monitoring (NOSPM) strategies for tracking network and operating system health and performance. The NOSPM shall cover all aspects of operations and availability so that system administrators are alerted and take preventive action prior to any service interruption. The Contractor shall provide an NOSPM Plan that defines how metrics shall be monitored throughout the performance of the requirements, including the automated testing tools and automated Service Level Agreement (SLA) testing scripts that shall be used. The Contractor shall provide the NOSPM Plan to the VA Task Manager for review and approval. Upon approval, the Contractor shall implement monitoring in accordance with the approved plan and establish a Dashboard that provides real time performance metrics to all program stakeholders.

The Contractor Network and Operating System Performance Monitoring processes shall:

1. Interface with the VA's Network Performance monitoring solution managed by the VA approved VAEC/CSP. The dashboard will display real-time monitored data from the existing solution.
2. Support/supplement current VA solutions to enable high availability collection of network data from all network data end points.
3. Ensure VA Facilities real time data feeds are ingested into the Dashboard that will provide the performance and availability metrics of current bandwidth utilization for the facility view.
4. Provide end-to-end network visibility, achieved by continually learning from the network devices and the clients attached to the network
5. Provide actionable insights to proactively identify and respond to events.
6. Provide guided remediation actions for events.

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7. Increase network visibility and faster time to resolution by visualizing real-time application traffic flow within a matter of seconds.
8. Proactively troubleshoot capabilities to identify the root cause of issues, ahead of time and with more granular details and assist with network issues that have occurred in the past.
9. Provide historical playback of network data to assist data recovery for downstream systems and to deliver continuous insights on network performance to reduce troubleshooting and improve a user's experience.
10. Quickly identify the location and nature of performance issues and respond immediately.
11. Provide end-to-end flow visualization, correlation of multiple data sets to provide views, graphs, and maps to illustrate the current state of applications and network performance.
12. Provide real-time network topology maps that enable the VA network operations teams to view top application traffic, performance, and bandwidth, and report on pre- and post-environments for initiative status.
13. Provide real-time capture of line-rate raw flow data combined with filtering and data analysis to establish a system and network performance baseline.
14. Monitor application turnup: Real-time visualization of end-to-end flows quickly identifies performance metrics and highlights routing loops for quick diagnosis and correction. Path change alerts facilitate configuration adjustments.
15. Configure alarms and alerting to notify engineers of degraded performance or failure so the teams can address issues before users are impacted and report them.
16. Track Performance Improvements and Return on Investments (ROI): Compare pre-migration baseline measurements to post-migration measurements to quantify improvements and ROI.
17. Provide network layer monitoring of the system that uses router and switch features (e.g., Cisco Network Based Application Recognition (NBAR) and telemetry available in NetFlow) in addition to SNMP reads and traps to provide a deeper application and flow understanding of the system.
18. Speed troubleshooting, increase service levels, and reduce downtime with network monitoring of existing VA network infrastructure
19. Measure the health of the logical network in addition to the physical network
20. Simplify the management of complex network devices by monitoring the right information for each device's unique role in the network
21. Define and lean the critical network path hop-by-hop analysis for on-prem, hybrid, and cloud services.
22. Cross-stack network data correlation for acceleration of problem identification
23. Improve operational efficiency with out-of-the-box dashboards, alerts, and reports
24. Provide traffic analysis dashboard, cross-stack network data correlation, network traffic forensics, Class-Based Quality of Service (CBQos) performance views, Port 0 Monitoring, and Autonomous System Traffic Analysis.

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5.25 TRAINING

The Contractor shall provide training for their solutions. A Training Plan will be delivered to the identified Government representative prior to executing the training. The training plan shall be integrated with the overall schedule and roadmaps developed and maintained using the Agile methodology. Following VA approval of the Training Plan, the Contractor shall execute the Training Plan and develop the Training Materials. The Training Plan and Training Materials shall outline the training purpose and provide the knowledge and skills necessary to achieve the full scope of the purpose. The training will incorporate instruction on why the training is being conducted.

5.26 TESTING

The Contractor shall establish a comprehensive Agile quality control and assurance program that gives VA the ability to make informed decisions about the readiness of a product or interface to go into production based on its ability to meet the functional and technical requirements. The quality control and assurance program shall cover unit, build, integration, risk-based, security, system, performance, usability, user acceptance, and field testing for all systems components and interfaces included in the solution. The Contractor shall adopt Agile best practices for integration of quality control and assurance into each Agile iteration and build to allow for continuous delivery. The Contractor shall automate testing wherever possible to improve product quality and efficiently utilize testing experts time iteration to iteration.

Under the quality control and assurance program, the Contractor shall:

1. Provide testing artifacts, reports, and metrics compliant with VA IT governance for all work done in fulfillment of VA requirements.
2. Produce/update a Master Test Plan (MTP) for each release of the system, components, and/or interfaces. The Master Test Plan (MTP) shall outline, at a minimum, the test strategy, test environments, test process, and scope of the effort.
3. Coordinate with internal and external teams to identify and/or create test data sufficient to adequately demonstrate components and interfaces operate as intended under production like conditions.
4. Provide and maintain development, testing, pre-release, and release environments that allow for end-to-end testing of the fully integrated system.
5. Prepare test procedures, design tests cases, conduct tests, observe tests, provide technical support, coordinate test plans in accordance with appropriate regulations, and analyze, evaluate, and document test results.
6. Enter test data in the VA approved tool (currently Jira), on a daily basis, following the templates and data requirements appropriate for each test purpose appropriate to each phase of development and/or configuration.

The Contractor shall utilize VA's implementation of Jira, GitHub or other VA approved toolset to provide a robust DevOps toolchain that allows other non-contractor VA resources to easily collaborate on joint work products. Before each test event, The Contractor shall conduct test readiness reviews (TRR) and coordinate with stakeholders to ensure readiness of all test participants. At the conclusion of each test event, the

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Contractor shall provide a Requirements Traceability Matrix (RTM) data set within the VA approved tool (currently Jira) to provide visibility of test coverage and mapping to test executions.

5.27 IT HELP DESK SUPPORT

The VA Enterprise Service Desk (ESD) provides Tier 1 Desk Support 24/7/365. The Contractor must provide Tier 2 and 3 Help Desk support of the Supply Chain Systems provided by the Contractor. Tiers 2 and 3 support for existing VA interfaces will be provided by the Office of Information and Technology.

Tier 1 support is defined as answering a customer's call, identifying the problem, creating a ticket in the VA support tool, resolving end user incidents per documented knowledge articles and escalating to the next level of support by routing the ticket to the appropriate support team or group per documented knowledge-based articles. Tier 2 support is defined as intermediate level troubleshooting and analysis to resolve system access, system usage, and procedural issues. This includes resolution of repetitive incidents, documenting, reporting and the resolution of each. Tier 3 support is defined as expert level support from the Contractor Team to resolve programmatic issues. The project requires a daily review of calls and tickets received so that all tickets created by Tier 1 are resolved or assigned to a Tier 2 or Tier 3 group within 24 hours of creation.

The Contractor must provide reports of all Help Desk activity. Help desk metrics are defined as, at a minimum, the number of tickets received, open tickets, closed tickets, aging information and average time for ticket closure, interactions per ticket, first response speed, resolution speed, average response time, customer satisfaction, and resolution feedback mechanism between the help desk and the customer. The Contractor must aid VA in capturing and analyzing Help Desk data.

In order to facilitate VA visibility into help desk tickets and to be able to report accurate ticket response times, the Contractor must provide seamless synchronization with the VA Information Technology Services Management (ITSM) tool (currently ServiceNow) to support Tier 2 and Tier 3 help desk tickets. In addition, the contractor must accept warm ticket handoffs if tickets are worked in a non-VA ticketing system. The Contractor must also work with the Enterprise Service Desk (ESD) intake, Office of Information and Technology (OIT), Healthcare Environment and Logistics Management (HELM) Portfolio, IMM to identify all ServiceNow workflows that will support Tier 1-Tier 3. The Contractor must assist in building the knowledge base documents that support Tier 1 in identifying the appropriate steps to triage and route service tickets. The Contractor must support IMM in identifying workflows and a knowledge base for Tier 1 – Tier 2 support that will ensure users who are encountering issues “that are not technical in nature” can get their issues resolved by routing them to the appropriate Subject Matter Experts (SMEs) who can re-train in process or system usage support.

Response times for Tier Support and Incident Priority

All support tickets are assessed for impact and urgency upon receipt and that assessment determines response time requirements based on Priority.

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Incident Impact - What/who is affected by this incident?

The Impact field details the effect of an issue on business operations and customers, which includes scope and numbers of customer affected, and is often based on how service levels will be affected. Impact options are:

Impact Options	Description
1 (Critical)	<u>National</u> impact
2 (High)	<u>Single</u> Facility or Regional impact
3 (Medium)	<u>Office/Floor</u> Impacting feature or function within an application/service for an Office/Floor without affecting the entire application/service.
4 (Low)	<u>One or more users</u> Impacting a feature or function within an application/service for one or more users without affecting the entire application/service.

Incident Urgency - How quickly should OIT acknowledge, respond, and restore the Incident?

The Urgency field measures the criticality of an issue and time available for fulfillment, repair or avoidance before business operations and customers are affected. Urgency options are:

Urgency Options	Description
1 (Critical)	System outage (Application or Service)
2 (High)	Customer work stoppage
3 (Medium)	Resolution scheduled when resources are available. Work Around is Available.
4 (Low)	Convenience vs. function - All <u>other</u> issues

Incident Priority Matrix (Urgency + Impact = Priority)

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Incident Response Performance Measures

Priority	Description	Target Communication interval (Service-Level Target)	Target Resolution Timeframe (Service-Level Target)
P1	Critical	Immediately, but no more than 30 minutes from initial notification. Hourly updates/notifications and final notifications when issue resolution is confirmed.	24 hours from initial notification to acceptable service/issue resolution
P2	High	Within 30 minutes from initial notification. Updates/notifications every 2-hours and final notifications when issue resolution is confirmed.	2 business days from initial notification to acceptable service/issue resolution
P3	Moderate	Within 12-hours from initial notification, Updates/notifications every 24-hours and final notifications when issue resolution is confirmed.	4 business days from initial notification to acceptable service/issue resolution
P4	Low	Within 24 hours from initial notification, Updates/notifications every 72-hours and final notifications when issue resolution is confirmed.	10 business days from initial notification to acceptable service/issue resolution

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5.28 SAAS ASSESSMENT, AUTHORIZATION, AND CONTINUOUS MONITORING REQUIREMENTS

5.28.1 IF THE SOLUTION IS NOT FedRAMP AUTHORIZED:

1. The information system solution selected by the Contractor shall comply with the Federal Information Security Management Act (FISMA).
2. The Contractor shall comply with FedRAMP requirements as mandated by Federal laws and policies, including making available any documentation, physical access, and logical access needed to support this requirement. The impact level shall be in accordance with individual task order requirements. << Impact Level from the Data Security Categorization. This should be done by DTC>>
3. The Contractor shall provide a SaaS product as defined by the following criteria:
5. SaaS is an application delivery model in which the application is hosted on a cloud infrastructure outside the security boundary of VA and is provided to the Cloud Service Customer (CSC) over the internet. The CSC uses the SaaS offering via a thin-client interface, such as a web-browser or a program interface.
6. The CSC subscribes to the SaaS offering and is only responsible for limited application configuration settings.
7. The CSP offering the application is responsible for management of the application, safeguarding of data stored or processed by the application, and all elements of the underlying infrastructure.
8. Additionally, the CSP is responsible for all on-going compliance. In order to qualify as SaaS for use at VA, and to align with Federal Risk and Authorization Management Program (FedRAMP) requirements, the hosting for the offering must conform to the NIST 800-145 definition of Cloud Computing and thus contain following key characteristics:
9. On-Demand Self-Service: The CSP fully automates the provisioning of both the customer interface and the underlying cloud components of the SaaS offering. In some cases, to the CSP may provision internal resources manually, while providing the CSC an automated interface to request and track the service.
10. Broad Network Access: The SaaS capabilities are available over the internet or over a network that is available from all access points the CSC requires. The SaaS offering is accessible through common platforms (e.g., mobile phones, tablets, laptops, and workstations).
11. Resource Pooling: The computing infrastructure supporting the SaaS offering is shared among more than one CSC using a multi-tenant model, and resources are dynamically assigned depending on customer demand.
12. Rapid Elasticity: Computing capabilities are automatically provisioned and released in a manner that scales with customer demand. In some cases, the scaling of resources may not be fully automated, but it should be fast enough to support the needs of the CSC, which the CSC would have to define.
13. Measured Service: Resource usage, such as storage, processing, bandwidth, and user activity are measured and reported on in a manner that is relevant to the SaaS offering.

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14. Following guidance from the Federal CIO, VA will utilize existing Joint Authorization Board ATO or agency ATO issued by another agency as a starting point for FedRAMP requirements. If neither of those exist, VA will sponsor FedRAMP ATO. VA will be using the FedRAMP baselines as a starting point, since they are specifically tailored for cloud services.
15. The Contractor shall, where applicable, assist with the VA ATO Process to help achieve agency authorization of the cloud service or migrated application.
16. The Contractor shall comply with FedRAMP requirements surrounding data location within the Continental United States. FedRAMP specifies data location requirements in the High Baseline as part of control SA-9 (5); however, FedRAMP does not provide or specify data location requirements for other baselines
17. The Contractor shall complete a FedRAMP System Security Plan (SSP) and supporting documentation including required attachments.
18. The Contractor shall work with a VA DTC Subject Matter Expert to develop and provide a VA system boundary diagram including any integration and connectivity components for VA use. This will be known as the VA Implementation Diagram (VAID) and will demonstrate the proposed implementation of this system at VA
19. The Contractor shall complete a Third-Party Assessment Organization (3PAO) Security Assessment Plan (SAP).
20. The Contractor shall complete a 3PAO Security Assessment Report (SAR).
21. If new or unanticipated vulnerabilities are discovered by either VA or the Contractor, or if existing safeguards have ceased to function, the discoverer shall immediately bring the situation to the attention of the other party within one hour in accordance with Addendum B, Information and Information System Security/Privacy Language.
22. The Contractor shall comply with FedRAMP data management requirements.
23. Successful issuance of a VA ATO will be required before live VA data can be used in the system.
24. The Contractor shall participate in FedRAMP Continuous Monitoring activities as outlined by FedRAMP's Continuous Monitoring Strategy Guide found on the FedRAMP website.
25. The Contractor shall participate in monthly Agency and FedRAMP Sustainment meetings following the granting of a VA ATO.
26. The Contractor shall provide continuous monitoring activities including, but not limited to, scans, security artifacts, and provide Continuous Monitoring Monthly Scans and monthly Plan of Action and Milestones (POAM) reports as outlined by VA and FedRAMP requirements.
27. The Contractor shall provide a Monthly VA License Report of VA sites currently utilizing the cloud product post ATO award. The license report shall include the number of subscription licenses being utilized and the specific VA site where they're in use.

Deliverables:

- A. FedRAMP System Security Plan (SSP) and required Attachments

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- B. VA Implementation Diagram
- C. 3PAO Security Assessment Plan (SAP)
- D. 3PAO Security Assessment Report (SAR)
- E. Plan of Action and Milestones Reports.
- F. Monthly VA License Report

5.28.2 IF THE SOLUTION IS FedRAMP AUTHORIZED BUT NOT VA AUTHORIZED:

1. The information system solution selected by the Contractor shall comply with the FISMA.
2. The Contractor shall remain in compliance with FedRAMP requirements as mandated by Federal laws and policies, including making available any documentation, physical access, and logical access needed to support this requirement.
3. The system must be FedRAMP Authorized. The impact level shall be in accordance with individual task order requirements << Impact Level from the Data Security Categorization. This should be done by DTC>>
4. The Contractor shall, where applicable, assist with the VA ATO Process to help achieve agency authorization of the cloud service or migrated application.
5. The Contractor shall provide confirmation of the completion of its FedRAMP System Security Plan (SSP) and supporting documentation by providing, to the VA PM, COR, and DTC, its repository ID number and associated link for VA to download the SSP and all required artifacts within five calendar days of contract award.
6. The Contractor shall work with a VA DTC Subject Matter Expert to develop and provide a VA specific system boundary diagram including any integration and connectivity components for VA use. This will be known as the VA Implementation Diagram (VAID) and will demonstrate the proposed implementation of this system at VA.
7. The Contractor shall provide the results of their most recent Third-Party Assessment Organization (3PAO) Security Assessment Plan (SAP).
8. The Contractor shall complete a 3PAO Security Assessment Report (SAR).
9. The Contractor shall provide VA with the most recent monthly scans for the production environment within the authorization boundary and their scan upload schedule for FedRAMP within 30 calendar days of contract award.
10. The Contractor shall provide their availability to participate in monthly continuous monitoring meetings to be scheduled following successful VA ATO within 30 calendar days of contract award.
11. If new or unanticipated vulnerabilities are discovered by either VA or the Contractor, or if existing safeguards have ceased to function, the discoverer shall bring the situation to the attention of the other party within one hour in accordance with Addendum B, VA Information and Information System Security/Privacy Language.
12. The Contractor shall comply with FedRAMP data management requirements.
13. Successful issuance of a VA ATO will be required before live VA data can be used in the system.
14. The Contractor shall participate in FedRAMP Continuous Monitoring activities as

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outlined by FedRAMP's Continuous Monitoring Strategy.

15. The Contractor shall participate in monthly Agency and FedRAMP Sustainment meetings following the granting of a VA ATO.
16. The Contractor shall provide continuous monitoring activities including, but not limited to scans, security artifacts, and provide Continuous Monitoring Monthly Scans and monthly Plan of Action and Milestones (POAM) reports as outlined by VA and FedRAMP requirements.
17. The Contractor shall provide a Monthly VA License Report of VA sites currently utilizing the cloud product post ATO award. The license report shall include the number of subscription licenses being utilized and the specific VA site where they're in use.

Deliverables:

- A. VA Implementation Diagram
- B. 3PAO Security Assessment Plan (SAP)
- C. 3PAO Security Assessment Report (SAR)
- D. Plan of Action and Milestones Reports
- E. Monthly VA License Report

5.28.3 IF THE SOLUTION IS FedRAMP AUTHORIZED AND VA AUTHORIZED:

1. The information system solution selected by the Contractor shall comply with the FISMA and have a current VA authorization.
2. The Contractor shall remain in compliance with FedRAMP requirements as mandated by Federal laws and policies, including making available any documentation, physical access, and logical access needed to support this requirement.
3. The FedRAMP Authorization level and existing VA ATO should be no less than the level required for this use case. The impact level shall be in accordance with individual task order requirements << Impact Level from the Data Security Categorization. This should be done by DTC>>.
4. The Contractor shall, where applicable, assist with the VA ATO Sustainment Process to help maintain health and quality of agency authorization of the cloud service or migrated application.
5. The Contractor shall exclusively provide subscription licenses to FedRAMP authorized and VA authorized environments.
6. If new or unanticipated vulnerabilities are discovered by either VA or the Contractor, or if existing safeguards have ceased to function, the discoverer shall bring the situation to the attention of the other party within one hour in accordance with Addendum B, VA Information and Information System Security/Privacy Language. VA Privacy and Security deliverables as directed by the VA System owner.
7. The Contractor shall comply with FedRAMP data management requirements.
8. Successful issuance of a VA ATO will be required before live VA data can be used in the system.

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9. The Contractor shall participate in FedRAMP Continuous Monitoring activities as outlined by FedRAMP's Continuous Monitoring Strategy Guide found on the FedRAMP Website.
10. The Contractor shall provide continuous monitoring activities including, but not limited to, scans, security artifacts, and provide Continuous Monitoring Monthly Scans and monthly Plan of Action and Milestones (POAM) reports as outlined by FedRAMP requirements.
11. The Contractor shall participate in monthly Agency and FedRAMP Sustainment meetings following the granting of a VA ATO.
12. The Contractor shall provide a Monthly VA License report of VA sites currently utilizing the cloud product post ATO award. The license report shall include the number of subscription licenses being utilized and the specific VA site where they're in use

Deliverables:

- A. Continuous Monitoring Monthly Scans
- B. Plan of Action and Milestones Reports.
- C. Monthly VA License Report

5.29 VA ENTERPRISE CLOUD IMPLEMENTATION/MIGRATION

Specific requirements for implementations or migrations of applications or systems to the VAEC shall be identified in individual task orders.

5.29.1 ARCHITECTURE AND DESIGN

The Contractor shall develop and maintain the solution architecture aligned with the VAEC Technical Reference Architecture as well as the One-VA Enterprise Architecture. The Contractor shall design VAEC hosted solution and address VA identified cloud-readiness gaps.

Deliverables:

- A. Solution Architecture
- B. Solution Design

5.29.2 IMPLEMENTATION/MIGRATION PLANNING

The Contractor shall:

1. Develop, maintain, and execute the VAEC Implementation/Migration Plan that defines the implementation/migration approach, processes and activities (prior to, during, and after), test strategy, setup and configuration procedure, data migration approach, inventory of IT assets, implementation/migration checklist, risk assessment, key dependencies, and schedule. In the event that a VAEC CSP has not yet been selected by VA, the Contractor shall recommend a CSP.
2. Develop and execute the VAEC Transition Plan, as part of the VAEC Implementation/Migration Plan, that defines the approach and action plans to

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prepare VA stakeholders to receive and operate the solution. This includes improving stakeholder engagement, outreach, and communications.

3. Develop and update project's VIP Deployment and Installation, Back-out, and Rollback Plan that describes the installation, back-out, and rollback approach, processes and activities, dependencies, and schedule. The plan shall also include the provisioning and installation procedures for VAEC resources.
4. Determine cloud capacity and workload requirements. VA shall review and approve cloud capacity requirements and provide the VAEC cloud capacity for the solution as GFE.
5. Assess input to VA to assess whether the current solution should be decommissioned (for migrations of applications to VAEC).

Deliverable:

A. VAEC Implementation/Migration Plan

5.29.3 BUILD AND DEVELOPMENT

The Contractor shall:

1. Support setup, configuration, and provisioning of the solution in the VAEC environments.
2. Work with VA to provide inputs for establishing VAEC capacity, accounts and privileges. This includes monitoring and tracking the creation, update, and deletion of application user (e.g., developer, systems administrator) accounts, and ensuring cloud capacity requirements are satisfied.
3. Develop necessary artifacts to obtain a VA ATO for the solution and complete VA Assessment and Authorization (A&A) process. After ATO is achieved, the Contractor shall update and maintain the A&A documentation as required to ensure continued compliance. The Contractor shall monitor, track, and respond to Plan of Action and Milestones (POAM). The Contractor shall provide input to update the VAEC ATO, as needed.
4. Provide information and documentation to support operational and production readiness reviews and go-no-go decisions. The Contractor shall execute corrective actions to address gaps and provide all required data and prepare supporting documents/artifacts for the reviews.

5.29.4 TESTING AND VALIDATION FOR MIGRATIONS

The Contractor shall validate migrated data as defined in the IMM (Solution) Test Plan.

5.29.5 IMPLEMENTATION

The Contractor shall:

1. Implement the solution in the VAEC as defined in VIP Deployment and Installation, Back-out, and Rollback Plan, as well as the VAEC Implementation/Migration Plan.

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2. Migrate data from current environment to the VAEC. The Contractor shall validate that the data has been successfully migrated as defined in the VAEC Migration Plan. (For migration of applications to the VAEC only)
3. Provide inputs and documentation for the Post-Implementation Review, within 5 days of migration completion, to review lessons learned and identify improvement opportunities.
4. Provide a Implementation/Migration Summary Report that describes Implementation results, lessons learned, open issues, corrective action, and improvement opportunities.

Deliverable:

- A. IMM (Solution) VAEC Implementation/Migration Summary Report

5.29.6 OPERATE AND MAINTAIN

The Contractor shall:

1. Operate and maintain the solution hosted in the VAEC in accordance with the application and VAEC SLAs, and operate the solution in its current environment in parallel as applicable
2. Utilize VAEC General Support Services (GSS) when available and applicable in order to minimize cloud services costs and optimize operations. The contractor shall use native tools and capabilities of the VAEC environment.
3. Provide for the backup and recovery of information stored by the solution to meet the application and VAEC SLA using native tools and capabilities of the VAEC environment.

5.29.7 MONITOR PERFORMANCE AND REPORTING

The Contractor shall:

1. Provide a Quarterly Solution Performance Report that summarizes solution availability, usage, events and incidents, improvement opportunities, risks and issues, status, action plans, and planned and actual resolution timelines.
2. Review all usage of cloud computing services provided by VAEC. The Contractor shall submit and implement Quarterly Resource Utilization Optimization Plans on how to best optimize the environment to reduce the costs associated with resource utilization.
3. Provide a breakdown of all costs by solution, environment, and utilization. The Contractor shall report on utilization of each class of resource as a percentage of provisioned capacity in a Monthly Utilization Report. The Contractor shall, as part of its Monthly Utilization Report, include the total infrastructure expenditure and total number of request services for Cloud Resource Optimization.

Deliverables:

- A. Quarterly Solution Performance Report

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- B. Quarterly Resource Utilization Optimization Plan
- C. Monthly Utilization Report

5.30 DEPLOYMENT, TRANSITION, AND HELP DESK

The Contractor shall provide a post-deployment checklist, and dashboard that verify users are fully functional in the new system across per capabilities provided across each commodity. The contractor shall provide a post-deployment team to stay on site for a minimum of two weeks post-deployment to assist users in the new system and address any performance issues or on-site training needs at the site.

6.0 SERVICE LEVEL AGREEMENT AND CONTINUITY OF OPERATIONS PLAN (COOP)

6.1 SERVICE LEVEL AGREEMENT

The Service Level Agreement for IMM is incorporated into the contract at Attachment 002, Inventory Management Modernization SLA. ***THE SERVICE LEVEL AGREEMENT SHALL BE A MINIMUM REQUIREMENT; HOWEVER, OFFERORS MAY PROPOSE HIGHER LEVELS OF SERVICE AS PART OF THEIR PROPOSED APPROACH, WHICH SHALL BE INCORPORATED INTO THE FINAL AWARDED SLA.***

The Contractor shall meet the operational and availability standards, including a downtime process for all systems provided under this contract.

In addition to meeting or exceeding the SLAs incorporated in the contract at Attachment 002, the Contractor shall:

1. Ensure services conform to the following tiered SLA parameters effective at Task Order award.
 1. Provide unfettered access to all components of the IMM System/s provided and maintained by the Contractor 24 hours a day, seven days a week, 365 days a year (24x7x365), including leap year. Any unscheduled downtime for the IMM system shall be counted against the $\geq 99.95\%$ SLA.

Hours of Operation	Availability*
24/7	99.95%

*99.95% system availability calculations shall exclude planned downtime for maintenance that the Contractor cannot perform without interruption to the live system.

Downtime limit with a Service Level Agreement of 99.95%:

Availability	Time Period	Downtime Limit	Unit
99.95%	Day	43	Sec
99.95%	Week	5.20	Min
99.95%	Month	21.44	Min

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99.95%	Year	4.20	Hrs
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2. The Contractor shall notify VA's Contracting Officer and COR in writing to notify and schedule system maintenance or routine data consolidation to maintain the integrity of the system at least 10 business days in advance with additional notification leading up to the actual downtime. All schedule downtime shall be performed outside of peak system usage times. The system maintenance notification shall include the system(s) affected, changes that will occur, impact the change has on users, and the date/time changes will be in effect. The Contractor shall schedule system maintenance only during the standard maintenance windows provided by VA and properly scheduled system maintenance that impacts system availability will not count against the IMM uptime (Outage Free Time (OFT)) metric.
3. For unscheduled system maintenance, the Contractor shall notify the Contracting Officer and COR via email within one hour of identifying an issue and that unscheduled maintenance will count against the availability of the system if downtime is incurred.
4. When unscheduled downtime occurs for more than one cumulative hour in any given 24-hour period, the Contractor shall conduct a Root Cause Analysis. The Contractor shall complete the analysis and provide its findings and recommended corrective actions to the VA Task Manager within five business days of the event. The Contractor shall provide the VA Task Manager with a schedule to resolve any identified issues within two days of completion of the Root Cause Analysis.
5. Calculate the "System Unavailability" for the IMM System for each calendar month and include the results in the monthly System Uptime Report. "System Unavailability" consists of the number of minutes and hours that the system was not available during the operational hours defined in 5.19(a)(1).
6. Major incidents shall be reported and handled in alignment with VA OIT Major Incident Management (MIM) Process. A major incident is a high-impact, high-urgency incident that affects many users, depriving the business of one or more crucial services. An incident becomes major when it results in a significant disruption to the business and demands a response beyond the routine incident management process.
7. The Contractor shall meet or exceed the Minimum Acceptable Performance Level (MAPL) for each SLA Metric to achieve full payment for an invoice. A failure to achieve the MAPL within the SLA performance period defined shall result in a credit to VA in the invoice for that period. Specific levels of performance levels below the MAPL and the credit to be applied to a VA invoice are defined in the full SLA included with the RFP package.
8. Conduct Root Cause analyses and provide findings to the VA COR and PM within three business days of detection if System Availability levels have fallen below the levels specified in this section. Provide the VA COR and PM with a schedule to resolve the issues within two business days of completion of the Root Cause Analyses.

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9. The provider shall produce reports on a regular cadence depending on the target metric. Unscheduled reports shall be delivered as agreed on between the service provider and the VA COR and PM on a case-by-case basis.
10. The SLA shall be reviewed a minimum of once per quarter, or by request of either party to address specific-service issues and determine if changes to reports produced are required.

6.2 CONTINUITY OF OPERATIONS PLAN (COOP)

1. The Contractor shall develop a Continuity of Operations Plan (COOP) that demonstrates the process for the continuous operation of its IT systems and selected cloud service provider.
2. The Contractor shall identify backup sites/facilities, shall identify in a priority order critical systems and applications, data availability, and organizational support of the IMM to provide 99.95% system availability.
3. The Contractor shall establish a reporting structure in the COOP.
4. The Contractor's COOP shall be submitted to VA IAW the Schedule of Deliverables and match expectations defined in this section.
5. The COOP shall include user access and authentication processes.
6. The COOP shall include information specific to all actions taken by the Contractor to continue operations should an actual disaster be declared for its IMM operations.
7. The COOP shall describe the process for managing temporary system unavailability and the communication method that will be used to ensure minimal process disruption.
8. The Contractor's systems and associated data shall always be available even in the event of hardware, software, and/or communications failures.
9. The Contractor shall notify VA's Contracting Officer and COR in writing to notify and schedule system maintenance at least two weeks in advance. The system maintenance notification shall include the system(s) affected, changes that will occur, and the date/time changes will be in effect.
10. The Contractor shall schedule system maintenance only during the standard maintenance windows provided by VA. For unscheduled system maintenance, the Contractor shall notify the Contracting Officer and COR via email (within one [1] hour of being alerted of an issue).
11. The COOP must address the following categories:
 - a. Process for Continuous Operations
 - b. System Maintenance (Scheduled and Unscheduled)
 - c. Hardware/Software System Failures
 - d. Temporary System Unavailability
 - e. Availability Performance
 - f. Disaster Recovery
12. The Contractor must submit a COOP Report IAW the Schedule of Deliverables to the COR during the period of performance.
13. The COOP Report shall include data such as system downtime (planned and unplanned) recorded that month (total hours and minutes), functional

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capabilities impacted by the system down time, root cause analysis and reason for the system downtime, updates/changes made to the system during downtime (or steps taken to remediate if no changes), and a summary of any analysis and corrective and preventive after actions taken to prevent recurrence.

7.0 GENERAL REQUIREMENTS

7.1 ENTERPRISE AND IT FRAMEWORK

7.1.1 VA TECHNICAL REFERENCE MODEL

The Contractor shall comply with the VA OIT Technical Reference Model (VA TRM). Compliance with the VA TRM is achieved by using only technologies and standards that are listed as approved for use in the VA TRM. The Contractor shall provide all necessary information requested by VA to ensure TRM approval is obtained prior to use on VA's network.

7.1.2 ZERO TRUST – VA CRITICAL SECURITY CONTROLS

VA has established minimum mandatory security requirements and requires that any network connected software system or service must meet the VA Critical Security Controls as outlined in the VA Memorandum, "VA Security Controls", <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=5010>. VA Critical Security Controls identify the minimum mandatory requirements that must be implemented across all VA enterprise infrastructure, cloud computing environments, information systems, networks, and specialized devices (medical devices/systems, special-purpose systems, and research scientific computing devices) that process, store, and/or transmit VA data. Effective July 1, 2025, the Contractor shall implement these VA Critical Security Controls, within any network connected software system or service prior to being authorized for use in the VA. This functional requirement is not negotiable, and Plan of Action & Milestones (POAM) will not be accepted in the event these controls cannot be implemented for new systems. Critical Security Controls are intended to increase VA's security posture and provide security and privacy risk visibility into the VA network and is not a new requirement. The Contractor's failure to maintain these VA Critical Controls after implementation will result in VA discontinuing the use of the system.

7.1.3 FEDERAL IDENTITY, CREDENTIAL, AND ACCESS MANAGEMENT (FICAM)

The Contractor shall ensure Commercial Off-The-Shelf (COTS) product(s), software configuration and customization, and/or new software are Personal Identity Verification (PIV) card-enabled by accepting HSPD-12 PIV credentials using [VA Enterprise Architecture \(EA\)](#), and VA Identity and Access Management (IAM) approved [Enterprise Technology Guidelines \(ETG\)](#). The Contractor shall ensure all Contractor delivered applications and systems comply with the VA Identity, Credential, and Access Management policies and guidelines set forth in Executive Order 14028, VA Handbook 6510 VA Identity and Access Management, VA Handbook 0735 Homeland Security Presidential Directive 12 (HSPD-12) Program, CISA Binding Operational Directive 23-

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01, and align with the Federal Identity, Credential, and Access Management Roadmap and Implementation Guidance v2.0.

The Contractor shall ensure all Contractor delivered applications and systems provide user authentication services compliant with the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) Special Publication (SP) 800-63-4, VA Handbook 6500, and VA IAM enterprise requirements for direct, assertion based authentication, and/or trust based authentication, as determined by the ETGs. Direct authentication at a minimum must include Public Key Infrastructure (PKI) based authentication supportive of PIV card and/or Common Access Card (CAC), as determined by the business need.

The Contractor shall ensure all Contractor delivered applications and systems conform to the specific Identity and Access Management PIV requirements set forth in the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Memoranda [M-05-24](#), [M-19-17](#), [M-22-09](#), and NIST Federal Information Processing Standard (FIPS) 201-3. Contractor delivered applications and systems shall be on the FIPS 201 Approved Product List (APL). If the Contractor delivered application and system is not on the APL, the Contractor shall be responsible for taking the application and system through the FIPS 201 Evaluation Program.

The Contractor shall ensure all Contractor delivered applications and systems support:

1. Automated provisioning and are able to use enterprise provisioning service.
2. Interfacing with VA's Master Person Index (MPI) to provision identity attributes, if the solution relies on VA user identities. MPI is the authoritative source for VA user identity data.
3. The VA defined unique identity (Secure Identifier [SEC ID] / Integrated Control Number [ICN]).
4. Multiple authenticators for a given identity and authenticators at every Authenticator Assurance Level (AAL) appropriate for the solution.
5. Identity proofing for each Identity Assurance Level (IAL) appropriate for the solution.
6. Federation for each Federation Assurance Level (FAL) appropriate for the solution, if applicable.
7. Two-factor authentication (2FA) through an applicable Technology Guideline as outlined in VA ETG.
8. A Security Assertion Markup Language (SAML) implementation if the solution relies on assertion-based authentication. Additional assertion implementations, besides the required SAML assertion, may be provided as long as they are compliant with NIST SP 800-63-4 guidelines.
9. Authentication/account binding based on trusted Hypertext Transfer Protocol (HTTP) headers if the solution relies on Trust based authentication.
10. Role Based Access Control.
11. Auditing and reporting capabilities.
12. Compliance with VIEWS 00155984, PIV Logical Access Policy Clarification <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=4896>.

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The required Assurance Levels for this specific effort are Identity Assurance Level 3, Authenticator Assurance Level 3, and Federation Assurance Level 3.

7.1.4 INTERNET PROTOCOL VERSION 6 (IPv6)

The Contractor solution shall support IPv6-Only based upon the memo issued by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) on November 19, 2020 (<https://www.whitehouse.gov/wp-content/uploads/2020/11/M-21-07.pdf>). Which defines IPv6-only as the state of an operational system or service when IPv4 protocol functions (addressing, packet forwarding) are not in use. The NIST USGv6 profile defines technical requirements for a product to be capable of operating in IPv6-Only environments. IPv6-Only technology, in accordance with the USGv6 Program (<https://www.nist.gov/programs-projects/usgv6-program/usgv6-revision-1>), NIST Special Publication (SP) 500-267B Revision 1 "USGv6 Profile" (<https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.SP.500-267Br1>), and NIST SP 800-119 "Guidelines for the Secure Deployment of IPv6" (<https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.SP.800-119>), compliance shall be included in all IT infrastructures, application designs, application development, operational systems and sub-systems, and their integration. In addition to the above requirements, all devices, applications, and systems shall support all applicable functionality on native IPv6-Only as well as dual stack (IPv6 / IPv4) connectivity without additional memory or other resources being provided by the Government, so that they can function in a mixed environment. All public/external facing servers and services (e.g., web, email, DNS, ISP services, etc.) shall support native IPv6-Only and dual stack (IPv6 / IPv4) users and all internal infrastructure and applications shall support using native IPv6-Only and dual stack (IPv6 / IPv4) for all functionality and operations.

7.1.5 TRUSTED INTERNET CONNECTION (TIC)

The Contractor solution shall meet the requirements outlined in Office of Management and Budget Memorandum M-19-26, "Update to the Trusted Internet Connections (TIC) Initiative" (<https://www.whitehouse.gov/wp-content/uploads/2019/09/M-19-26.pdf>), VA Directive 6513 "Secure External Connections", and shall comply with the TIC 3.0 Core Guidance Documents, including all Volumes and TIC Use Cases, found at the Cybersecurity & Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) (<https://www.cisa.gov/publication/tic-30-core-guidance-documents>).

7.1.6 STANDARD COMPUTER CONFIGURATION

The Contractor IT end user solution that is developed for use on standard VA computers shall be compatible with and be supported on the standard VA operating system, Windows 11, Edge (Chromium based), and 365 Apps for enterprise. Applications delivered to VA and intended to be deployed to Windows 11 workstations shall be delivered as a signed .msi package with switches for silent and unattended installation and updates shall be delivered in signed .msp file formats for easy deployment using Microsoft Endpoint Configuration Manager (CM) VA's current desktop application deployment tool. Signing of the software code shall be through a vendor provided certificate that is trusted by VA using a code signing authority such as Verizon/Cybertrust or Symantec/VeriSign. The Contractor shall also ensure and certify that their solution functions as expected when used from a standard VA computer, with

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non-admin, standard user rights that have been configured using the Defense Information Systems Agency (DISA) Secure Technical Implementation Guide (STIG) specific to the particular client operating system being used.

7.1.7 VETERAN FOCUSED INTEGRATION PROCESS (VIP) AND PRODUCT LINE MANAGEMENT (PLM)

The Contractor shall support VA efforts IAW the Veteran-Focused Integration Process (VIP) Guide and Product Line Management (PLM) Playbook. The major focus of VIP is on Enterprise Oversight, Governance, reporting, and establishing practices that focus on outcomes and continuously delivering sustainable IT capabilities to benefit the Veteran. PLM is a framework that focuses on delivering functional products that provide the highest priority work to customers while delivering simplified, reliable, and practical solutions to the business, medical staff, and our Veterans. The VIP Guide is a companion guide to the PLM Transformation Playbook and can be found at: <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=4371> and the PLM Transformation Playbook can be found at <https://www.voa.va.gov/DocumentView.aspx?DocumentID=4946>. VIP and PLM are the authoritative processes that IT projects must follow to ensure development and delivery of IT products.

The VIP Guide provides guidance for transitioning from project-centric to product-centric delivery. The VIP guide applies to all OIT Office of Management and Budget (OMB) reportable products that are required to collect and report costs, schedules, risks, and other valuable information in VA PARS (whether products are procured or developed by VA) and any VA Information Technology project effort in Software Product Management (SPM) and Infrastructure Operations (IO), or their successors, that touch the VA network regardless of IT organizational alignment (whether it spends government funding from VA's Congressional IT Appropriation or any other appropriation).

The PLM Transformation Playbook details how OIT leadership expects Product Lines (PLs) to implement PLM, DevOps, and Lean-Agile principles, methods, practices, and techniques through levels of maturity. The PLM Transformation Playbook applies to all Information Technology (IT) products aligned to PLs in the Software Product Management, Infrastructure Operations and Product Engineering organizations within the OIT organization.

Others outside the referenced groups or organizations may use the VIP Guide and PLM Transformation Playbook for situational awareness as needed.

7.1.8 PROCESS ASSET LIBRARY (PAL)

The Contractor shall perform their duties consistent with the processes defined in the OIT Process Asset Library (PAL). The PAL includes a spectrum of OIT functions and activities, such as project management, operations, service delivery, communications, acquisition, and resource management. PAL serves as an authoritative and informative repository of searchable processes, activities or tasks, roles, artifacts, tools and applicable standards and guides to assist the OIT workforce, Government and

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Contractor personnel. OIT utilizes PAL processes to ensure compliance with policies and regulations and to meet VA quality standards. The PAL includes the contractor onboarding process consistent with Section 6.2.2 and can be found at [process CONB ext.docx \(live.com\)](#). The main PAL can be accessed at www.va.gov/process.

7.1.9 AUTHORITATIVE DATA SOURCES

The VA Enterprise Architecture Repository (VEAR) is one component within the overall EA that establishes the common framework for data taxonomy for describing the data architecture used to develop, operate, and maintain enterprise applications. The Contractor shall comply with the department's Authoritative Data Source (ADS) requirement that VA systems, services, and processes throughout the enterprise shall access VA data solely through official VA ADSs where applicable, see below. The Information Classes which compose each ADS are located in the VEAR, in the Data & Information domain. The Contractor shall ensure that all delivered applications and system solutions support:

1. Interfacing with VA's Master Person Index (MPI) (formerly the Master Veteran Index (MVI)) to provision identity attributes, if the solution relies on VA user identities. MPI is the authoritative source for VA user identity data.
2. Interfacing with Capital Asset Inventory (CAI) to conduct real property record management actions, if the solution relies on real property records data. CAI is the authoritative source for VA real property record management data.
3. Interfacing with electronic Contract Management System (eCMS) for access to contract, contract line item, purchase requisition, offering vendor, and solicitation information above the micro-purchase threshold, if the solution relies on procurement data. ECMS is the authoritative source for VA procurement actions data.
4. Interfacing with HRSmart Human Resources Information System to conduct personnel action processing, on-boarding, benefits management, and compensation management, if the solution relies on personnel data. HRSmart is the authoritative source for VA personnel information data.
5. Interfacing with VA Profile to access personal contact information, if the solution relies on VA Veteran personal contact information data. VA Profile is the authoritative source for VA Veteran Personal Contact Data.
6. Interfacing with VA/Department of Defense (DoD) Identity Repository (VADIR) for determining eligibility for VA benefits under Title 38, if the solution relies on qualifying active duty military service data. VADIR is the authoritative source for qualifying active duty military service in VA.
7. Interfacing with VA Systems Inventory (VASI) to access VA systems information, if the solution relies on VA system information. VASI is the authoritative source for VA Information Technology systems.
8. Interfacing with Enterprise Mission Assurance Support Service (eMASS) to access the historical ATO status of all VA Information Systems prior to migrating to ServiceNow Continuous Authorization and Monitoring (SNowCAM) until it is determined the migration is completed and eMASS is sunset. eMASS contains

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the historical ATO status of all VA Information Systems prior to September 30, 2025, with all status provided through SNowCAM once migration is completed.

7.1.10 SOCIAL SECURITY NUMBER (SSN) REDUCTION

The Contractor solution shall support the Social Security Number (SSN) Fraud Prevention Act (FPA) of 2017 which prohibits the inclusion of SSNs on any document sent by mail. The Contractor support shall also be performed in accordance with Section 240 of the Consolidated Appropriations Act (CAA) 2018, enacted March 23, 2018, which mandates VA to discontinue using SSNs to identify individuals in all VA information systems as the Primary Identifier. The Contractor shall ensure that any new IT solution discontinues the use of SSN as the Primary Identifier to replace the SSN with the ICN in all VA information systems for all individuals. The Contractor shall ensure that all Contractor delivered applications and systems integrate with the VA MPI for identity traits to include the use of the ICN as the Primary Identifier. The Contractor solution may only use a Social Security Number to identify an individual in an information system if and only if the use of such number is required to obtain information VA requires from an information system that is not under the jurisdiction of VA.

7.1.11 SOFTWARE AND LICENSING REQUIREMENTS

The Contractor shall be responsible for the provision of all software licenses and any associated licensing maintenance required for any development, delivery, integration, operation, and/or maintenance associated with its proposed application(s), software products, software solution, and/or system including, but not limited to, any and all application(s), software and/or software products that comprise, are a part of, or integrate with the Contractor's proposed application(s), software products, software solution, and/or system for the life of any resulting contract.

7.1.12 GENERATIVE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE REQUIREMENTS

If AI is part of the Contractor system/solution, the Contractor shall be in compliance with E.O. 13960 and 14319, OMB Memorandums M-25-21, M-25-22, and M-26-04, and VA Directive and Handbook 6500 to support VA in trustworthy, secure, responsible, accountable, Truth Seeking, and Ideologically Neutral AI innovation.

No web-based, publicly available generative AI service has been approved for use with VA-sensitive data including, but not limited to OpenAI's ChatGPT, Microsoft's Copilot, Google's Gemini, and Anthropic's Claude. No PII, protected health information (PHI), or VA-sensitive data should be entered into these unapproved services. The entire definition of VA Sensitive Data can be found at 38 U.S.C. § 5727 (23). The Contractor shall protect VA Sensitive data from unauthorized disclosure or use, and from being used to train or improve the functionality of the vendor's commercial offerings without express permission from VA. Only VA-hosted instances of generative AI services may be approved for use with VA-sensitive data.

The Contractor shall deliver the services, technical data, configurations, models, weights, documentation or other information, including source code, developed during

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contract performance. The Contractor, in collaboration with VA, must evaluate the output of any AI tool for accuracy prior to using the output in VA efforts. All data, including models, weights, algorithms, and outputs generated using either Government-furnished data or data first developed under this contract shall be the property of the Government with unlimited rights as defined by FAR 52.227-14. The Contractor shall also deliver any custom-developed code developed with AI methodologies in accordance with the SHARE IT Act, if applicable. VA shall also retain unlimited rights to any improvements to that data, including the continued design, development, testing, and operation of AI systems and/or systems utilizing AI.

The Contractor shall ensure that all AI Systems, including Large Language Models (LLM), whether standalone LLMs or integrated into broader software platforms, procured under this effort and/or used in performance of this contract complies with the Unbiased AI Principles as defined in Executive Order 14319 and OMB Memorandum M-26-04, e.g. Truth Seeking and Ideologically Neutral, as applicable to the intended use of the system.

The Contractor shall ensure that AI System/LLM generated outputs are truthful in responding to user prompts seeking factual information or analysis, prioritize historical accuracy, scientific inquiry, and objectivity, as well as acknowledge uncertainty where reliable information is incomplete or contradictory and do not fabricate, hallucinate, or present unverifiable information as fact.

The Contractor shall ensure that LLMs and AI outputs are neutral, nonpartisan tools that do not manipulate responses in favor of ideological dogmas such as Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI). The Contractor shall ensure that the LLMs, including the AI System, are not intentionally encoded with partisan or ideological judgments within an AI System's/LLM's outputs unless those judgments are prompted by or otherwise readily accessible to the end user.

Compliance with the AI requirements of this contract, including adherence to the Unbiased AI Principles, Truth-Seeking and Ideological Neutrality requirements, disclosure obligations, monitoring and reporting requirements, and corrective action responsibilities, is a material condition of eligibility for payment and continued performance. In accordance with OMB Memorandum M-26-04, failure to comply with these requirements, or refusal to take timely and appropriate corrective action to remedy identified noncompliance, may constitute a material breach of contract and may result in remedies consistent with the terms of the contract and applicable law including but not limited to withholding of payment, termination for cause/default, or other appropriate contractual remedies, as determined by the Contracting Officer.

All AI for delivery and/or use in performance of the contract shall adhere to the VA *Trustworthy AI Framework*, available at <https://department.va.gov/ai/trustworthy/>. Once the Contractor has obtained CO authorization to use specific AI in contract performance, the Contractor shall provide the COR a signed Statement of Attestation

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prior to AI implementation as identified in the AI in VA Contracts clause, to include its associated list of AI being used in contract performance.

Deliverable:

A. Statement of Attestation

7.1.12.1 AI SYSTEM/LLM DEVELOPMENT AND OPERATION DOCUMENTATION REQUIREMENTS

To enable Government continued assessment of compliance with Trustworthy AI requirements and both Unbiased AI Principles, Truth-seeking and Ideological Neutrality, in accordance with OMB M-26-04, the Contractor shall provide AI System/LLM Development and Operation Documentation Package to include, at a minimum:

1. Acceptable Use Policy

The Contractor shall provide an Acceptable Use Policy document governing its AI operation that characterizes and differentiates appropriate and inappropriate use of their product offering

2. Model Cards, System Cards and/or Data Cards

The Contractor shall provide documentation describing essential information about the model, system, and or data as it relates to the AI/LLM product offering. The documentation shall address summaries of training process, identified risks and mitigations, and model evaluation scores on LLM benchmarks at a minimum, where appropriate

3. End User Resources

The Contractor shall provide documentation to include product tutorials, developer guides, and/or other tools to assist VA in ensuring proper use of the AI/LLM to maximize utility

4. Mechanism for End User Feedback

The Contractor shall provide documentation describing the mechanism employed to provide feedback to the Offeror on outputs identified that violate the Unbiased AI Principles. This may be satisfied by a general inbox, specific Point of Contact, or similar feedback mechanism.

5. Pre-Training and Post-Training Activities of the AI System/LLM

The Contractor shall provide documentation of Pre-Training and Post Training Activity that provides details on:

- a. Actions taken that impact the factuality and grounding of AI System/LLM outputs
- b. System-level prompts that provide natural language instructions to the model specifying guidelines on responding to user-generated queries, to include how a model responds when reliable information is incomplete, contradictory, or subject to individual interpretation
- c. The type of outputs restricted via content moderation and safety filters
- d. The use of red teaming as a means of continuously assessing the model to protect against incidents of bias in generated output.
- e. Training or development, if any, that occurred outside the United States, to include the type of activity and the country in which it occurred.

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- f. Any modifications or configurations undertaken to comply with any regulation from a government other than the U.S. Federal Government.
- 6. **Model Evaluation Results and Methodologies**
The Contractor shall provide documentation describing the Evaluation Results of bias evaluations conducted by the Vendor to include the methodology for performing such tests (e.g., testing prompt pairs for politically oriented topics). The documentation shall also include Benchmark scoring results measuring the model's bias, helpfulness, honesty, or accuracy when provided with ambiguous versus straightforward questions. (Including any benchmarks comparing performance across multiple languages, where applicable).
- 7. **Description of Enterprise-Level Controls**
The Contractor shall provide documentation describing the Enterprise Governance tools and controls, such as:
 - a. Customizable system instructions that are additive to a base model's system prompts or content generation filters.
 - b. Product features that require a model to cite sources of its outputs or otherwise provide visibility into the provenance of the model's outputs.
 - c. AI System/LLM model evaluation tools that enable comparisons either between a model's outputs, or across various models.
- 8. **Third Party Modification Disclosure**
The Contractor shall disclose of any additional controls to modify an AI Model's/LLM's output applied by the Contractor if the Contractor is not a direct developer of the LLM (e.g., classifiers, system prompts, fine-tuning, content moderation and filters, etc.)

Deliverable:

- A. AI System/LLM Development and Operation Documentation Package

7.1.12.2 MONITORING, REPORTING, AND CORRECTIVE ACTION

The Contractor shall develop and implement a Compliance Monitoring and Reporting Plan supporting ongoing monitoring processes to evaluate AI outputs for compliance with Trustworthy AI and Unbiased AI principles. This plan shall include the mechanism for authorized users to provide end user feedback to report suspected violations of Truth-Seeking or Ideological Neutrality requirements.

The Contractor shall notify the COR within 10 business days of identifying any material deviation from these principles and shall submit a written Corrective Action Plan describing mitigation steps, responsible parties, and timelines. Any material deviation, corrective action taken, and results shall be detailed in the **<Monthly>** Progress Reports.

Deliverable:

- A. Compliance Monitoring and Reporting Plan
- B. Corrective Action Plan

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7.1.12.3 AI MODEL UPDATES AND CHANGE DISCLOSURES

The Contractor, in an AI Model/LLM Change Disclosure, shall notify the Government throughout the PoP in advance of any material changes to AI models, including new AI enhancements, features and/or components, controls, retraining, classifiers, system prompts, fine-tuning, content moderation, filters, version replacement, or architectural changes, that could reasonably affect compliance with Trustworthy AI or Unbiased AI principles. Updated documentation shall be provided to VA for VA approval prior to implementation of such changes.

Deliverable:

- A. AI Model/LLM Change Disclosure

7.2 SOURCE CODE HARMONIZATION AND REUSE IN INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY (SHARE IT ACT)

The Contractor shall comply with the Source Code Harmonization and Reuse in Information Technology (SHARE IT) Act, P.L. 118-187, when developing and delivering custom code first produced for the VA in the performance of this Contract/Order. The Contractor shall deliver to the Government all data first produced under this Contract/Order with unlimited rights as defined by FAR 52.227-14, to include without limitation, all custom-developed code and other key technical components of the code (including documentation, data models, schemas, metadata, architecture designs, configuration scripts, and artifacts required to develop, build, test, and deploy the code). Custom-developed code includes source code, or segregable portions of source code and all documentation created in support thereof to include source code written for a software project, product, module, plugin, script, middleware, or application programming interface.

7.3 SECURITY AND PRIVACY REQUIREMENTS

It has been determined that protected health information may be disclosed or accessed and a signed Business Associate Agreement (BAA) shall be required. The Contractor shall adhere to the requirements set forth within the BAA, referenced in Section D of the contract, and shall comply with VA Directive 6066.

6.2.1 POSITION/TASK RISK DESIGNATION LEVEL(S)

The position sensitivity risk designation [LOW, MODERATE, and HIGH] and associated level of background investigation [Tier 1, Tier 2, and Tier 4] for each TO PWS task shall be designated accordingly, as identified within the respective TO PWS. The level and process of background security investigations for Contractors must be IAW VA Directive and Handbook 0710, "Personnel Security and Suitability Program".

7.3.1 CONTRACTOR PERSONNEL SECURITY REQUIREMENTS

Contractor Responsibilities:

- a. The Contractor shall prescreen all personnel requiring access to the computer systems to ensure they maintain the appropriate Background Investigation, and are able to read, write, speak, and understand the English language.

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- b. Within 3 business days after award, the Contractor shall provide a roster of Contractor and Subcontractor employees to the COR to begin their background investigations in accordance with the PAL template artifact. The Contractor Staff Roster shall contain the Contractor's Full Name, Date of Birth, Place of Birth, individual background investigation level requirement (based upon Section 6.2.1 Tasks), etc. The Contractor shall submit full Social Security Numbers either within the Contractor Staff Roster or under separate cover to the COR. The Contractor Staff Roster shall be updated and provided to VA within 1 day of any changes in employee status, training certification completion status, Background Investigation level status, additions/removal of employees, etc. throughout the Period of Performance. The Contractor Staff Roster shall remain a historical document indicating all past information and the Contractor shall indicate in the Comment field, employees no longer supporting this contract. The preferred method to send the Contractor Staff Roster or Social Security Number is by encrypted e-mail. If unable to send encrypted e-mail, other methods which comply with FIPS 140-2 (or its successor) are to encrypt the file, use a secure fax, or use a traceable mail service. (Note that by September 22, 2026, all FIPS 140-2 certificate validations will be placed on the Historical List. See FIPS Transition Effort Timeline for more details: <https://csrc.nist.gov/projects/fips-140-3-transition-effort#schedule>)
- c. The Contractor should coordinate with the location of the nearest VA fingerprinting office through the COR. Only electronic fingerprints are authorized. The Contractor shall bring their completed Personnel Security Adjudication Center (PSAC) Fingerprint request form with them (see paragraph d.4. below) when getting fingerprints taken.
- d. The Contractor shall ensure the following required forms are submitted to the COR within 5 days after contract award:
 - 1) Optional Form 306
 - 2) Self-Certification of Continuous Service
 - 3) VA Form 0710
 - 4) Completed PSAC Fingerprint Request Form
- e. The Contractor personnel shall submit all required information related to their background investigations (completion of the investigation documents (SF85, SF85P, or SF 86) utilizing the Defense Counterintelligence and Security Agency (DCSA) National Background Investigation Services (NBIS) Electronic Application (eAPP) (formerly e-QIP) after receiving an email notification from the PSAC.
- f. The Contractor employee shall certify and release the eAPP document, print, and sign the signature pages, and send them encrypted to the COR for electronic submission to the PSAC. These documents shall be submitted to the COR within 3 business days of receipt of the eAPP notification email. (Note: DCSA is moving towards a "click to sign" process. If click to sign is used, the Contractor employee should notify the COR within 3 business days that documents were signed via eAPP).

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- g. The Contractor shall be responsible for the actions of all personnel provided to work for VA under this contract. In the event that damages arise from work performed by Contractor provided personnel, under the auspices of this contract, the Contractor shall be responsible for all resources necessary to remedy the incident.
- h. A Contractor may be granted unescorted access to VA facilities and/or access to VA Information Technology resources (network and/or protected data) with a favorably adjudicated Special Agreement Check (SAC), completed training delineated in VA Handbook 6500.6 (Appendix C, Section 4), signed "Contractor Rules of Behavior", and with a valid, operational Personal Identity Verification (PIV) credential for PIV-only logical access to VA's network. A PIV card credential can be issued once your SAC has been favorably adjudicated and your background investigation has been scheduled by DCSA. However, the Contractor will be responsible for the actions of the Contractor personnel they provide to perform work for VA. The investigative history for Contractor personnel working under this contract must be maintained in the database of DCSA.
- i. The Contractor, when notified of an unfavorably adjudicated background investigation on a Contractor employee as determined by the Government, shall withdraw the employee from consideration in working under the contract.
- j. Failure to comply with the Contractor personnel security investigative requirements may result in loss of physical and/or logical access to VA facilities and systems by Contractor and Subcontractor employees and/or termination of the contract for default.
- k. PIV Credential Holders must follow all HSPD-12 policies and procedures as well as use and protect their assigned identity credentials in accordance with VA policies and procedures, displaying their badges at all times, and returning the identity credentials upon termination of their relationship with VA.

Deliverable:

- A. Contractor Staff Roster

7.4 METHOD AND DISTRIBUTION OF DELIVERABLES

The Contractor shall deliver documentation in electronic format, unless otherwise directed in Section B of the solicitation/contract. Acceptable electronic media include: Microsoft 365 suite, MS Word, MS Excel, MS PowerPoint, MS Project, MS Access, MS Visio, AutoCAD, and Adobe Postscript Data Format (PDF).

7.5 CONTRACT PERFORMANCE METRICS

The table below defines the Performance Standards and Acceptable Levels of Performance associated with this effort and includes the Service Level Agreement (SLA) requirements the Contractor shall meet. The Contractor shall monitor, track, and report SLA performance in accordance with Government-defined reporting intervals and shall participate in recurring SLA review meetings to evaluate performance trends, identify risks, and implement corrective actions as required.

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Performance Objective	Performance Standard	Acceptable Levels of Performance
A. Technical / Quality of Product or Service	1. Demonstrates understanding of requirements 2. Efficient and effective in meeting requirements 3. Meets technical needs and mission requirements 4. Provides quality services/products 5.	Satisfactory or higher
B. Project Milestones and Schedule	1. Established milestones and project dates are met 2. Products completed, reviewed, delivered in accordance with the established schedule 3. Notifies customer in advance of potential problems	Satisfactory or higher
C. Cost & Staffing	1. Currency of expertise and staffing levels appropriate to perform tasks required 2. Personnel possess necessary knowledge, skills, and abilities to perform tasks	Satisfactory or higher
D. Management	1. Integration and coordination of all activities to execute effort	Satisfactory or higher

The COR will utilize a Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan (QASP) throughout the life of the contract to ensure that the Contractor is performing the services required by this PWS in an acceptable level of performance. The Government reserves the right to alter or change the surveillance methods in the QASP at its own discretion. A Performance Based Service Assessment will be used by the COR in accordance with the QASP to assess Contractor performance.

7.6 FACILITY/RESOURCE PROVISIONS

The Government will provide office space, telephone service and system access when authorized contract staff work at a Government location as required in order to accomplish the Tasks associated with this PWS. All procedural guides, reference materials, and program documentation for the project and other Government applications will also be provided on an as-needed basis.

The Contractor shall request other Government documentation deemed pertinent to the work accomplishment directly from the Government officials with whom the Contractor has contact. The Contractor shall consider the COR as the final source for needed

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Government documentation when the Contractor fails to secure the documents by other means. The Contractor is expected to use common knowledge and resourcefulness in securing all other reference materials, standard industry publications, and related materials that are pertinent to the work.

VA may provide remote access to VA specific systems/network in accordance with VA Handbook 6500, which requires the use of a VA approved method to connect external equipment/systems to VA's network. Citrix Access Gateway (CAG) and now the Azure Virtual Desktop (AVD) (as VA is currently transitioning from CAG to the AVD), are the current and only VA approved methods for remote access users when using or manipulating VA information for official VA Business. VA permits CAG remote access through approved Personally Owned Equipment (POE) and Other Equipment (OE) provided the equipment meets all applicable 6500 Handbook requirements for POE/OE. All of the security controls required for Government furnished equipment (GFE) must be utilized in approved POE or OE. The Contractor shall provide proof to the COR for review and approval that their POE or OE meets the VA Handbook 6500 requirements and VA Handbook 6500.6 Appendix C, herein incorporated as Addendum B, before use. CAG authorized users shall not be permitted to copy, print, or save any VA information accessed via CAG at any time. VA prohibits remote access to VA's network from non-North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) countries. The exception to this are countries where VA has approved operations established (e.g. Philippines and South Korea). Exceptions are determined by the COR in coordination with the Information System Security Officer (ISSO) and Privacy Officer (PO).

This remote access may provide access to VA specific software such as Veterans Health Information System and Technology Architecture (VistA), ClearQuest, PAL, Primavera, and Remedy, including appropriate seat management and user licenses, depending upon the level of access granted. The Contractor shall utilize government-provided software development and test accounts, documents, and requirements repositories, etc. as required for the development, storage, maintenance, and delivery of products within the scope of this effort. All VA sensitive information shall be protected at all times in accordance with VA Handbook 6500, local security field office System Security Plans (SSP) and Authority to Operate (ATO) for all systems/LAN's accessed while performing the tasks detailed in this PWS. The Contractor shall ensure all work is performed in countries deemed not to pose a significant security risk. For detailed Security and Privacy Requirements (additional requirements of the contract consolidated into an addendum for easy reference) refer to ADDENDUM A – ADDITIONAL VA REQUIREMENTS, CONSOLIDATED and ADDENDUM B - VA INFORMATION AND INFORMATION SYSTEM SECURITY/PRIVACY LANGUAGE.

7.7 GOVERNMENT FURNISHED PROPERTY

The Government has multiple remote access solutions available to include Citrix Access Gateway (CAG), Site-to-Site Virtual Private Network (VPN), and RESCUE VPN. The Government's issuance of Government Furnished Equipment (GFE) is limited to Contractor personnel requiring direct access to the network to: development environments; install, configure and run Technical Reference Model (TRM) approved

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software and tools (e.g., Oracle, Fortify, Eclipse, SoapUI, WebLogic, LoadRunner); upload/download/ manipulate code, run scripts, and apply patches; configure and change system settings; check logs, troubleshoot/debug, and test/QA.

When necessary, the Government will furnish desktops or laptops, for use by the Contractor to access VA networks, systems, or applications to meet the requirements of this PWS. The overarching goal is to determine the most cost-effective approach to providing needed access to the VA environment coupled with the need to ensure proper Change Management principles are followed. Contractor personnel shall adhere to all VA system access requirements for on-site and remote users in accordance with VA standards, local security regulations, policies, and rules of behavior. GFE shall be approved by the COR and Program Manager on a case-by-case basis prior to issuance.

Based upon the Government assessment of remote access solutions and requirements of this effort, the Government estimates that the following GFE will be required by this effort:

1. **<TBD at task order level>** laptops
2. **<TBD at task order level >** desktops.

The Government will not provide IT accessories including but not limited to Mobile Wi-Fi hotspots/wireless access points, additional or specialized keyboards or mice, laptop bags, extra charging cables, extra Personal Identity Verification card readers, peripheral devices, or additional Random Access Memory (RAM). The Contractor is responsible for providing these types of IT accessories in support of this effort as necessary and any VA installation required for these IT accessories shall be coordinated with the COR.

For implementations or migrations to the VAEC, the Government shall furnish Cloud capacity in and connectivity to the VAEC environments, VA Enterprise Cloud Operational Tools (VAECOT), comprised of a suite of COTS cloud management tools, and Enterprise Development Environment (EDE) and Tools as identified in the VAEC Technical Reference Guide.

Additionally, the Contractor shall provide a status of all reportable GFE as part of the monthly Status of GFE Report as required by PWS paragraph 7.6.1.2. For purposes of this report, reportable GFE includes equipment that is furnished by the Government as tangible "personal" property which the Contractor takes possession of, physically leaves a Government facility, and needs to be returned the end of Contractor performance. The following information shall be provided for each piece of GFE:

1. Name of Contractor employee assigned to the GFE
2. Type of Equipment (Make and Model)
3. Tracking Number/Serial Number
4. VA Bar Code
5. Location
6. Value

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7. Total Value of Equipment
8. Anticipated Transfer Date to Government
9. Anticipated Transfer Location

8.0 CONTRACT MANAGEMENT

8.1 CONTRACTOR PROGRAM MANAGEMENT

The Contractor shall establish a single management focal point, the Program Manager, to accomplish the administrative, managerial and financial aspects of this contract and all subsequent Task Orders. This individual shall be identified to the Contracting Officer as the focal point for all programmatic issues.

8.2 CONTACTING OFFICER'S REPRESENTATIVE (COR)

A COR shall be designated for the ID/IQ and each individual Task Order. The COR will be appointed by the Contracting Officer and duties delegated in an appointment letter. The COR is responsible for technical administration of the contract/order and shall assure proper Government surveillance of the Contractor's performance. The COR shall keep a quality assurance file. This file shall contain all quality assessment reports. The COR is not empowered to make any contractual commitments or to authorize any contractual changes on the Government's behalf.

8.3 PRE-AWARD PROCEDURES

8.3.1 REQUEST FOR TASK EXECUTION (RTEP) PROCESS

Upon identification of the need for a Task Order, a tracking number shall be assigned, and the Contracting Officer shall issue a RTEP to the Contractor. For Performance-Based tasks, the Government will specify requirements in terms of performance objectives. The Contractor shall propose "how to" best satisfy those objectives including proposed metrics to measure and evaluate performance. The Government's RTEP does NOT constitute an authorization to start work.

8.3.2 TASK EXECUTION PLAN (TEP)

Within seven business days of receipt of the RTEP, or unless otherwise specified in the RTEP, the Contractor shall submit one TEP IAW the format provided below unless otherwise specified by the Contractor Officer. The following information shall be provided and submitted to VA:

- A. In addition to the information requested in the RTEP, the following shall be addressed in every TEP:
 1. Proposal Summary Volume including:
 - a. Task number
 - b. Date submitted
 - c. Contractor's name
 - d. Contractor task leader contact information for questions
 - e. Subcontractor(s) and vendors shall be identified by name at all tiers (as applicable)

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- f. Proposed start and finish dates
 - g. Proposed total price
 - h. Offerors are hereby advised that any Offeror-imposed terms and conditions which deviate from the Government's material terms and conditions established by the RTEP, may render the Offeror's proposal Unacceptable, and thus ineligible for award.
 - i. If applicable, FAR 52.244-2 Subcontracts shall be addressed
 - j. Duration for which proposal is valid (minimum 90 days)
 - k. VA Acquisition Regulation (VAAR) 852.209-70 is in effect for all RTEPs issued and the contractor should provide a statement IAW VAAR 852.209-70(b), when applicable
 - l. Acknowledgement of Amendments.
 - m. FAR 52.209-5 "Certification Regarding Responsibility Matters" applies for all issued RTEPS. The Contractor shall provide representation within the Summary Volume of its TEP.
 - 2. If applicable to a specific Task Order, Service Contract Act shall be considered in the Offeror's price proposal volume which shall be submitted in Microsoft Excel spreadsheet format. The first tab shall be a summary to include a top-level rollup of the total dollars and percentages by labor, materials, travel, ODCs, and total Task Order price. Labor shall further be broken out by labor categories, labor rates, and hours. A separate tab shall be used for the Prime and each Subcontractor.
 - 3. The Contractor shall submit a completed Section B including all priced line items for the base period and any options.
 - 4. Contractors are hereby advised that any Pricing Assumptions which deviate from the Government's requirements or material terms and conditions established by the RTEP, may render the Offeror's proposal Unacceptable, and thus ineligible for award.
 - 5. The Offeror shall submit a draft Small Business Participation Report, to include identification of subcontractors, socio-economic categories, and estimated dollar values.
- B. The following pertains to the preparation and submission of all TEPs:
- 1. TEP Format
 - a. Proposal Summary
 - i. Microsoft Word or PDF format
 - b. Technical Volume
 - i. Microsoft Word or PDF format
 - ii. No marketing materials; information relevant to the requirement only
 - c. Price
 - i. Shall be provided in Microsoft Excel
 - ii. All Prime and Subcontractor Labor costs, Material costs, Travel, and ODCs must be broken out
 - (a) (MS Excel) Summary Tab for Price roll-up, and separate Tabs for Base Period and any Option
 - (b) Separate tabs for Subcontractor(s)

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8.3.3 TEP EVALUATION

The goal is to evaluate TEP submittals within 12 business days of receipt. Questions and clarifications may be required which can prolong the evaluation period. When requested by the Contracting Officer, the Contractor shall provide a revised TEP to address changes.

8.4 ISSUANCE OF TASK ORDERS

Upon Government approval of the TEP and designation of an appropriate fund cite, the Contracting Officer shall issue a Task Order to the Contractor. Contractor work shall commence only after issuance of the Task Order by the Contracting Officer.

8.5 POST AWARD PROCEDURES

8.5.1 REQUEST FOR POST AWARD ACTION

Upon identification of the need for a modification to a Task Order, the Government shall issue a Request for Post Award Action, designated by an action number, to the Contractor. The Contracting Officer shall designate individuals authorized to issue such requests upon Task Order award, in writing. The Contractor shall respond to requests from these authorized individuals only. All Contractor correspondence shall reference the Government designated action number. The Government's Request for Post Award Action does NOT constitute an authorization to start work. A Request for Post Award action may include but not be limited to cost and no cost changes, period of performance extensions, within scope changes, shipping or inspections changes.

8.5.2 REVISED TEP FOR POST AWARD ACTIONS

Within seven business days of receipt of the Request for Post Award Action, the Contractor shall submit a Revised TEP, IAW the format defined in Section 7.3.2.

8.5.3 POST AWARD ACTION APPROVAL

The goal is to approve each Revised TEP within five business days of receipt. The Government shall either approve the TEP or enter discussions as soon as practical after TEP receipt. When requested, the Contractor shall provide an updated TEP to address the results of such discussions.

8.6 REPORTING AND MEETING REQUIREMENTS

8.6.1 REPORTING REQUIREMENTS

The Contractor shall use VA's implementation of the Jira, GitHub or other VA approved toolset to provide a single Agile project/product lifecycle management tool to track execution details. The VA approved toolset Project/Product Data and Artifact Repository will be used to provide a single authoritative project and product data and artifact repository. All project data and artifacts will be required to be managed in this data and artifact repository daily. All checked out artifacts shall be checked back in daily and any data updated daily. VA approved toolset synchronizes all changed

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information immediately for all team members to access work proficiently without the concern of working on aged information.

The Contractor shall utilize the VA approved toolset to:

2. Input and manage scheduled project/product sprints and backlog
3. Input and manage project/product Agile requirements
4. Input and manage project/product risks and issues
5. Input and manage project/product configurations and changes
6. Input and manage project/product test plans and execution
7. Input and manage project/product planning and engineering documentation
8. Input and manage project/product user guides and training materials
9. Input and manage linkages to correlate requirements to change orders to configurable items to risks, impediments, and issues to test cases and test results to show full traceability.
10. Input and manage policies, processes, procedures, and guidance.
11. Input and manage governance, knowledge management, lessons learned.
12. Input and manage High Reliability Organization (HRO) products in support of HRO principles.
13. Input and manage Change Management products and activities (e.g. pre and post training surveys).

The Contractor shall show all Agile requirements, changes, tests performed and test results in the VA approved toolset to show evidence of code coverage and test coverage of all the requirements specified. This expectation will allow VA to have high confidence in a fully documented, requirements traceability matrix, as evidenced by data in the tools.

8.6.1.1 MONTHLY PROGRESS REPORT

The Contractor shall submit a Monthly Progress Report for each Task Order awarded. These reports shall convey the status of the Task Order performance. Task orders that are completed shall be listed as such. A standard format will be provided by VA and shall be utilized for submission of the below required information. The Task Order report shall be unique to that Task Order only.

The Monthly Progress Reports shall cover all work completed during the reporting period and work planned for the subsequent reporting period. The report shall also identify any problems that arose and a description of how the problems were resolved. If problems have not been completely resolved, the Contractor shall provide an explanation including their plan and timeframe for resolving the issue. The report shall also include an itemized list of all Information and Communication Technology (ICT) deliverables and their current Section 508 conformance status. The Contractor shall monitor performance against the CPMP and report any deviations. It is expected that the Contractor shall keep in communication with VA accordingly so that issues that arise are transparent to both parties to prevent escalation of outstanding issues.

A For Each Task Order, indicate/discuss:

1. Task Order summary

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2. Performance metrics
3. Task Order schedule
4. Major Program VIP Compliance (as applicable)
5. List of software delivered and in operation
6. Critical items for Government review
7. Accomplishments
8. An itemized listing of all ICT deliverables and their current Section 508 conformance status
9. Significant open issues, risk and mitigation action
10. Summary of issues closed
11. Meetings completed
12. Projected meetings
13. Subcontractor performance – discuss first tier Subcontractor(s) performance
14. Projected activities for next reporting period
15. Explanation if the reporting period is over one month
16. Invoice/receiving report submitted
17. Milestone payment schedule
18. Automated bill of materials in data base format
19. Continuous Monitoring report for all cloud services and applications

B. General and Cumulative Performance. Indicate the following:

1. Any general meetings that occurred with Government representatives during the reporting period
2. Total dollars awarded to date (ceiling)
3. Total dollars invoiced to date, by fiscal year, and since contract award

C. Performance Metrics

1. Schedule Performance to Plan
2. Monthly System Uptime
3. Incident Report
 - a. Root Cause Analysis
 - b. Event Update
 - c. After Action Update
4. Disaster Recovery Report

The Contractor shall provide a Monthly Progress Report at the basic contract level that provides a roll up of each Task Order.

8.6.1.2 STATUS OF GOVERNMENT FURNISHED EQUIPMENT (GFE) REPORT

The Contractor shall submit a Monthly Status of GFE Report for each Task Order. This Task Order report shall be unique to each Task Order.

- A. Task Order Number
- B. Project Name
- C. Employee Name
- D. Type of Equipment

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- E. Tracking Number
- F. VA Bar Code
- G. Location
- H. Value
- I. Total Number of Pieces
- J. Total Value of Equipment
- K. Anticipated Transfer Date to Government
- L. Anticipated Transfer Location

The Contractor shall provide a Monthly Status of GFE Report at the basic contract level that provides a roll up of each Task Order.

8.6.1.3 PERSONNEL CONTRACTOR MANPOWER REPORT

The Contractor shall provide a Monthly Personnel Contractor Manpower Report in MS Excel, listing all personnel for each Task Order. This report shall be provided at the basic contract level only. The report shall include a separate tab for each Task Order. The information contained on each tab shall be unique to the individual Task Order. The information required is as follows:

- A. Task Order Number
- B. Employee Name
- C. Background Investigation/Clearance level and/or Status
- D. Company name
- E. Prime/Subcontractor
- F. Labor Category
- G. Facility location
- H. Universal Unique Identifier (UUID) (Badge Number bottom right of back of badge)
- I. Facility where badge was issued
- J. Badge Expiration Date
- K. Project supporting
- L. Tour of Duty Schedule
- M. Date Disassociated from Contract (for employees who no longer support this contract)
- N. Date Badge Returned to Task Order COR
- O. Contractor Rules of Behavior
- P. VA Cyber Security Awareness and Rules of Behavior Training
- Q. Annual VA Privacy Training

8.6.1.4 CONTRACTOR STAFF ROSTER

The Contractor shall provide a Contractor Staff Roster of Contractor and Subcontractor employees within thirty business days after initial Task Order award. The Contractor Staff Roster shall be provided at the Task Order level only. The Contractor Staff Roster shall identify all personnel employed under each Task Order to begin their background investigations. As personnel changes occur a revised roster is required. The Contractor Staff Roster shall be updated and delivered only to the applicable Task

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Order's COR within five days of any changes in employee status, training certification completion status, Background Investigation level status, additions/removal of employees, etc., throughout the PoP. The Contractor Staff Roster shall remain a historical document indicating all past information and which employees are active or inactive. For inactive employees, the roster should indicate the date the employee was separated from the Task Order and their credentials returned to the Task Order COR.

The Contractor Staff Roster shall contain:

- A. Contractor's Full Name
- B. Email Address
- C. Place of Birth
- D. Date of Birth
- E. Security/Privacy Training Completion Dates
- F. Risk Designation-individual background investigation level requirement (Refer to Section 4.6 of the Task Order PWS for investigative requirements by task)
- G. Existing Background Investigation and/or Clearance (if applicable)
- H. The Contractor shall submit full Social Security Numbers either within the Contractor Staff Roster or under separate cover to the Task Order COR. The preferred method to send the Contractor Staff Roster or Social Security Number is by encrypted e-mail. If unable to send encrypted e-mail, other methods which comply with FIPS 140-2 are to encrypt the file, use a secure fax, or use a traceable mail service.

8.6.1.5 SMALL BUSINESS PARTICIPATION REPORT

The Contractor shall submit the Small Business Participation Report, using the VA-provided template, on a quarterly basis. The Small Business Participation Report shall be provided at the basic contract level only.

8.6.1.6 VETERANS EMPLOYMENT CERTIFICATION REPORT

The Contractor shall provide a Veterans Employment Certification Report, on a quarterly basis listing the following:

- a. Total number of employees at time of proposal submission
- b. Total number of Veterans employed at time of proposal submission
- c. Total number of current employees
- d. Total number of current Veterans employed

The Contractor's Chief Executive Officer (CEO), or equivalent, shall certify in the Veterans Employment Certification Report that the that the Contractor has, in good faith, relied on the representations of its employees to derive the total number of employees and the number of Veterans that it employs.

8.7 MEETINGS AND REVIEWS

For successful management and contract surveillance, the following meetings and reviews are required.

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8.7.1 IDIQ CONTRACT KICKOFF

The Government intends to convene a Post-Award Conference within 30 days after contract award. The CO shall notify the Contractor of a specific date, location and agenda within 10 days after contract award.

8.7.2 TASK ORDER KICKOFF MEETINGS

As required by the designated COR, and CO, a kickoff meeting may be held on the Task Order level after award. Dates, locations, and agenda shall be specified at least five calendar days prior to the meeting.

8.7.3 PROGRAM REVIEWS

At the discretion of the CO, Program Review Meetings shall be conducted by the VA TAC Contract Specialist and/or designated COR. Dates, locations, agenda, and attendance requirements shall be specified by the appropriate Government representative, at least five calendar days prior to the meeting.

8.8 COMMUNICATIONS

The Contractor shall adhere to the following regarding the Public Release of Information:

14. VA is the public release approval authority for any Contractor or associated sub-contractor requests for release of public information related to VA's IMM program.
- a) Public release for purposes of this contract is defined as new, unreleased information in press releases, fact sheets, web/online stories or blogs, speeches and industry presentations to either external audiences or VA internal audiences.
15. The Contractor shall coordinate with and gain approval of VA through the VA IMM program office before releasing any new public information by the Contractor and/or any sub-contractor associated with the VA IMM program
- b) The Contractor and associated sub-contractors shall follow release of public information protocols and processes as determined by VA (the customer).
16. VA will coordinate, when possible, with the Contractor regarding the VA's public release of information relating to VA's IMM program that is significant in nature and would likely result in media inquiry.

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A – ADDITIONAL VA REQUIREMENTS, CONSOLIDATED

A1.0 Cyber and Information Security Requirements for VA IT Services

The Contractor shall ensure adequate LAN/Internet, data, information, and system security in accordance with VA standard operating procedures and standard PWS language, conditions, laws, and regulations. The Contractor's firewall and web server shall meet or exceed VA minimum requirements for security. All VA data shall be protected behind an approved firewall. Any security violations or attempted violations shall be reported to the VA Program Manager and VA Information Security Officer as soon as possible. The Contractor shall follow all applicable VA policies and procedures governing information security, especially those that pertain to assessment and authorization and continuous monitoring.

Contractor supplied equipment, PCs of all types, equipment with hard drives, etc. for contract services must meet all security requirements that apply to Government Furnished Equipment (GFE) and Government Owned Equipment (GOE). Security Requirements include: a) VA Approved Encryption Software must be installed on all laptops or mobile devices before being placed into operation, b) Bluetooth equipped devices are prohibited within VA; Bluetooth must be permanently disabled or removed from the device, unless the connection uses FIPS 140-2 (or its successor) validated encryption, c) VA approved anti-virus and firewall software, d) Equipment must meet all VA sanitization requirements and procedures before disposal. The Contractor shall notify the COR/CO within one hour of disclosure or successful exploits of any vulnerability which can compromise the confidentiality, integrity, or availability of the information systems.

Each documented initiative under this contract incorporates VA Handbook 6500.6, "Contract Security," March 12, 2010 (Appendix C updated April 22, 2024) by reference as though fully set forth therein. The VA Handbook 6500.6, "Contract Security" shall also be included in every related agreement, contract, or order. The VA Handbook 6500.6, Appendix C, is included in this document as Addendum B.

Training requirements: The Contractor shall complete all mandatory training courses on the current VA training site, the VA Talent Management System (TMS) 2.0, and will be tracked therein. The TMS 2.0 may be accessed at <https://www.tms.va.gov/SecureAuth35/>. If you do not have a TMS 2.0 profile, go to <https://www.tms.va.gov/SecureAuth35/> and click on the "Create New User" link on the TMS 2.0 to gain access.

Contractor employees shall complete a VA Systems Access Agreement if they are provided access privileges as an authorized user of the computer system of VA.

A2.0 VA Enterprise Architecture Compliance

The applications, supplies, and services furnished under this contract must comply with VA Enterprise Architecture (EA), available at <http://www.ea.oit.va.gov/index.asp> in force at the time of issuance of this contract, including the Program Management Plan and VA's rules, standards, and guidelines in the Technical Reference Model/Standards

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Profile (TRMSP). VA reserves the right to assess contract deliverables for EA compliance prior to acceptance.

A2.1. VA Internet and Intranet Standards

The Contractor shall adhere to and comply with VA Directive 6102 and VA's Web Governance if the Contractor's work includes building and maintaining VA's digital presence. This pertains, but is not limited to: websites, social media, creating announcements; collecting information; databases to be accessed, graphics and links to external sites.

Internet/Intranet Services Directive 6102 is posted at (copy and paste the following URL to browser): https://www.va.gov/vapubs/viewPublication.asp?Pub_ID=1056&FType=2

VA Web Governance website can be found at [Home - VA Web Governance](#).

A3.0 Notice of the Federal Accessibility Law Affecting All Information and Communication Technology (ICT) Procurements (Section 508)

On January 18, 2017, the Access Board issued a final rule that updated accessibility requirements covered by Section 508 and refreshed guidelines for telecommunications equipment subject to Section 255 of the Communications Act. The final rule went into effect on January 18, 2018. The revisions and updates to the Section 508-based standards and Section 255-based guidelines are intended to ensure that information and communication technology (ICT) covered by the respective statutes is accessible to and usable by individuals with disabilities.

A3.1. Section 508 – Information and Communication Technology (ICT) Standards

The Section 508 standards established by the Access Board are incorporated into, and made part of all VA orders, solicitations and purchase orders developed to procure ICT. These standards are found in their entirety at: [Revised 508 Standards and 255 Guidelines \(access-board.gov\)](#). A single PDF file version of the Revised Section 508 Standards and 255 Guidelines will be supplied upon request, or can be obtained from the Access Board website. Federal agencies must comply with the Rehabilitation Act of 1973, as amended.

The Contractor shall comply with "508 Chapter 2: Scoping Requirements" for all electronic ICT and content delivered under this contract. Specifically, as appropriate for the technology and its functionality, the Contractor shall comply with the technical standards marked here:

- ☒ E205 Electronic Content – (Accessibility Standard -WCAG 2.0 Level A and AA Guidelines)
- ☒ E204 Functional Performance Criteria
- ☒ E206 Hardware Requirements
- ☒ E207 Software Requirements
- ☒ E208 Support Documentation and Services Requirements

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A3.2. Compatibility with Assistive Technology

The standards do not require installation of specific accessibility-related software or attachment of an assistive technology device. Section 508 requires that ICT be compatible with such software and devices so that ICT can be accessible to and usable by individuals using assistive technology, including but not limited to screen readers, screen magnifiers, and speech recognition software.

A3.3. Acceptance and Acceptance Testing

Deliverables resulting from this solicitation will be accepted based in part on satisfaction of the Section 508 Chapter 2: Scoping Requirements standards identified above.

The Government reserves the right to test for Section 508 Compliance before delivery. The Contractor shall be able to demonstrate Section 508 Compliance upon delivery.

A4.0 Physical Security & Safety Requirements:

The Contractor and their personnel shall follow all VA policies, standard operating procedures, applicable laws and regulations while on VA property. Violations of VA regulations and policies may result in citation and disciplinary measures for persons violating the law.

1. The Contractor and their personnel shall wear visible identification at all times while they are on the premises.
2. VA does not provide parking spaces at the work site; the Contractor must obtain parking at the work site if needed. It is the responsibility of the Contractor to park in the appropriate designated parking areas. VA will not invalidate or make reimbursement for parking violations of the Contractor under any conditions.
3. Smoking is prohibited inside/outside any building other than the designated smoking areas.
4. Possession of weapons is prohibited.
5. The Contractor shall obtain all necessary licenses and/or permits required to perform the work, with the exception of software licenses that need to be procured from a Contractor or vendor in accordance with the requirements document. The Contractor shall take all reasonable precautions necessary to protect persons and property from injury or damage during the performance of this contract.

A5.0 Confidentiality and Non-Disclosure

The Contractor shall follow all VA rules and regulations regarding information security to prevent disclosure of sensitive information to unauthorized individuals or organizations.

The Contractor may have access to Protected Health Information (PHI) and Electronic Protected Health Information (ePHI) that is subject to protection under the regulations issued by the Department of Health and Human Services, as mandated by the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act of 1996 (HIPAA); 45 CFR Parts 160 and 164, Subparts A and E, the Standards for Privacy of Individually Identifiable Health Information ("Privacy Rule"); and 45 CFR Parts 160 and 164, Subparts A and C, the

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Security Standard ("Security Rule"). Pursuant to the Privacy and Security Rules, the Contractor must agree in writing to certain mandatory provisions regarding the use and disclosure of PHI and ePHI.

1. The Contractor will have access to some privileged and confidential materials of VA. These printed and electronic documents are for internal use only, are not to be copied or released without permission, and remain the sole property of VA. Some of these materials are protected by the Privacy Act of 1974 (revised by PL 93-5791) and Title 38. Unauthorized disclosure of Privacy Act or Title 38 covered materials is a criminal offense.
2. The VA CO will be the sole authorized official to release in writing, any data, draft deliverables, final deliverables, or any other written or printed materials pertaining to this contract. The Contractor shall release no information. Any request for information relating to this contract presented to the Contractor shall be submitted to the VA CO for response.
3. Contractor personnel recognize that in the performance of this effort, Contractor personnel may receive or have access to sensitive information, including information provided on a proprietary basis by carriers, equipment manufacturers and other private or public entities. Contractor personnel agree to safeguard such information and use the information exclusively in the performance of this contract. Contractor shall follow all VA rules and regulations regarding information security to prevent disclosure of sensitive information to unauthorized individuals or organizations as enumerated in this section and elsewhere in this Contract and its subparts and appendices.
4. Contractor shall limit access to the minimum number of personnel necessary for contract performance for all information considered sensitive or proprietary in nature. If the Contractor is uncertain of the sensitivity of any information obtained during the performance this contract, the Contractor has a responsibility to ask the VA CO.
5. Contractor shall train all of their employees involved in the performance of this contract on their roles and responsibilities for proper handling and nondisclosure of sensitive VA or proprietary information. Contractor personnel shall not engage in any other action, venture or employment wherein sensitive information shall be used for the profit of any party other than those furnishing the information. The sensitive information transferred, generated, transmitted, or stored herein is for VA benefit and ownership alone.
6. Contractor shall maintain physical security at all facilities housing the activities performed under this contract, including any Contractor facilities according to VA-approved guidelines and directives. The Contractor shall ensure that security procedures are defined and enforced to ensure all personnel who are provided access to patient data must comply with published procedures to protect the privacy and confidentiality of such information as required by VA.
7. Contractor must adhere to the following:

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- a. The use of “thumb drives” or any other medium for transport of information is expressly prohibited.
 - b. Controlled access to system and security software and documentation.
 - c. Recording, monitoring, and control of passwords and privileges.
 - d. All terminated personnel are denied physical and electronic access to all data, program listings, data processing equipment and systems.
 - e. VA, as well as any Contractor (or Subcontractor) systems used to support development, provide the capability to cancel immediately all access privileges and authorizations upon employee termination.
 - f. Contractor PM and VA PM are informed within twenty-four (24) hours of any employee termination.
 - g. Acquisition sensitive information shall be marked "Acquisition Sensitive" and shall be handled as "For Official Use Only (FOUO)".
 - h. Contractor does not require access to classified data.
8. Regulatory standard of conduct governs all personnel directly and indirectly involved in procurements. All personnel engaged in procurement and related activities shall conduct business in a manner above reproach and, except as authorized by statute or regulation, with complete impartiality and with preferential treatment for none. The general rule is to strictly avoid any conflict of interest or even the appearance of a conflict of interest in VA/Contractor relationships.
9. VA Form 0752 shall be completed by all Contractor employees working on this contract and shall be provided to the CO before any work is performed. In the case that Contractor personnel are replaced in the future, their replacements shall complete VA Form 0752 prior to beginning work.

A6.0 Information Technology Using Sustainable Products

The Contractor shall comply with Sections 524 and Sections 525 of the Energy Independence and Security Act of 2007; Section 104 of the Energy Policy Act of 2005; Executive Order 14148, “Initial Rescissions of Harmful Executive Orders and Actions,” dated January 20, 2005; Executive Order 13221, “Energy-Efficient Standby Power Devices,” dated August 2, 2001; and the Revolutionary Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) Overhaul (RFO) to provide ENERGY STAR® certified and Federal Energy Management Program (FEMP) Designated Low Standby Power information technology products, see <https://www.energy.gov/femp/search-energy-efficient-products>. See <http://www.energystar.gov> for complete product specifications and updated lists of Energy Star certified products. FEMP low standby power product listing can be found at <https://www.energy.gov/femp/low-standby-power-product-list>.

The Contractor shall provide products that meet the definition of sustainable products if the products are delivered to the Government; furnished by the Contractor for use by the Government, incorporated into the construction of a public building or public work, or acquired by the Contractor for use in performing services under a Government contract where the cost of the products is a direct cost to a Government contract (versus costs

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which are normally applied to a contractor's general and administrative expenses or indirect costs).

Specifically, the Contractor shall provide sustainable products under this contract in accordance with RFO 52.223-23 (NOV 2025). The applicable products with their associated certification and/or designation required (e.g. Energy Star, FEMP Low Standby Power) are identified within the product requirements specifications in this PWS. The Contractor shall self-certify that its proposed products meet the certification(s) and/or designation(s) specified.

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**ADDENDUM B – VA INFORMATION AND INFORMATION SYSTEM SECURITY/
PRIVACY LANGUAGE**

NOTE: In the event of a conflict, VA Acquisition Regulation (VAAR) Security Clauses take precedence over the language in this Addendum B.

APPLICABLE SECTIONS TAILORED FROM: VA NOTICE 24-12, APRIL 22, 2024, UPDATE TO VA HANDBOOK 6500.6, CONTRACT SECURITY, APPENDIX C VA INFORMATION AND INFORMATION SYSTEM SECURITY/PRIVACY LANGUAGE, FOR INCLUSION INTO CONTRACTS, AS APPROPRIATE

B1. GENERAL

This entire section applies to all acquisitions requiring any Information Security and Privacy language. Contractors, contractor personnel, Subcontractors and subcontractor personnel will be subject to the same federal laws, regulations, standards, VA directives and handbooks, as VA personnel regarding information and information system security and privacy.

B2. VA INFORMATION CUSTODIAL LANGUAGE

- a. The Government shall receive unlimited rights to data/intellectual property first produced and delivered in the performance of this contract or order (hereinafter “contract”) unless expressly stated otherwise in this contract. This includes all rights to source code and all documentation created in support thereof. The primary clause used to define Government and Contractor data rights is FAR 52.227-14 Rights in Data – General.
- b. Information made available to the Contractor by VA for the performance or administration of this contract will be used only for the purposes specified in the service agreement, SOW, PWS, PD, and/or contract. The Contractor shall not use VA information in any other manner without prior written approval from a VA Contracting Officer (CO). The primary clause used to define Government and Contractor data rights is FAR 52.227-14 Rights in Data – General.
- c. VA information will not be co-mingled with any other data on the Contractor’s information systems or media storage systems. The Contractor shall ensure compliance with Federal and VA requirements related to data protection, data encryption, physical data segregation, logical data segregation, classification requirements and media sanitization.
- d. VA reserves the right to conduct scheduled or unscheduled audits, assessments, or investigations of Contractor Information Technology (IT) resources to ensure information security is compliant with Federal and VA requirements. The Contractor shall provide all necessary access to records (including electronic and documentary materials related to the contracts and subcontracts) and support (including access to Contractor and Subcontractor staff associated with the

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contract) to VA, VA's Office Inspector General (OIG), and/or Government Accountability Office (GAO) staff during periodic control assessments, audits, or investigations.

- e. The Contractor may only use VA information within the terms of the contract and applicable Federal law, regulations, and VA policies. If new Federal information security laws, regulations or VA policies become applicable after execution of the contract, the parties agree to negotiate contract modification and adjustment necessary to implement the new laws, regulations, and/or policies.
- f. The Contractor shall not make copies of VA information except as specifically authorized and necessary to perform the terms of the contract. If copies are made for restoration purposes, after the restoration is complete, the copies shall be destroyed in accordance with VA Directive 6500, VA Cybersecurity Program and VA Information Security Knowledge Service.
- g. If a Veterans Health Administration (VHA) contract is terminated for default or cause with a business associate, the related local Business Associate Agreement (BAA) shall also be terminated and actions taken in accordance with VHA Directive 1605.05, Business Associate Agreements. If there is an executed national BAA associated with the contract, VA will determine what actions are appropriate and notify the contractor.
- h. The Contractor shall store and transmit VA sensitive information in an encrypted form, using VA-approved encryption tools which are, at a minimum, Federal Information Processing Standards (FIPS) 140-2, Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules (or its successor) validated and in conformance with VA Information Security Knowledge Service requirements. The Contractor shall transmit VA sensitive information using VA approved Transport Layer Security (TLS) configured with FIPS based cipher suites in conformance with National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) 800-52, Guidelines for the Selection, Configuration and Use of Transport Layer Security (TLS) Implementations.
- i. The Contractor's firewall and web services security controls, as applicable, shall meet or exceed VA's minimum requirements.
- j. Except for uses and disclosures of VA information authorized by this contract for performance of the contract, the Contractor may use and disclose VA information only in two situations: (i) in response to a qualifying order of a court of competent jurisdiction after notification to VA CO (ii) with written approval from the VA CO. The Contractor shall refer all requests for, demands for production of or inquiries about, VA information and information systems to the VA CO for response.
- k. Notwithstanding the provision above, the Contractor shall not release VA records protected by Title 38 U.S.C. § 5705, Confidentiality of medical quality-assurance

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records and/or Title 38 U.S.C. § 7332, Confidentiality of certain medical records pertaining to drug addiction, sickle cell anemia, alcoholism or alcohol abuse or infection with Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV). If the Contractor is in receipt of a court order or other requests for the above-mentioned information, the Contractor shall immediately refer such court order or other requests to the VA CO for response.

- l. Information made available to the Contractor by VA for the performance or administration of this contract or information developed by the Contractor in performance or administration of the contract will be protected and secured in accordance with VA Directive 6500 and Identity and Access Management (IAM) Security processes specified in the VA Information Security Knowledge Service.
- m. Any data destruction done on behalf of VA by a Contractor shall be done in accordance with National Archives and Records Administration (NARA) requirements as outlined in VA Directive 6300, Records and Information Management, VA Handbook 6300.1, Records Management Procedures, and applicable VA Records Control Schedules.
- n. The Contractor shall provide its plan for destruction of all VA data in its possession according to VA Directive 6500 and NIST 800-88, Guidelines for Media Sanitization prior to termination or completion of this contract. If directed by the COR/CO, the Contractor shall return all Federal Records to VA for disposition.
- o. Any media, such as paper, magnetic tape, magnetic disks, solid state devices or optical discs that is used to store, process, or access VA information that cannot be destroyed shall be returned to VA. The Contractor shall hold the appropriate material until otherwise directed by the Contracting Officer's Representative (COR) or CO. Items shall be returned securely via VA-approved methods. VA sensitive information must be transmitted utilizing VA-approved encryption tools which are validated under FIPS 140-2 (or its successor) and NIST 800-52. If mailed, the Contractor shall send via a trackable method (USPS, UPS, FedEx, etc.) and immediately provide the COR/CO with the tracking information. Self-certification by the Contractor that the data destruction requirements above have been met shall be sent to the COR/CO within 30 business days of termination of the contract.
- p. All electronic storage media (hard drives, optical disks, CDs, back-up tapes, etc.) used to store, process or access VA information will not be returned to the Contractor at the end of lease, loan, or trade-in. Exceptions to this paragraph will only be granted with the written approval of the VA CO.

B3. ACCESS TO VA INFORMATION AND VA INFORMATION SYSTEMS

- a. A Contractor/Subcontractor shall request logical (technical) or physical access to VA information and VA information systems for their employees and

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subcontractors only to the extent necessary to perform the services specified in the solicitation or contract. This includes indirect entities, both affiliate of Contractor/Subcontractor and agent of Contractor/Subcontractor.

- b. Contractors and subcontractors shall sign the VA Information Security Rule of Behavior (ROB) before access is provided to VA information and information systems (see Section 4, Training, below). The ROB contains the minimum user compliance requirements and does not supersede any policies of VA facilities or other agency components which provide higher levels of protection to VA's information or information systems. Users who require privileged access shall complete the VA elevated privilege access request processes before privileged access is granted.
- c. All Contractors and Subcontractors working with VA information are subject to the same security investigative and clearance requirements as those of VA appointees or employees who have access to the same types of information. The level and process of background security investigations for contractors shall be in accordance with VA Directive and Handbook 0710, Personnel Vetting Program. The Office of Human Resources and Administration/Operations, Security and Preparedness (HRA/OSP) is responsible for these policies and procedures. Contract personnel who require access to classified information or information systems shall have an appropriate security clearance. Verification of a Security Clearance shall be processed through the Special Security Officer located in HRA/OSP. Contractors shall conform to all requirements stated in the National Industrial Security Program Operating Manual (NISPOM).
- d. All Contractors and subcontractors shall comply with conditions specified in VAAR 852.204-71(d); Contractor operations required to be in United States. All Contractors and Subcontractors working with VA information must be permanently located within a jurisdiction subject to the law of the United States or its Territories to the maximum extent feasible. If services are proposed to be performed abroad the Contractor must state where all non-U.S. services are provided. The Contractor shall deliver to VA a detailed plan specifically addressing communications, personnel control, data protection and potential legal issues. The plan shall be approved by the COR/CO in writing prior to access being granted.
- e. The Contractor shall notify the COR/CO in writing immediately (no later than 24 hours) after personnel separation or occurrence of other causes. Causes may include the following:
 - (1) Contractor/Subcontractor personnel no longer has a need for access to VA information or VA information systems.
 - (2) Contractor/Subcontractor personnel are terminated, suspended, or otherwise has their work on a VA project discontinued for any reason.

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- (3) Contractor believes their own personnel or Subcontractor personnel may pose a threat to their company's working environment or to any company-owned property. This includes Contractor-owned assets, buildings, confidential data, customers, employees, networks, systems, trade secrets and/or VA data.
 - (4) Any previously undisclosed changes to Contractor/Subcontractor background history are brought to light, including but not limited to changes to background investigation or employee record.
 - (5) Contractor/Subcontractor personnel have their authorization to work in the United States revoked.
 - (6) Agreement by which Contractor provides products and services to VA has either been fulfilled or terminated, such that VA can cut off electronic and/or physical access for Contractor personnel.
- f. In such cases of contract fulfillment, termination, or other causes; the Contractor shall take the necessary measures to immediately revoke access to VA network, property, information, and information systems (logical and physical) by Contractor/Subcontractor personnel. These measures include (but are not limited to): removing and then securing Personal Identity Verification (PIV) badges and PIV – Interoperable (PIV-I) access badges, VA-issued photo badges, credentials for VA facilities and devices, VA-issued laptops, and authentication tokens. Contractors shall notify the appropriate VA COR/CO immediately to initiate access removal.
- g. Contractors/Subcontractors who no longer require VA accesses will return VA-issued property to VA. This property includes (but is not limited to): documents, electronic equipment, keys, and parking passes. PIV and PIV-I access badges shall be returned to the nearest VA PIV Badge Issuance Office. Once they have had access to VA information, information systems, networks and VA property in their possessions removed, Contractors shall notify the appropriate VA COR/CO.

B4. TRAINING

All contractors and subcontractors requiring access to VA information and VA information systems shall successfully complete the following before being granted access to VA information and its systems:

- (1) VA Privacy and Information Security Awareness and Rules of Behavior course (Talent Management System (TMS) #10176) initially and annually thereafter.
- (2) Sign and acknowledge (electronically through TMS #10176) understanding of and responsibilities for compliance with the

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Organizational Rules of Behavior, relating to access to VA information and information systems initially and annually thereafter; and

- (3) Successfully complete any additional cyber security or privacy training, as required for VA personnel with equivalent information system or information access [to be defined by the VA program official and provided to the VA CO for inclusion in the solicitation document – i.e., any role-based information security training].
- b. The Contractor shall provide to the COR/CO a copy of the training certificates and certification of signing the Organizational Rules of Behavior for each applicable employee within five days of the initiation of the contract and annually thereafter, as required.
- c. Failure to complete the mandatory annual training is grounds for suspension or termination of all physical or electronic access privileges and removal from work on the contract until such time as the required training is complete.

B5. SECURITY INCIDENT INVESTIGATION

- a. The Contractor, Subcontractor, their employees, or business associates shall immediately (within one hour) report suspected security / privacy incidents to the VA OIT's Enterprise Service Desk (ESD) by calling (855) 673-4357 (TTY: 711). The ESD is OIT's 24/7/365 single point of contact for IT-related issues. After reporting to the ESD, the Contractor, Subcontractor, their employees, or business associates shall, within one hour, provide the COR/CO the incident number received from the ESD.
- b. To the extent known by the Contractor/Subcontractor, the Contractor/Subcontractor's notice to VA shall identify the information involved and the circumstances surrounding the incident, including the following:
 - (1) The date and time (or approximation of) the Security Incident occurred.
 - (2) The names of individuals involved (when applicable).
 - (3) The physical and logical (if applicable) location of the incident.
 - (4) Why the Security Incident took place (i.e., catalyst for the failure).
 - (5) The amount of data belonging to VA believed to have been compromised.
 - (6) The remediation measures the Contractor is taking to ensure no future incidents of a similar nature.
- c. After the Contractor has provided the initial detailed incident summary to VA, they will continue to provide written updates on any new and relevant

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circumstances or facts they discover. The Contractor, Subcontractor, and their employees shall fully cooperate with VA or third-party entity performing an independent risk analysis on behalf of VA. Failure to cooperate may be deemed a material breach and grounds for contract termination.

- d. VA IT Contractors shall follow VA Handbook 6500, Risk Management Framework for VA Information Systems VA Information Security Program, and VA Information Security Knowledge Service guidance for implementing an Incident Response Plan or integrating with an existing VA implementation.
- e. In instances of theft or break-in or other criminal activity, the Contractor/Subcontractor must concurrently report the incident to the appropriate law enforcement entity (or entities) of jurisdiction, including the VA OIG, and the VA Office of Security and Law Enforcement. The Contractor, its employees, and its Subcontractors and their employees shall cooperate with VA and any law enforcement authority responsible for the investigation and prosecution of any possible criminal law violation(s) associated with any incident. The Contractor/Subcontractor shall cooperate with VA in any civil litigation to recover VA information, obtain monetary or other compensation from a third party for damages arising from any incident, or obtain injunctive relief against any third party arising from, or related to, the incident.
- f. The Contractor shall comply with VA Handbook 6500.2, Management of Breaches Involving Sensitive Personal Information, which establishes the breach management policies and assigns responsibilities for the oversight, management and reporting procedures associated with managing of breaches.
- g. With respect to unsecured Protected Health Information (PHI), the Contractor is deemed to have discovered a data breach when the Contractor knew or should have known of breach of such information. When a business associate is part of VHA contract, notification to the covered entity (VHA) shall be made in accordance with the executed BAA.
- h. If the Contractor or any of its agents fails to protect VA sensitive personal information or otherwise engages in conduct which results in a data breach involving any VA sensitive personal information the Contractor/Subcontractor processes or maintains under the contract; the Contractor shall pay liquidated damages to the VA as set forth in clause [852.211-76, Liquidated Damages—Reimbursement for Data Breach Costs.](#)

B6. INFORMATION SYSTEM DESIGN AND DEVELOPMENT

- a. Information systems designed or developed on behalf of VA at non-VA facilities shall comply with all applicable Federal law, regulations, and VA policies. This includes standards for the protection of electronic Protected Health Information (PHI), outlined in 45 C.F.R. Part 164, Subpart C and information and system security categorization level designations in accordance with FIPS 199,

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Standards for Security Categorization of Federal Information and Information Systems and FIPS 200, Minimum Security Requirements for Federal Information Systems. Baseline security controls shall be implemented commensurate with the FIPS 199 system security categorization (reference VA Handbook 6500 and VA Trusted Internet Connections (TIC) Architecture).

- b. Contracted new developments require creation, testing, evaluation, and authorization in compliance with VA Assessment and Authorization (A&A) processes in VA Handbook 6500 and VA Information Security Knowledge Service to obtain an Authority to Operate (ATO). VA Directive 6517, Risk Management Framework for Cloud Computing Services, provides the security and privacy requirements for cloud environments.
- c. VA IT Contractors, Subcontractors and third-party service providers shall address and/or integrate applicable VA Handbook 6500, VA Handbook 6517, Risk Management Framework for Cloud Computing Services and Information Security Knowledge Service specifications in delivered IT systems/solutions, products and/or services. If systems/solutions, products and/or services do not directly match VA security requirements, the Contractor shall work through the COR/CO to identify the VA organization responsible for governance or resolution. Contractors shall comply with FAR 39.1, specifically the prohibitions referenced.
- d. The Contractor (including producers and resellers) shall comply with Office of Management and Budget (OMB) M-26-05 when using third-party software on VA information systems or otherwise affecting the VA information. This includes new software purchases and software renewals for software developed or modified by major version change. The term "software" includes firmware, operating systems, applications and application services (e.g., cloud-based software), as well as products containing software. The Contractor shall provide a self-attestation that secure software development practices are utilized as outlined by Executive Order (EO) 14028 and NIST Guidance. A third-party assessment provided by either a certified Federal Risk and Authorization Management Program (FedRAMP) Third Party Assessor Organization (3PAO) or one approved by the agency will be acceptable in lieu of a software producer's self-attestation.
- e. The Contractor shall ensure all delivered applications, systems and information systems are compliant with Homeland Security Presidential Directive (HSPD) 12 and VA Identity and Access management (IAM) enterprise identity management requirements as set forth in OMB M-19-17, M-05-24, FIPS 201-3, Personal Identity Verification (PIV) of Federal Employees and Contractors (or its successor), M-21-31 and supporting NIST guidance. This applies to Commercial Off-The-Shelf (COTS) product(s) that the Contractor did not develop, all software configurations and all customizations.
- f. The Contractor shall ensure all Contractor delivered applications and systems provide user authentication services compliant with VA Handbook 6500, VA

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Information Security Knowledge Service, IAM enterprise requirements and NIST 800-63, Digital Identity Guidelines, for direct, assertion-based authentication and/or trust-based authentication, as determined by the design and integration patterns. Direct authentication at a minimum must include Public Key Infrastructure (PKI) based authentication supportive of PIV and/or Common Access Card (CAC), as determined by the business need and compliance with VA Information Security Knowledge Service specifications.

- g. The Contractor shall use VA authorized technical security baseline configurations and certify to the COR that applications are fully functional and operate correctly as intended on systems in compliance with VA baselines prior to acceptance or connection into an authorized VA computing environment. If the Defense Information Systems Agency (DISA) has created a Security Technical Implementation Guide (STIG) for the technology, the Contractor may configure to comply with that STIG. If VA determines a new or updated VA configuration baseline needs to be created, the Contractor shall provide required technical support to develop the configuration settings. FAR 39.1 requires the population of operating systems and applications includes all listed on the NIST National Checklist Program Checklist Repository,
- h. The standard installation, operation, maintenance, updating and patching of software shall not alter the configuration settings from VA approved baseline configuration. Software developed for VA must be compatible with VA enterprise installer services and install to the default "program files" directory with silently install and uninstall. The Contractor shall perform testing of all updates and patching prior to implementation on VA systems.
- i. Applications designed for normal end users will run in the standard user context without elevated system administration privileges.
- j. The Contractor-delivered solutions shall reside on VA approved operating systems. Exceptions to this will only be granted with the written approval of the COR/CO.
- k. The Contractor shall design, develop, and implement security and privacy controls in accordance with the provisions of VA security system development life cycle outlined in NIST 800-37, Risk Management Framework for Information Systems and Organizations: A System Life Cycle Approach for Security and Privacy, VA Directive and Handbook 6500, and VA Handbook 6517.
- l. The Contractor shall comply with the Privacy Act of 1974 (the Act), FAR 52.224-2 Privacy Act, and VA rules and regulations issued under the Act in the design, development, or operation of any system of records on individuals to accomplish a VA function.

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- m. The Contractor shall ensure the security of all procured or developed information systems, systems, major applications, minor applications, enclaves and platform information technologies, including their subcomponents (hereinafter referred to as "Information Systems") throughout the life of this contract and any extension, warranty, or maintenance periods. This includes security configurations, workarounds, patches, hotfixes, upgrades, replacements and any physical components which may be necessary to remediate all security vulnerabilities published or known to the Contractor anywhere in the information systems (including systems, operating systems, products, hardware, software, applications and firmware). The Contractor shall ensure security fixes do not negatively impact the Information Systems.
- n. When the Contractor is responsible for operations or maintenance of the systems, the Contractor shall apply the security fixes within the timeframe specified by the associated controls on the VA Information Security Knowledge Service. When security fixes involve installing third party patches (such as Microsoft OS patches or Adobe Acrobat), the Contractor shall provide written notice to the VA COR/CO that the patch has been validated as to not affecting the Systems within 10 business days.

B7. INFORMATION SYSTEM HOSTING, OPERATION, MAINTENANCE OR USE

- a. The Contractor shall comply with all Federal laws, regulations, and VA policies for Information systems (cloud and non-cloud) that are hosted, operated, maintained, or used on behalf of VA at non-VA facilities. Security controls for collecting, processing, transmitting, and storing of VA sensitive information, must be in place. The controls will be tested by VA or a VA sanctioned 3PAO and approved by VA prior to hosting, operation, maintenance or use of the information system or systems by or on behalf of VA. This includes conducting compliance risk assessments, security architecture analysis, routine vulnerability scanning, system patching, change management procedures and the completion of an acceptable contingency plan for each system. The Contractor's security control procedures shall be the same as procedures used to secure VA-operated information systems.
- b. Outsourcing (Contractor facility, equipment, or staff) of systems or network operations, telecommunications services or other managed services require Assessment and Authorization (A&A) of the Contractor's systems in accordance with VA Handbook 6500 as specified in VA Information Security Knowledge Service. Major changes to the A&A package may require reviewing and updating all the documentation associated with the change. The Contractor's cloud computing systems shall comply with FedRAMP and VA Directive 6517 requirements.
- c. The Contractor shall return all electronic storage media (hard drives, optical disks, CDs, back-up tapes, etc.) on non-VA leased or non-VA owned IT equipment used to store, process or access VA information to VA in accordance

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with A&A package requirements. This applies when the contract is terminated or completed and prior to disposal of media. The Contractor shall provide its plan for destruction of all VA data in its possession according to VA Information Security Knowledge Service requirements and NIST 800-88. The Contractor shall send a self-certification that the data destruction requirements above have been met to the COR/CO within 30 business days of termination of the contract.

- d. All external internet connections to VA network involving VA information must be in accordance with VA Trusted Internet Connection (TIC) Reference Architecture and VA Directive and Handbook 6513, Secure External Connections and reviewed and approved by VA prior to implementation. Government-owned Contractor-operated systems, third party or business partner networks require a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) and Interconnection Security Agreements (ISA).
- e. Contractor procedures shall be subject to periodic, announced, or unannounced assessments by VA officials, the OIG or a 3PAO. The physical security aspects associated with Contractor activities are also subject to such assessments. The Contractor shall report, in writing, any deficiencies noted during the above assessment to the VA COR/CO. The Contractor shall use VA's defined processes to document planned remedial actions that address identified deficiencies in information security policies, procedures, and practices. The Contractor shall correct security deficiencies within the timeframes specified in the VA Information Security Knowledge Service.
- f. All major information system changes which occur in the production environment shall be reviewed by the VA to determine the impact on privacy and security of the system. Based on the review results, updates to the Authority to Operate (ATO) documentation and parameters may be required to remain in compliance with VA Handbook 6500 and VA Information Security Knowledge Service requirements.
- g. The Contractor shall conduct an annual privacy and security self-assessment on all information systems and outsourced services as required. Copies of the assessment shall be provided to the COR/CO. The VA/Government reserves the right to conduct assessment using government personnel or a third-party if deemed necessary. The Contractor shall correct or mitigate any weaknesses discovered during the assessment.
- h. VA prohibits the installation and use of personally owned or Contractor-owned equipment or software on VA information systems. If non-VA owned equipment must be used to fulfill the requirements of a contract, it must be stated in the service agreement, SOW, PWS, PD or contract. All security controls required for government furnished equipment must be utilized in VA approved Other Equipment (OE). Configuration changes to the Contractor OE, must be funded by the owner of the equipment. All remote systems must use a VA-approved

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antivirus software and a personal (host-based or enclave based) firewall with a VA-approved configuration. The Contractor shall ensure software on OE is kept current with all critical updates and patches. Owners of approved OE are responsible for providing and maintaining the anti-virus software and the firewall on the non-VA owned OE. Approved Contractor OE will be subject to technical inspection at any time.

- i. The Contractor shall notify the COR/CO within one hour of disclosure or successful exploits of any vulnerability which can compromise the confidentiality, integrity, or availability of the information systems. The system or effected component(s) need(s) to be isolated from the network. A forensic analysis needs to be conducted jointly with VA. Such issues will be remediated as quickly as practicable, but in no event longer than the timeframe specified by VA Information Security Knowledge Service. If sensitive personal information is compromised reference VA Handbook 6500.2 and Section 5, Security Incident Investigation.
- j. For cases wherein the Contractor discovers material defects or vulnerabilities impacting products and services they provide to VA, the Contractor shall develop and implement policies and procedures for disclosure to VA, as well as remediation. The Contractor shall, within 30 business days of discovery, document a summary of these vulnerabilities or defects. The documentation will include a description of the potential impact of each vulnerability and material defect, compensating security controls, mitigations, recommended corrective actions, root cause analysis and/or workarounds (i.e., monitoring). Should there exist any backdoors in the products or services they provide to VA (referring to methods for bypassing computer authentication), the Contractor shall provide the VA CO/CO written assurance they have permanently remediated these backdoors.
- k. All other vulnerabilities, including those discovered through routine scans or other assessments, will be remediated based on risk, in accordance with the remediation timelines specified by the VA Information Security Knowledge Service and/or the applicable timeframe mandated by Cybersecurity & Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) Binding Operational Directive (BOD) 22-01 and BOD 19-02 for Internet-accessible systems. Exceptions to this paragraph will only be granted with the approval of the COR/CO.

B8. SECURITY AND PRIVACY CONTROLS COMPLIANCE TESTING, ASSESSMENT AND AUDITING

- a. Should VA request it, the Contractor shall provide a copy of their (corporation's, sole proprietorship's, partnership's, limited liability company (LLC), or other business structure entity's) policies, procedures, evidence and independent report summaries related to specified cybersecurity frameworks (International Organization for Standardization (ISO), NIST Cybersecurity Framework (CSF), etc.). VA or its third-party/partner designee (if applicable) are further entitled to

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perform their own audits and security/penetration tests of the Contractor's IT or systems and controls, to ascertain whether the Contractor is complying with the information security, network or system requirements mandated in the agreement between VA and the Contractor.

- b. Any audits or tests of the Contractor or third-party designees/partner VA elects to carry out will commence within 30 business days of VA notification. Such audits, tests and assessments may include the following: (a): security/penetration tests which both sides agree will not unduly impact Contractor operations; (b): interviews with pertinent stakeholders and practitioners; (c): document review; and (d): technical inspections of networks and systems the Contractor uses to destroy, maintain, receive, retain, or use VA information.
- c. As part of these audits, tests and assessments, the Contractor shall provide all information requested by VA. This information includes, but is not limited to, the following: equipment lists, network or infrastructure diagrams, relevant policy documents, system logs or details on information systems accessing, transporting, or processing VA data.
- d. The Contractor and at its own expense, shall comply with any recommendations resulting from VA audits, inspections and tests. VA further retains the right to view any related security reports the Contractor has generated as part of its own security assessment. The Contractor shall also notify VA of the existence of any such security reports or other related assessments, upon completion and validation.
- e. VA appointed auditors or other government agency partners may be granted access to such documentation on a need-to-know basis and coordinated through the COR/CO. The Contractor shall comply with recommendations which result from these regulatory assessments on the part of VA regulators and associated government agency partners.

B9. PRODUCT INTEGRITY, AUTHENTICITY, PROVENANCE, ANTI-COUNTERFEIT AND ANTI-TAMPERING

- a. The Contractor shall comply with Code of Federal Regulations (CFR) Title 15 Part 7, "Securing the Information and Communications Technology and Services (ICTS) Supply Chain", which prohibits ICTS Transactions from foreign adversaries. ICTS Transactions are defined as any acquisition, importation, transfer, installation, dealing in or use of any information and communications technology or service, including ongoing activities, such as managed services, data transmission, software updates, repairs or the platforming or data hosting of applications for consumer download.
- b. When contracting terms require the Contractor to procure equipment, the Contractor shall purchase or acquire the equipment from an Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) or an authorized reseller of the OEM. The Contractor shall

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attest that equipment procured from an OEM or authorized reseller or distributor are authentic. If procurement is unavailable from an OEM or authorized reseller, the Contractor shall submit in writing, details of the circumstances prohibiting this from happening and procure a product waiver from the VA COR/CO.

- c. All Contractors shall establish, implement, and provide documentation for risk management practices for supply chain delivery of hardware, software (to include patches) and firmware provided under this agreement. Documentation will include chain of custody practices, inventory management program, information protection practices, integrity management program for sub-supplier provided components, and replacement parts requests. The Contractor shall make spare parts available. All Contractor(s) shall specify how digital delivery for procured products, including patches, will be validated and monitored to ensure consistent delivery. The Contractor shall apply encryption technology to protect procured products throughout the delivery process.
- d. If a Contractor provides software or patches to VA, the Contractor shall publish or provide a hash conforming to the FIPS Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules (FIPS 140-2 or successor).
- e. The Contractor shall provide a software bill of materials (SBOM) for procured (to include licensed products) and consist of a list of components and associated metadata which make up the product. SBOMs must be generated in one of the data formats defined in the National Telecommunications and Information Administration (NTIA) report "The Minimum Elements for a Software Bill of Materials (SBOM)."
- f. Contractors shall use or arrange for the use of trusted channels to ship procured products, such as U.S. registered mail and/or tamper-evident packaging for physical deliveries.
- g. Throughout the delivery process, the Contractor shall demonstrate a capability for detecting unauthorized access (tampering).
- h. The Contractor shall demonstrate chain-of-custody documentation for procured products and require tamper-evident packaging for the delivery of this hardware.

B10. VIRUSES, FIRMWARE, AND MALWARE

- a. The Contractor shall execute due diligence to ensure all provided software and patches, including third-party patches, are free of viruses and/or malware before releasing them to or installing them on VA information systems.
- b. The Contractor warrants it has no knowledge of and did not insert, any malicious virus and/or malware code into any software or patches provided to VA which could potentially harm or disrupt VA information systems. The Contractor shall use due diligence, if supplying third-party software or patches, to ensure the

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third-party has not inserted any malicious code and/or virus which could damage or disrupt VA information systems.

- c. The Contractor shall provide or arrange for the provision of technical justification as to why any “false positive” hit has taken place to ensure their code’s supply chain has not been compromised. Justification may be required, but is not limited to, when install files, scripts, firmware, or other Contractor-delivered software solutions (including third-party install files, scripts, firmware, or other software) are flagged as malicious, infected, or suspicious by an anti-virus vendor.
- d. The Contractor shall not upload (intentionally or negligently) any virus, worm, malware or any harmful or malicious content, component and/or corrupted data/source code (hereinafter “virus or other malware”) onto VA computer and information systems and/or networks. If introduced (and this clause is violated), upon written request from the VA CO, the Contractor shall:
 - (1) Take all necessary action to correct the incident, to include any and all assistance to VA to eliminate the virus or other malware throughout VA’s information networks, computer systems and information systems; and
 - (2) Use commercially reasonable efforts to restore operational efficiency and remediate damages due to data loss or data integrity damage, if the virus or other malware causes a loss of operational efficiency, data loss, or damage to data integrity.

B11. CRYPTOGRAPHIC REQUIREMENT

- a. The Contractor shall document how the cryptographic system supporting the Contractor’s products and/or services protect the confidentiality, data integrity, authentication and non-repudiation of devices and data flows in the underlying system.
- b. The Contractor shall use only approved cryptographic methods as defined in FIPS 140-2 (or its successor) and NIST 800-52 standards when enabling encryption on its products.
- c. The Contractor shall provide or arrange for the provision of an automated remote key-establishment method which protects the confidentiality and integrity of the cryptographic keys.
- d. The Contractor shall ensure emergency re-keying of all devices can be remotely performed within 30 business days.
- e. The Contractor shall provide or arrange for the provision of a method for updating cryptographic primitives or algorithms.

B12. PATCHING GOVERNANCE

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- a. The Contractor shall provide documentation detailing the patch management, vulnerability management, mitigation and update processes (to include third-party) prior to the connection of electronic devices, assets or equipment to VA's assets. This documentation will include information regarding the following:
 - (1) The resources and technical capabilities to sustain the program or process (e.g., how the integrity of a patch is validated by VA); and.
 - (2) The approach and capability to remediate newly reported zero-day vulnerabilities for Contractor products.
- b. The Contractor shall verify and provide documentation all procured products (including third-party applications, hardware, software, operating systems, and firmware) have appropriate updates and patches installed prior to delivery to VA.
- c. The Contractor shall provide or arrange the provision of appropriate software and firmware updates to remediate newly discovered vulnerabilities or weaknesses for their products and services within 30 days of discovery. Updates to remediate critical or emergent vulnerabilities will be provided within seven business days of discovery. If updates cannot be made available by Contractor within these time periods, the Contractor shall submit mitigations, methods of exploit detection and/or workarounds to the COR/CO prior to the above deadlines.
- d. The Contractor shall provide or arrange for the provision of appropriate hardware, software and/or firmware updates, when those products, including open-source software, are provided to the VA, to remediate newly discovered vulnerabilities or weaknesses. Remediations of products or services provided to the VA's system environment must be provided within 30 business days of availability from the original supplier and/or patching source. Updates to remediate critical vulnerabilities applicable to the Contractor's use of the third-party product in its system environment will be provided within seven business days of availability from the original supplier and/or patching source. If applicable third-party updates cannot be integrated, tested and made available by Contractor within these time periods, mitigations and/or workarounds will be provided to the COR/CO before the above deadlines.

B13. SPECIALIZED DEVICES/SYSTEMS (MEDICAL DEVICES, SPECIAL PURPOSE SYSTEMS, RESEARCH SCIENTIFIC COMPUTING)

- a. Contractor supplies/delivered Medical Devices, Special Purpose Systems-Operational Technology (SPS-OT) and Research Scientific Computing Devices shall comply with all applicable Federal law, regulations, and VA policies. New developments require creation, testing, evaluation, and authorization in compliance with processes specified on the Specialized Device Cybersecurity Department Enterprise Risk Management (SDCD-ERM) Portal, VA Directive 6550, Pre-Procurement Assessment and Implementation of Medical Devices/Systems, VA Handbook 6500, and the VA Information Security

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Knowledge Service. Deviations from Federal law, regulations, and VA Policy are identified and documented as part of VA Directive 6550 and/or the VA Enterprise Risk Analysis (ERA) processes for Specialized Devices/Systems processes.

- b. All Contractors and third-party service providers shall address and/or integrate applicable VA Handbook 6500 and Information Security Knowledge Service specifications in delivered IT systems/solutions, products and/or services. If systems/solutions, products and/or services do not directly match VA security requirements, the Contractor shall work through the COR/CO for governance or resolution.
- c. The Contractor shall certify to the COR/CO that devices/systems that have completed the VA Enterprise Risk Analysis (ERA) process for Specialized Devices/Systems are fully functional and operate correctly as intended. Devices/systems must follow the VA ERA authorized configuration prior to acquisition and connection to the VA computing environment. If VA determines a new VA ERA needs to be created, the Contractor shall provide required technical support to develop the configuration settings. Major changes to a previously approved device/system will require a new ERA.
- d. The Contractor shall comply with all practices documented by the Food Drug and Administration (FDA) Premarket Submission for Management of Cybersecurity in Medical Devices and Postmarket Management of Cybersecurity in Medical Devices.
- e. The Contractor shall design devices capable of accepting all applicable security patches with or without the support of the Contractor personnel. If patching can only be completed by the Contractor, the Contractor shall commit the resources needed to patch all applicable devices at all VA locations. If unique patching instructions or packaging is needed, the Contractor shall provide the necessary information in conjunction with the validation/testing of the patch. The Contractor shall apply security patches within 30 business days of the patch release and have a formal tracking process for any security patches not implemented to include explanation when a device cannot be patched.
- f. The Contractor shall provide devices able to install and maintain VA-approved antivirus capabilities with the capability to quarantine files and be updated as needed in response to incidents. Alternatively, a VA-approved whitelisting application may be used when the Contractor cannot install an anti-virus / anti-malware application.
- g. The Contractor shall verify and document all software embedded within the device does not contain any known viruses or malware before delivery to or installation at a VA location.

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- h. Devices and other equipment or systems containing media (hard drives, optical disks, solid state, and storage via chips/firmware) with VA sensitive information will be returned to the Contractor with media removed. When the contract requires return of equipment, the options available to the Contractor are the following:
- (1) The Contractor shall accept the system without the drive, firmware and solid state.
 - (2) VA's initial device purchase includes a spare drive or other replacement media which must be installed in place of the original drive at time of turn-in; or
 - (3) Due to the highly specialized and sometimes proprietary hardware and software associated with the device, if it is not possible for VA to retain the hard drive, firmware, and solid state, then:
 - (a) The equipment Contractor shall have an existing BAA if the device being traded in has sensitive information stored on it and hard drive(s) from the system are being returned physically intact.
 - (b) Any fixed hard drive, Complementary Metal-Oxide-Semiconductor (CMOS), Programmable Read-Only Memory (PROM), solid state and firmware on the device must be non-destructively sanitized to the greatest extent possible without negatively impacting system operation. Selective clearing down to patient data folder level is recommended using VA approved and validated overwriting technologies/methods/tools. Applicable media sanitization specifications need to be pre-approved and described in the solicitation, contract, or order.

B14. DATA CENTER PROVISIONS

- a. The Contractor shall ensure the VA network is accessed by in accordance with VA Directive 6500 and IAM security processes specified in the VA Information Security Knowledge Service.
- b. The Contractor shall ensure network infrastructure and data availability in accordance with VA information system business continuity procedures specified in the VA Information Security Knowledge Service.
- c. The Contractor shall ensure any connections to the internet or other external networks for information systems occur through managed interfaces utilizing VA approved boundary protection devices (e.g., internet proxies, gateways, routers, firewalls, guards or encrypted tunnels).

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- d. The Contractor shall encrypt all traffic across the segment of the Wide Area Network (WAN) it manages and no unencrypted Out of Band (OOB) Internet Protocol (IP) traffic will traverse the network.
- e. The Contractor shall ensure tunnel endpoints are routable addresses at each VA operating site.
- f. The Contractor shall secure access from Local Area Networks (LANs) at co-located sites in accordance with VA TIC Reference Architecture, VA Directive and Handbook 6513, and MOU/ISA process specified in the VA Information Security Knowledge Service.

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ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Offerors shall, if Artificial Intelligence (AI) is part of the Contractor system/solution, provide the below self-certification with their quote/proposal affirming that the identified/proposed AI System/LLM complies with the two Unbiased AI Principles, Truth-seeking and Ideological Neutrality, as required by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Memorandum M-26-04, "Increasing Public Trust in Artificial Intelligence Through Unbiased AI Principles", or indicate otherwise that a self-certification is Not Applicable. Additionally, Offerors shall self-certify that the content requested within the AI System/LLM Development and Operation Documentation Package, as identified in OMB Memorandum M-26-04 as Transparency Documentation, will be provided for its proposed AI System/LLM during the period of performance, meet the required transparency threshold and align with the two Unbiased AI Principles. Failure to include the requisite Offeror's self-certification may render the Offeror's proposal/quotation unacceptable, and therefore ineligible for award. The Government will rely on the Offeror's self-certification that its proposed AI System/LLM adheres to the Unbiased AI Principles and related requirements. VA reserves the right to request additional information if it determines that doing so is in the Government's best interest.

Certification:

- ☐ Not Applicable.
- ☐ I hereby certify that the proposed AI System/LLM complies with the required Unbiased AI Principles as identified in OMB Memorandum M-26-04 and can also meet the required AI System/LLM Development and Operation Documentation requirements specified therein. I further certify that I am authorized to execute this certification on behalf of *<insert name of Offeror>*.

Printed Name of Signee: _____

Printed Title of Signee: _____

Signature: _____

Name (and version) of its proposed AI System/LLM: _____

Date: _____

Company Name and Address: _____

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Artificial Intelligence in VA Contracts

For purposes of this clause, AI is defined as set forth by VA and Section 238(g) of the National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 2019 to include:

1. Any artificial system that performs tasks under varying and unpredictable circumstances without significant human oversight, or that can learn from experience and improve performance when exposed to data sets.
2. An artificial system developed in computer software, physical hardware, or other context that solves tasks requiring human-like perception, cognition, planning, learning, communication, or physical action.
3. An artificial system designed to think or act like a human, including cognitive architectures and neural networks.
4. A set of techniques, including machine learning (ML), that is designed to approximate a cognitive task.
5. An artificial system designed to act rationally, including an intelligent software agent or embodied robot that achieves goals using perception, planning, reasoning, learning, communicating, decision making, and acting.

The Contractor shall provide a list of all AI it will be proposing, creating, delivering, and/or using as part of contract performance, for VA approval. The list of AI shall be provided directly to the VA PM, COR, and CO at least annually but also at the following times: upon proposal submission, contract award, the COR's request, and upon the Contractor's proposed use of new AI tools not contemplated at the time of last reporting. AI shall not be used in performance of the contract without the written approval and authorization of the CO. The Contractor shall also report all AI intended for use in contract performance for VA's inclusion in the VA AI Use Case Inventory. The Contractor shall actively engage in AI discovery, assessment, and compliance activities undertaken by VA.

Once the Contractor has obtained CO authorization to use specific AI in contract performance, the Contractor shall provide the COR a signed Statement of Attestation prior to AI implementation. All AI for delivery and/or use in performance of the contract shall adhere to the *VA Trustworthy AI Framework*, available at <https://department.va.gov/ai/trustworthy/>. The Statement of Attestation shall include, but is not limited to, a description of all controls, processes, technologies, and mechanisms utilized to satisfy VA's six (6) AI Principles: Purposeful, Effective and Safe, Secure and Private, Fair and Equitable, Transparent and Explainable, and Accountable and Monitored. The Statement of Attestation shall also certify that the Contractor owns or possesses all legally required rights, copyright, and licenses to use the specified AI. The Statement of Attestation shall clearly state that the use of the AI by VA personnel in performance of the contract:

1. Does not and will not infringe upon any intellectual property rights of any kind.
2. Does not violate any intellectual property rights of any kind.
3. Does not violate any other third-party rights of any kind.

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The Statement of Attestation shall also affirm that there have not been any persisting or existing material errors, defects, failures, or interruptions in AI performance of its intended purpose. Additionally, the Statement of Attestation shall include the Contractor's endorsement that the AI has materially performed in accordance with its specifications and intended purpose. Lastly, the Statement of Attestation shall be updated and resubmitted, at a minimum, annually, prior to the exercise of any contract option periods. The Statement of Attestation shall be deemed separate from, and in addition to, the Contractor's reporting requirements relative to the use of AI. The Statement of Attestation is a material term of the contract; accordingly, failure to provide the Statement of Attestation, to include all requirements, may be deemed a breach of contract and thus, cause for termination.

Data Ownership and Use. VA data ("Data") shall include data collected, used, processed, stored, or generated as the result of the use of AI. VA data is and shall remain the sole and exclusive property of VA. Contractor is provided a limited, non-exclusive license to access and use Data solely for performing its obligations under the Contract. The Contractor shall: (a) keep and maintain VA data in strict confidence and as further described in this Contract and applicable law to avoid unauthorized access, use, disclosure, or loss; (b) not use, sell, rent, transfer, distribute, or otherwise disclose or make available VA Data for Contractor's own purposes or for the benefit of anyone other than VA without the CO's prior written consent; and (c) not store, use, and transmit VA Data outside of the United States. This applies to both identified and de-identified data.

The Contractor (or Subcontractor at any tier, including affiliates, third-party affiliates, and any other non-VA entities) shall not sell, monetize, release, share, reuse, transfer, or misuse any VA data, to include any models, training data, testing data, patterns, documentation, implementation artifacts, runtime artifacts, or any other digital artifacts, partially or as a whole, derived from AI or machine learning (ML) without the express written consent and approval from the CO.

The Contractor is prohibited from using non-public VA data, including Veteran data, and outputted results to train publicly or commercially available AI algorithms, fine-tune, or otherwise develop AI or ML models for reuse, transfer, or commercial purposes, without the express written authorization from the CO specifying VA data that may be used along with the acceptable scope of such usage. Contractor agrees that any AI models, weights, or derivative artifacts trained, or fine-tuned, on VA non-public data, if authorized by VA, may not be commercialized or used for the benefit of any third party without prior written approval by the CO and must be conducted within a VA authorized environment that has obtained an Authority to Operate

The Contractor shall indemnify VA and its officers, employees, and agents against liability, including costs, for actual or alleged direct or contributory infringement of, or inducement to infringe, any United States or foreign patent, trademark, or copyright, arising out of VA use of any AI products and/or services under the contract.

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The Contractor shall maintain commercially reasonable insurance coverage for claims or losses pertaining to the AI products or services being used in performance of the contract.

The Contractor shall maintain commercially reasonable and industry standard conforming security safeguards and controls, including proper access controls for the AI. The Contractor agrees the VA Contracting Officer has the unilateral right to require deactivation of any AI for any reason and without notice.

Any development and/or creation of AI, including any AI derivatives, during performance of this contract, is subject to applicable Intellectual Property and data rights clauses under the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) including, FAR 52.227-14. The VA retains the unlimited right to reuse, share, and/or redeploy AI code and AI models procured under this contract. License rights in any Commercial Computer Software shall be governed by this contract.

This clause applies to both existing and new uses of AI, both stand-alone AI and AI embedded within other systems or applications, AI developed both by VA or by third parties on behalf of agencies for the fulfillment of specific VA missions, including relevant data inputs used to train AI and outputs used in support of decision making, and VA procurement of AI applications.

This clause does not apply to AI embedded within common commercial products, such as word processors or map navigation systems. The Contractor shall inform the VA Contracting Officer in writing if it believes the AI it intends to use during contract performance is not covered by this clause. The burden to demonstrate the AI is a common commercial product shall rest solely with the Contractor.

Non-compliance with the terms above, or loss of sensitive VA medical records information resulting from AI use (whether accidental or intentional), may result in Contractor liability to VA for any and all rights and remedies provided by law, including but not limited to contract termination, liquidated damages, and referral to VA's Suspension and Debarment Committee.

The Contractor shall include the substance of this clause in all subcontracts, including Subcontractors at any tier, affiliates, third-party affiliates, and any other non-VA entities.
